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PRODUCT DOSSIER · PAYMENTS

Free money movement, paid everything else

UPI made payments free and instant. That forced every payments company in India to find its profits somewhere else. Here is where each one is looking.

It is 7:40 a.m. outside a tea stall in Koramangala. A student scans a QR code, types a four-digit PIN, and before she has picked up her cup a small speaker on the counter says, in Kannada, "Twenty rupees received on PhonePe." The owner does not look at his phone. He trusts the box.

That scene happens about **79 crore times a day**. In August 2026 India made **24.51 billion UPI payments worth ₹29.82 lakh crore**. The average payment was just ₹1,217 (NPCI data, via MediaNama, Sep 2026). Payments now come in small amounts, many times a day, by habit, and they cost the user nothing.

The teardown checklist used in every dossier

Every dossier in Part II follows these ten questions (adapted from HelloPM, LogRocket and Lenny Rachitsky's product-sense guide). Use them to take apart any product in an interview.

1. User and job Who hires this product, and for which job? What did they use before?	2. Positioning The one-line promise, and who it is NOT for.	3. Core loop The action users repeat, and what brings them back.	4. First run What happens in the first five minutes. Where do new users drop?	5. Key features For each feature: the problem, the design choice, the metric it moves.
6. Business model Who pays, for what, and what is left per order or user.	7. Growth loops How one user or order brings the next one in.	8. Moat Why a copycat with money still loses: Helmer's 7 Powers.	9. Metrics North Star, three or four input metrics, and guardrails.	10. Build next Two or three bets: the user problem, the idea, the metric.

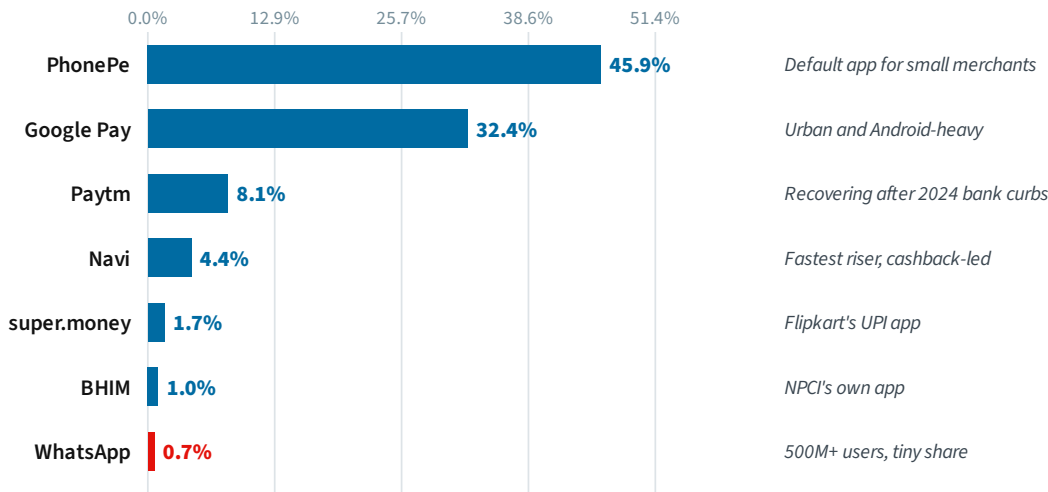
The job, and the market

Users hire a payments app for one job: **move money right now, without worrying that it will fail or get stolen**. Merchants hire a payments company for a different job: **get paid by every customer, see the money in the bank, and know which payment was which**. The best products in this dossier serve one side very well and then use that position to sell something else.

Since 2020, UPI payments to merchants have carried **zero MDR**. MDR, the merchant discount rate, is the fee a shop pays on each digital payment. With UPI it is zero, so the app that processes your ₹20 chai payment earns nothing from it. That single rule shapes every strategy below. Payments became the free way in, and the profit has to come from loans, insurance, investing, merchant devices, card payments, or software.

Who processes India's UPI payments

Share of UPI transaction volume by app, August 2026 (%)

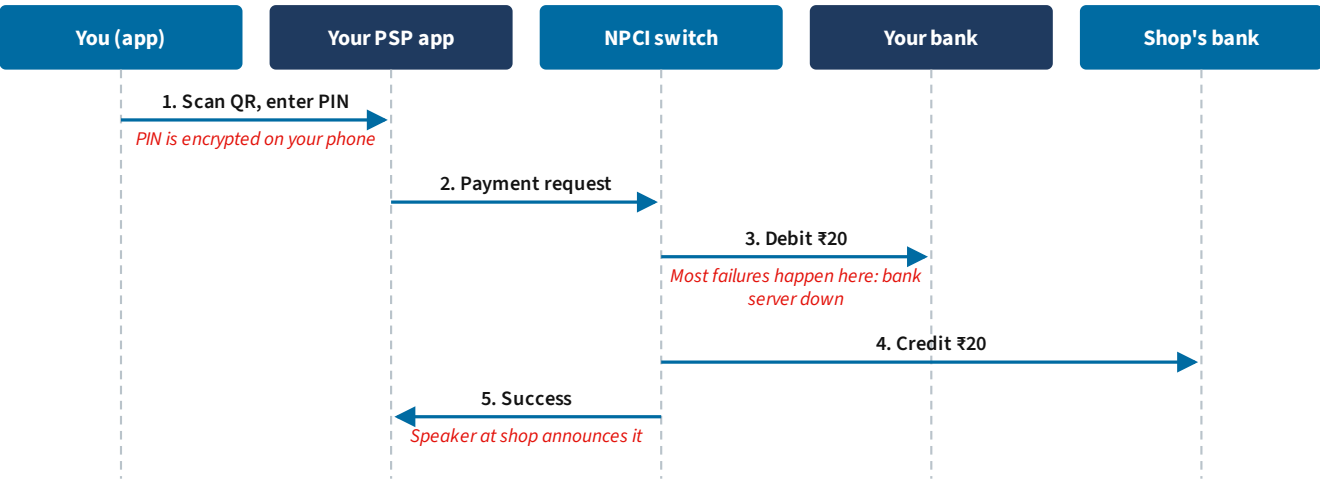


Source: NPCI data via Inc42 (Sep 2026); WhatsApp figure is May 2026 (NPCI via Trak.in)

Two apps handle almost four in every five payments. NPCI has proposed a **30% cap on any one app's share**, but it has pushed the deadline back twice. The deadline now stands at 31 December 2026. If the cap is enforced, PhonePe and Google Pay would have to turn users away, which no product team would plan for. That is why every interviewer loves asking about it.

What happens in the two seconds after you tap Pay

A UPI payment from a PhonePe user to a shop that banks with HDFC



Source: NPCI UPI architecture; simplified

The payment app does not hold your money. It is only the front door, a **PSP (payment service provider) app**, while banks move the money and NPCI connects them. So apps compete on what you can see: speed to "Paid", failure rate, safety, and what else they sell you afterwards.

PAYMENTS · RAZORPAY

The payment company built for developers

Razorpay won online checkout by being easy to plug in. Its next problem: UPI pays it nothing, so it has to sell businesses everything else.

Who it is for. Any business that takes money online, from a two-person D2C brand on Shopify to Zomato and Swiggy. The first user is not the founder but the **developer**. Razorpay's early growth came from clean documentation, a test mode that works in minutes, and plug-ins for every common platform. Positioning: *"one integration for every way Indians pay, and then banking, payroll and credit for the same business."* It is not built for the kirana store that only needs a QR code.

Core loop. A merchant integrates → customers pay → Razorpay learns which bank, card and UPI route succeeds at what time → success rates rise → the merchant earns more and tells other founders → more merchants join. More payments lead to better routing data, which leads to a higher success rate. That data advantage grows with scale.

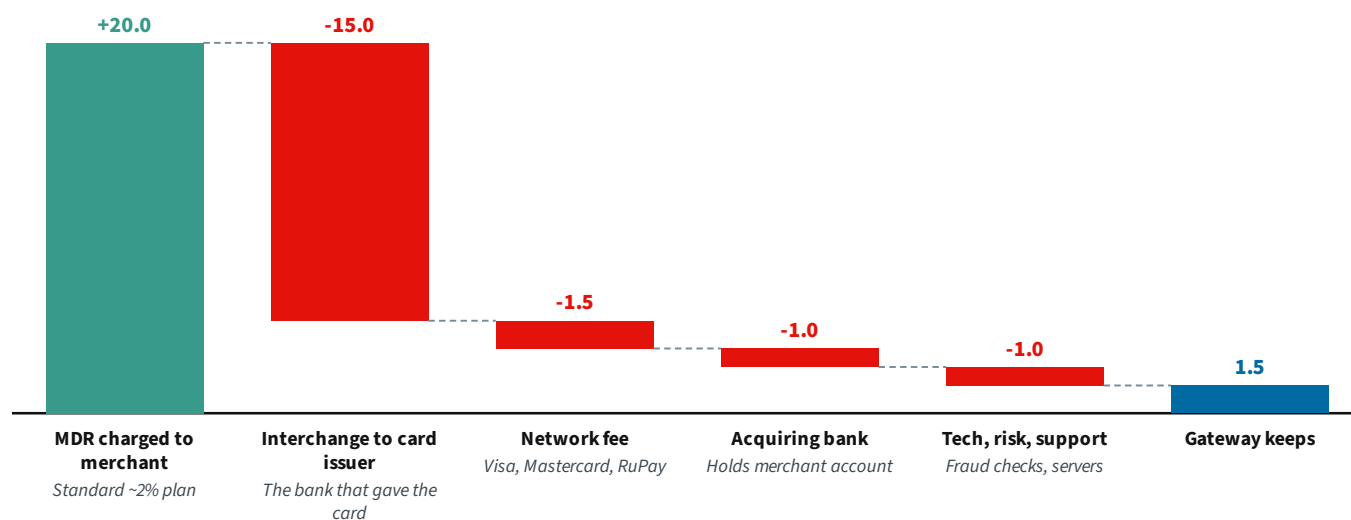
First run. Sign up with an email, get test API keys straight away, and make a dummy payment within minutes. KYC (identity checks on the business) happens afterwards, before real money flows. Letting developers build first and complete paperwork later is a deliberate choice. The drop-off point is **activation**: merchants who start KYC but never go live. That is the funnel Razorpay's onboarding teams watch.

Feature	User problem it solves	Why it is designed this way	Metric it moves
Payment Gateway	"I need cards, UPI, netbanking, wallets, EMI"	One API and one dashboard hide 100+ bank integrations	Merchant activation, GMV
Optimizer (smart routing)	"A failed payment is a lost sale"	Routes each payment to the gateway or bank most likely to succeed right now	Payment success rate
Magic Checkout	"Shoppers abandon when typing addresses"	Pre-fills address and payment details across Razorpay's shopper network; scores COD risk	Checkout conversion, RTO (return-to-origin) rate
Payment Links and Pages	"I sell on Instagram and have no website"	A link that works in any chat	New small merchants
Subscriptions / UPI Autopay	"Collecting monthly fees is manual"	Mandates set up once, charged automatically	Recurring GMV, churn
RazorpayX, Payroll, POS	"My money, salaries and store sales are in five tools"	Sells into the same dashboard the merchant already opens daily	Products per merchant
Agentic Payments (2026)	"An AI assistant can find food but cannot pay for it"	Built on UPI Reserve Pay: user pre-approves a limit once; agent pays within it	New commerce surface

Business model and unit economics. Razorpay's FY25 revenue was **₹3,783 Cr (+65%)**, with a net loss of ₹1,209 Cr driven by one-time ESOP and "reverse flip" costs from moving its holding company back to India (company filings via the press). It handles about **\$180 billion of annualised payments** for over 12 million businesses and has roughly **55% of India's online gateway market** (industry estimates, 2026). On a card payment Razorpay keeps only a thin slice of the fee. On a UPI payment it keeps nothing at all.

What a gateway keeps from a ₹1,000 credit-card payment

₹ per payment, illustrative; actual rates vary by card type and merchant size



On a ₹1,000 UPI payment the same waterfall starts at zero. That is why RazorpayX, payroll and lending matter.

Source: Illustrative, based on standard ~2% MDR plans and typical interchange ranges

Growth loops. Developer word of mouth (engineers carry Razorpay to their next start-up); a shopper network (each Magic Checkout purchase makes the next Razorpay merchant's checkout faster); and cross-sell (a merchant settling money with Razorpay is easy to sell a current account or loan).

Moat, in plain words. Switching costs are the biggest one. Changing a payment gateway means rewriting code, re-testing refunds, and rebuilding reconciliation, the daily matching of payments to orders. Scale economies come next: more volume gives better routing data, which gives higher success rates. Finally, process power: years of work on bank downtime, fraud rules and settlements that a newcomer cannot copy quickly. The weakness is that for plain UPI, a gateway is close to a commodity.

Metrics. *North Star:* successful payment volume processed (₹ TPV that actually succeeded). *Inputs:* active merchants, payment success rate, checkout conversion on Magic Checkout, products per merchant. *Guardrails:* fraud and chargeback rate, downtime minutes, settlement delay.

2025–26 moves. Razorpay received the RBI licence for cross-border payments (PA-CB) in January 2026. In February 2026, at the India AI Impact Summit, it launched **Agentic Payments with NPCI on Anthropic's Claude**, with Zomato, Swiggy and Zepto as early merchants. It filed confidentially for an IPO in June 2026. It also pushes offline with POS and into lending, because online UPI earns it nothing.

Strengths: developer trust, high success rates, product range. **Weaknesses:** thin core margins, RBI dependence, and strong rivals (Cashfree, PayU, Juspay) in every line.

What I would build next at Razorpay

- Agent-ready checkout.** *Problem:* AI agents cannot read most checkout pages. *Bet:* a "merchant agent kit" that publishes catalogue, prices and payment limits in a form assistants can use, with Reserve Pay mandates built in. *Metric:* GMV through agent-initiated payments; mandate approval rate.
- Cash-flow forecast for small merchants.** *Problem:* D2C founders do not know if they can pay next month's salaries. *Bet:* use settlement data to predict cash 30 days ahead and offer a credit line before the gap appears. *Metric:* loan book per active merchant, 90-day repayment rate.
- RTO shield as a service.** *Problem:* cash-on-delivery returns eat 20–30% of some brands' orders (illustrative). *Bet:* sell the COD risk score from Magic Checkout to merchants who do not use Razorpay checkout. *Metric:* RTO rate for paying merchants; attach revenue from merchants who do not use Razorpay for payments, and the share of COD orders that the score flags correctly.

PAYMENTS • PHONEPE

The default app of Bharat

PhonePe won UPI by making the scan-and-pay moment fast everywhere. Now it has to earn money from users it trained to expect free payments.

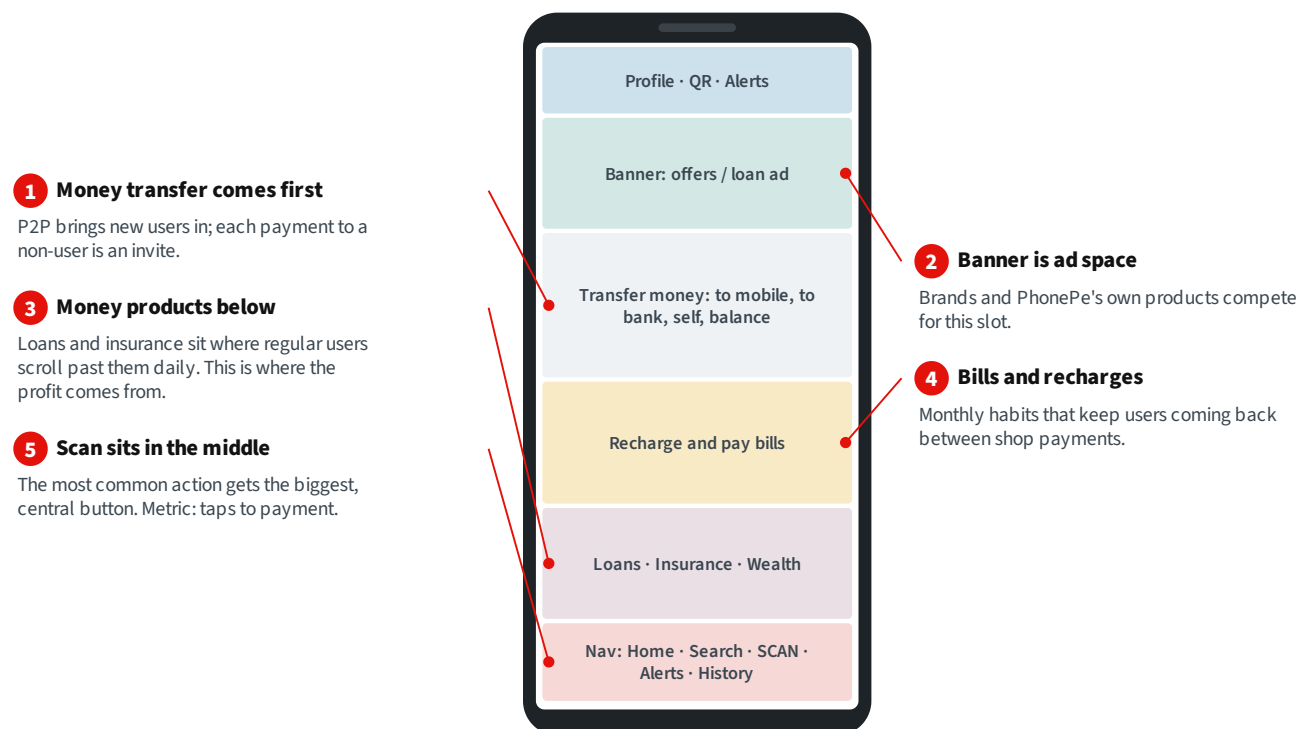
Who it is for. Everyone, and especially the small-town and small-merchant India that Google Pay reached later. PhonePe has over **60 crore registered users** (company, 2025). Positioning: *"the app that works at every shop."* The product feels like a utility: large buttons, a clear Scan button, and vernacular support.

Core loop. Scan a QR → pay in seconds → the shop's speaker confirms it → the user trusts the habit → the user pays again tomorrow. On the merchant side: more PhonePe users at the counter → shopkeepers display PhonePe QR codes and speakers → customers see PhonePe everywhere → they install PhonePe. UPI is **interoperable**: any app can pay any QR code. So PhonePe's network effect comes from habit and brand visibility, not from a technical lock-in. That makes it weaker than it looks.

First run. You enter your mobile number, the app verifies the SIM with an SMS, finds your bank accounts linked to that number, and asks you to set a UPI PIN using your debit card. The riskiest step is the PIN set-up. Users without a debit card at hand drop off, which is why Aadhaar-OTP PIN set-up matters for first-time users.

PhonePe home screen, annotated

Everything is arranged around getting to Pay in one tap



Feature	User problem	Design choice	Metric
Scan & Pay	"I need to pay in the queue, fast"	Opens straight to the camera; remembers recent merchants	Time to pay, success rate
SmartSpeaker (sound box)	Shopkeeper: "Did the money actually arrive?"	Speaks every payment aloud in local languages; stops fake-screenshot fraud	Merchant retention, device rental revenue
UPI Lite	"Small payments fail when the bank is slow"	Small on-device balance, no PIN for low amounts	Failure rate on sub-₹500 payments
RuPay credit card on UPI	"I want credit-card rewards at a QR shop"	Links a credit card to UPI	Revenue: MDR applies on larger merchants
Lending, insurance, Share.Market	"I need a loan or cover, quickly"	Distributes partner products to a user base that already trusts the app	Revenue per MTU

Business model. FY26 revenue was ₹7,920 Cr (+11%) and the loss widened to ₹2,792 Cr (company filings, 2026). Growth has slowed sharply: 74% → 40% → 11% across three years. The profitable engines are small but growing fast: lending distribution earned ₹945 Cr (more than double), insurance ₹191 Cr, and broking ₹108 Cr. PhonePe deferred a planned \$1.3 billion IPO in March 2026. Its Pincode shopping app was pivoted to serve businesses (B2B) after failing in consumer commerce. It also runs **Indus Appstore**, an Android app store, as a longer-term bet.

Moat. Brand and habit (branding power), plus the physical network of speakers and QR stickers at millions of shops (a cornered resource that takes years to build). Switching costs for users are close to zero. That explains why a 30% share cap would be so damaging: nothing technical stops users from moving.

Metrics. *North Star:* monthly transacting users (MTU). *Inputs:* payments per MTU, payment success rate, active merchant devices, cross-sell rate into lending or insurance. *Guardrails:* fraud losses, complaint resolution time, and share of UPI volume, which must stay under any cap.

Strengths: reach, reliability, merchant presence. **Weaknesses:** revenue grows much slower than usage, losses are rising, the 30% cap threat, and it depends on partner banks and NBFCs for every money product.

What I would build next at PhonePe

1. **Scam shield for first-time users.** *Problem:* older and first-time users are the main targets of "collect request" and fake-refund scams. *Bet:* on-device warnings in the local language when a payment matches scam patterns, plus a "check with family" hold through UPI Circle. *Metric:* fraud reports per lakh transactions; payment completion rate, a guardrail so warnings do not block genuine payments.
2. **Speaker-data credit for shopkeepers.** *Problem:* kirana owners cannot get working capital. *Bet:* use daily speaker-confirmed inflows to offer daily-repayment loans. *Metric:* disbursements per active device; repayment rate.
3. **Share-cap-proof loyalty.** *Problem:* if the cap bites, PhonePe must keep its best users while turning others away. *Bet:* a membership tier with insurance, credit and bill-pay benefits for heavy users. *Metric:* revenue per MTU, retention of the top 10% of users.

PAYMENTS • GOOGLE PAY

Google-grade trust, Google-scale indifference to revenue

Google Pay proved that a clean design and scratch cards could win urban India. It then had to decide what India payments were for.

Who it is for. Urban, smartphone-first users, mostly on Android, who value a clean interface and trust the Google brand with money. Positioning: "simple, secure payments from the company you already trust."

Core loop. Pay a friend → the conversation-style history shows every payment with that person → you pay them again from the same thread. In 2018–20 the loop was powered by **scratch cards**: each payment could win cashback, which turned payments into a small game. Those rewards have mostly gone. The habit has stayed, which tells you they did their job of forming the habit.

Key features.

- **Chat-style payment threads.** Payments with each person look like a messaging thread. This makes splitting costs and paying back feel social. Metric: repeat P2P payments.
- **UPI Circle (2024).** A primary user lets a trusted secondary user, such as a parent or college student, pay from their account, either with each payment approved or up to a monthly limit. It brings in users who have no bank app. Metric: new users activated via Circle.
- **Bill payments and ClickPay QR.** Scan a QR printed on a utility bill to pay it without typing account numbers. Since 2025 Google Pay has charged a small convenience fee on credit-card bill payments, one of its few direct fees.
- **Tap to pay and UPI Lite**, and in 2026 **biometric authentication** (fingerprint or face instead of a PIN) for UPI payments, which NPCI now allows.
- **Loans and gold from partners**, shown to users with good payment histories.

Business model. Google does not report Google Pay India's revenue. Its value is mainly strategic: it keeps Android the best way to use UPI and builds a trusted money relationship that Google can extend to loans and merchant services. Direct revenue comes from loan and card distribution, convenience fees and merchant services.

Moat. Brand trust and Android distribution, since the app comes preinstalled or one tap away. It is weaker at small merchants, where PhonePe's and Paytm's speakers dominate.

Metrics. *North Star:* monthly transacting users. *Inputs:* P2P payments per user, merchant payments per user, UPI Circle activations, loan applications from eligible users. *Guardrails:* fraud rate, failure rate, share cap.

What I would build next at Google Pay

1. **Gemini "explain this payment request."** *Problem:* users approve collect requests they do not understand. *Bet:* one tap shows in plain language who is asking, why, and whether it looks like a known scam pattern. *Metric:* scam losses per lakh users.
2. **Shared household ledger.** *Problem:* families track rent, maids, milk and school fees in their heads. *Bet:* a shared view built on UPI Circle that tags recurring household payments. *Metric:* households with 2+ active members; recurring payments made.

PAYMENTS · PAYTM

From super-app to merchant machine

Paytm lost its bank, most of its consumer share and its valuation in 2024. It came back by doubling down on the shopkeeper.

Who it is for today. Small and mid-sized merchants first, then consumers. Paytm serves **1.57 crore storefronts with Soundbox devices** and has **8 crore monthly transacting users** (Paytm Q1 FY27 earnings release, Jul 2026). Positioning: *"everything a shopkeeper needs to get paid, get credit, and grow."*

What happened. In January 2024 the RBI stopped Paytm Payments Bank from taking new deposits over compliance failures, and consumer UPI users left for PhonePe and Google Pay. The licence was cancelled in April 2026. Paytm now runs UPI as a **TPAP** (third-party app provider) on Axis, HDFC, SBI and Yes Bank rails, like its rivals.

Core loop. A merchant rents a Soundbox → every payment is announced → the merchant keeps Paytm QR at the counter → Paytm sees daily cash flows → it can offer the merchant a loan through a partner lender → the merchant stays loyal. The device is the anchor, and it turns free payments into data and a monthly fee.

Around the Soundbox, Paytm sells card machines for customers who still pay by card, **merchant loans** from partner lenders (offered from payment history), Paytm Postpaid and wealth products for regular users, and an AI-led travel booking flow that it says converts 7–8 times better than its old app screens.

Business model and results. FY26 was Paytm's **first full-year profit: ₹552 Cr on ₹8,437 Cr revenue**, with ₹13,315 Cr of cash on hand. In Q1 FY27 revenue rose 28% to ₹2,448 Cr, profit after tax was ₹220 Cr and merchant GMV reached ₹7.1 lakh crore (company release). Paytm now puts all new investment into AI.

Moat. A physical merchant network, merchant-credit data, and a brand among shopkeepers that survived 2024. Its weakness is regulatory memory: regulators watch Paytm more closely than anyone.

Metrics. *North Star:* active merchant devices (monthly). *Inputs:* GMV per device, loan disbursements per active merchant, consumer MTU, subscription churn. *Guardrails:* compliance incidents, loan default rate at partners, device downtime.

What I would build next at Paytm

1. **Shopkeeper co-pilot on the Soundbox.** *Problem:* merchants have no time to read dashboards. *Bet:* a voice summary each night ("You earned ₹8,420, 12% more than last Tuesday; your loan EMI is due Friday"). *Metric:* device retention at 12 months.
2. **Inventory credit with distributors.** *Problem:* shopkeepers pay suppliers in cash on delivery. *Bet:* let merchants pay distributors via Paytm with 15-day credit. *Metric:* credit GMV; default rate.

PAYMENTS · WHATSAPP PAY

The biggest distribution in India, the smallest share

WhatsApp has over 500 million Indian users and less than 1% of UPI payments. It is the best case study of why distribution alone does not win.

Who it is for. In theory, every Indian with WhatsApp. In practice, a small group of users who send money to family inside chats.
Share of UPI volume: about 0.65% (NPCI, May 2026).

Why it lost the first round.

- **Late and capped.** WhatsApp launched a pilot in 2018, but NPCI allowed it only a limited number of users until the cap was fully removed in **December 2024**. By then the UPI habit belonged to PhonePe and Google Pay.
- **Wrong moment.** Most UPI payments are *merchant scans*, not *chat payments*. When you stand at a counter you open a scan-first app, not a messaging app.
- **No reward and little reason to switch.** Rivals paid users with cashback while WhatsApp could not. UPI interoperability meant there was no feature only WhatsApp could offer.
- **Trust split.** Many users are happy to chat on WhatsApp but hesitate to link their bank account to a social app.

The second attempt. Meta has made commerce inside WhatsApp a priority. Businesses message customers under **per-message pricing** (from July 2025, billed in rupees from January 2026). More than **1 million businesses use Meta's Business Agents weekly** (Meta Q2 2026), and WhatsApp added bill payments through BBPS. In June 2026 CRED founder **Kunal Shah was named head of WhatsApp**, a clear signal that payments and commerce are central to its plans (press reports). If the 30% cap is enforced, WhatsApp is the biggest ready-made alternative.

Where chat payments fit, and where they do not

The payment moment decides which app wins

Where WhatsApp Pay loses	Where WhatsApp Pay can win
● Paying at a shop Scan-first apps open to the camera in one tap	● Paying a business in chat The order, the bill and the payment happen in one thread
● Habit already formed Users have used PhonePe or Google Pay for 5+ years	● Family transfers Money goes where the conversation already is
● No cashback Nothing pulls users to try it	● Agent commerce A business agent answers, quotes and collects payment

Distribution does not beat habit at the moment of use. WhatsApp should own payments that start in a conversation, not fight for the QR scan.

What I would build next at WhatsApp Pay

1. **One-tap checkout inside business chats.** *Problem:* a customer finishes a chat order and is then sent to a payment link in a browser. *Bet:* the business agent sends a native "Pay ₹640" card. *Metric:* chat-to-payment conversion rate for businesses.
2. **Group split for trips and flatmates.** *Problem:* groups track shared costs in separate apps. *Bet:* split and settle inside the group chat. *Metric:* groups with a settled split; new UPI users activated through a split.

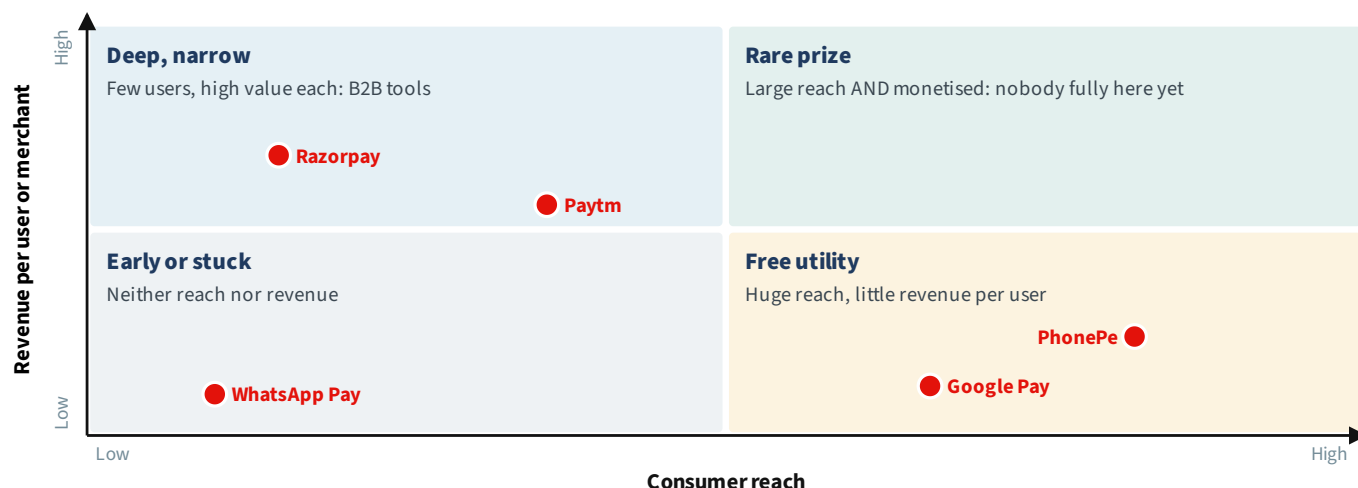
Comparing the five

	Razorpay	PhonePe	Google Pay	Paytm	WhatsApp Pay
Main customer	Online businesses	Mass consumers + small shops	Urban consumers	Small merchants	Chatting users, businesses
Core job	Accept every payment online	Pay anywhere, fast	Pay simply, safely	Get paid and get credit	Pay where you already chat

	Razorpay	PhonePe	Google Pay	Paytm	WhatsApp Pay
How it earns	MDR on cards, value-added services	Loans, insurance, broking, devices	Distribution, fees; strategic value	Devices, processing, loan fees	Business messaging (Meta)
Main moat	Switching costs, routing data	Habit, merchant presence	Brand, Android	Merchant devices, credit data	Distribution
Biggest risk	Thin margins, regulation	30% cap, slow revenue growth	30% cap, low priority inside Google	Regulatory memory	Habit already set elsewhere

Reach versus money made per user

Where each player sits today (author's judgement)



Likely interview questions

1. "NPCI enforces the 30% cap tomorrow. You are PM at PhonePe. What do you do?" A strong answer protects the heaviest and most profitable users first, then moves the rest on purpose (not at random) and treats it as a revenue-per-user problem, not a volume problem.
2. "How would you make money from UPI without charging users?" Walk through the stack: merchant devices, credit on UPI, distribution, ads. Name the guardrail: trust drops if every screen is an ad.
3. "Why did WhatsApp Pay fail despite 500M users?" Use the moment-of-use argument (scan versus chat) and interoperability, then say where it can still win.
4. "Define success metrics for UPI Circle." North Star: secondary users who make 3+ payments in 30 days. Guardrail: fraud disputes raised by primary users.
5. "Payment success rate dropped 2 points on Razorpay. Find the cause." Break it down by method (UPI, cards), bank, device and time. Most drops trace back to one bank's downtime.
6. "Design a payments product for first-time rural users." Consider voice, feature phones (UPI 123Pay), trust signals and family delegation. Measure a second payment within 7 days.

Recall: payments

1. What does zero MDR on UPI mean, and why does it push payment apps into lending and devices?
2. Explain in two sentences why UPI interoperability weakens PhonePe's network effect.
3. Name three of Razorpay's features and the metric each one moves.
4. What problem does a sound box solve for a shopkeeper, and what does it give Paytm in return?
5. Give two reasons WhatsApp Pay's share is below 1%.
6. What is UPI Reserve Pay, and why does agentic commerce need it?
7. For PhonePe, pick a North Star metric and two guardrails, and justify each.

PRODUCT DOSSIER • INVESTING

Breadth versus intensity

Groww has twice as many active clients as Zerodha. Zerodha makes more than twice the profit. They are two different answers to the same question: who is your investing app really for?

Two phones, one Monday morning. In Indore, a 24-year-old opens Groww after a YouTube video on index funds. She starts a ₹500 monthly SIP, a systematic investment plan that auto-debits every month. It takes four minutes, including KYC. In Mumbai, a full-time trader has Zerodha's Kite open on two screens. He buys and sells Nifty options thirty times before lunch, and each order goes through in a fraction of a second.

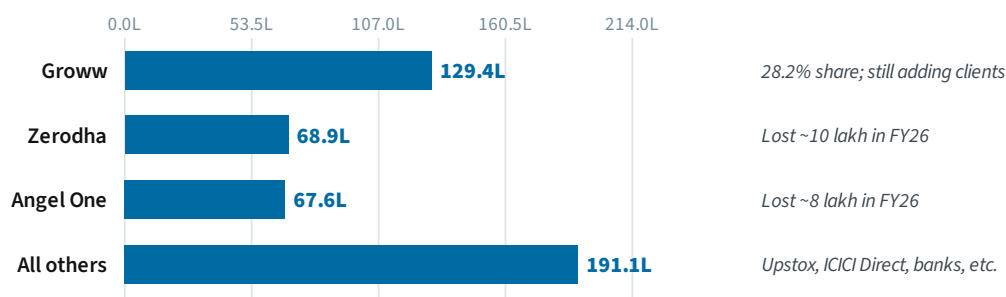
Both are "investing apps". But the first user brings **breadth**: millions of small, sticky accounts. The second brings **intensity**: fewer users, each worth a lot of brokerage. Almost every product decision in this dossier follows from which of the two a company has chosen to serve.

The job, and the market

The investor hires the app to "**grow my savings without being cheated or confused.**" The trader hires it to "**execute my trade instantly, cheaply, and never go down when the market moves.**" smallcase serves a third job: "**let me invest in an idea (like 'EV makers' or 'dividend stocks') without picking every stock myself.**"

Who has India's active investors

NSE active clients by broker, March 2026 (lakh)

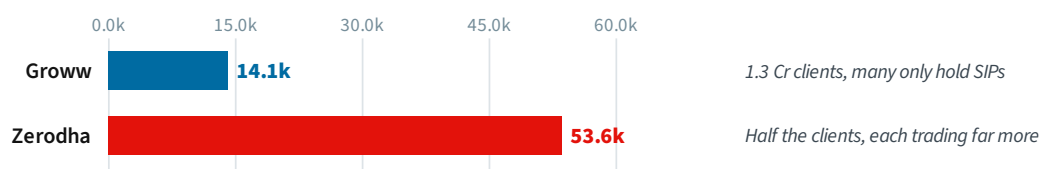


Source: NSE data via Business Today (Apr 2026). Total 4.57 crore, down 7.1% YoY after SEBI's F&O curbs

Two things happened in the market. First, in October 2024 **SEBI tightened futures and options (F&O) trading**. It raised contract sizes, allowed only one weekly expiry per exchange, and required option premiums to be collected upfront. It acted because its studies found that roughly **9 in 10 individual F&O traders lose money**. Brokers that earned most of their revenue from F&O were hit hardest. Second, retail enthusiasm cooled as markets fell after September 2024, so the number of active clients shrank for the first time in years.

Same industry, two economic engines

FY25 profit per NSE active client (₹ thousand)



Source: Company financials FY25; author calculation (FY25 profit ÷ NSE active clients)

Breadth versus intensity

Breadth (Groww)	Intensity (Zerodha)
● Acquire Mutual funds first; 81% organic sign-ups	● Acquire Traders, via word of mouth and Varsity education
● Earn Small revenue from many users, across MF, stocks, F&O, loans	● Earn ₹20 per F&O order from very active users
● Risk Low revenue per user; needs cross-selling	● Risk Revenue swings with market mood and SEBI rules

In an interview, first ask which user you are optimising for. The right metric, features and guardrails all depend on it.

INVESTING · GROWW

The first investing app for new India

Groww began with mutual funds for people who had never invested. It now wants to be their broker, lender and wealth manager.

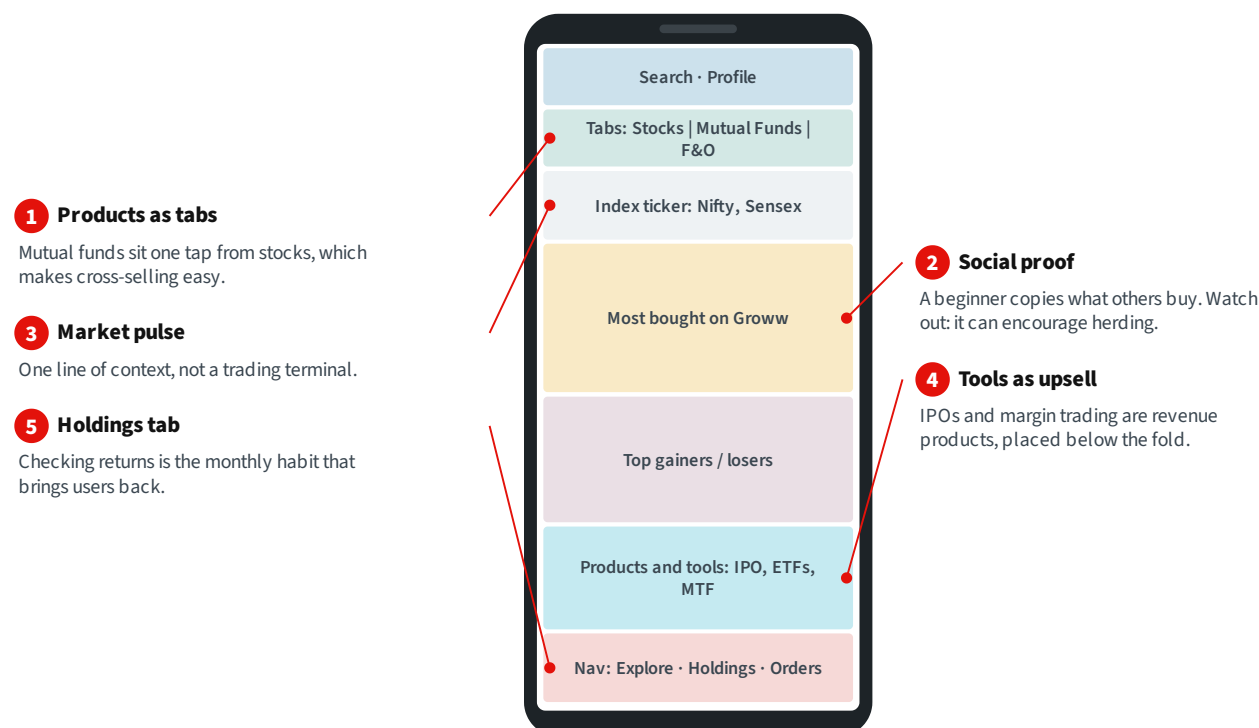
Who it is for. First-time investors, often under 30 and increasingly outside the metros. Positioning: "investing made simple." Groww began in 2017 as a direct mutual-fund app, added stocks in 2020, then F&O, margin trading, loans, its own asset management company (AMC), and wealth services. It listed on the stock exchanges in November 2025.

Core loop. A YouTube video or a friend's referral → download → start a small SIP → the SIP debits every month → the user opens the app to check returns → sees stock prices and "most bought" lists → buys a first stock → trades more often. The SIP is the **anchor habit**. It makes the user open the app every month without any marketing spend.

First run. Mobile number → PAN → Aadhaar e-sign → selfie and signature → bank link. It takes minutes and is fully digital. The risky steps are KYC rejections (name mismatches between PAN and bank) and the empty state after sign-up. Groww fills that empty state with "Popular funds" and "Most bought on Groww" so a nervous beginner has somewhere to start.

Groww home (Stocks tab), annotated

Built to calm a beginner and nudge a first action

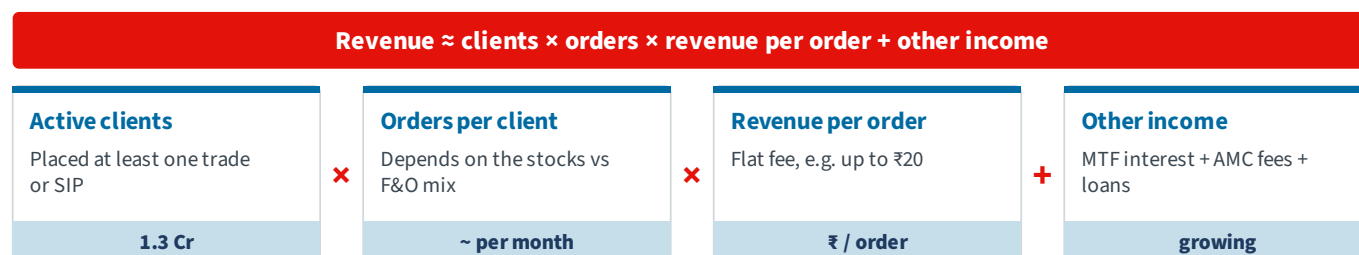


Feature	User problem	Design choice	Metric it moves
Direct mutual funds, zero commission	"Agents sell me funds with hidden commissions"	Direct plans only; clear expense ratios	First investment, trust
SIP with UPI Autopay	"I forget to invest every month"	Mandate set once, debited automatically	SIP persistence (months active)
"Most bought" lists	"I don't know where to start"	Social proof on the home screen	First stock purchase
Simplified F&O and option chain	"Options screens look like a cockpit"	Fewer numbers, clear profit/loss preview	F&O orders (with guardrails)
Margin Trading Facility (MTF)	"I want to buy more than my cash allows"	Pay ~20–25%, Groww funds the rest at interest	Interest income
Loans, UPI, wealth, own AMC	"I use five apps for money"	One trusted app for the whole wallet	Products per client

Business model. In Q1 FY27 Groww's operating revenue was **₹1,501 Cr (+66% YoY)** and net profit **₹735 Cr (+94%)**, with **1.30 crore active clients** (Entrackr, Jul 2026). Revenue comes from brokerage (a flat fee per order), interest on the MTF book, AMC fees, and distribution. After SEBI's curbs, F&O fell from about 68% to 57% of revenue, and Groww has been deliberately diversifying since.

How to break down Groww's revenue in an interview

Each term is something a PM can move



Source: Structure only; values illustrative

Growth loops and moat. About 81% of Groww's users arrive organically, through content, referrals and app-store search. Each new investor tells friends, and each "most bought" list gives the next beginner confidence. The moat is **brand among first-time investors** plus low acquisition cost at scale. Against banks' high-fee broking accounts, Groww also has **counter-positioning**: it charges less and runs a simpler app, and banks cannot match it without cutting their own fee income.

Metrics. *North Star*: active investing clients (a trade or SIP in the last 30 days). *Inputs*: KYC-to-first-investment rate within 7 days, SIP persistence at 12 months, share of clients using two or more products, MTF book size. *Guardrails*: F&O losses per retail client, complaints per lakh clients, outage minutes on high-volume days.

Strengths: reach, low acquisition cost, product breadth, now profitable. **Weaknesses**: low revenue per user, tempting to push F&O, and a lot of regulatory exposure.

What I would build next at Groww

- Loss-aware F&O mode.** *Problem*: most retail option buyers lose money and then leave angry. *Bet*: before each F&O order, show the user's own 90-day realised profit and loss, and offer a cooling-off period after a streak of losses. *Metric*: 12-month retention of F&O users; complaints (guardrail: F&O revenue per user falls only modestly).
- Goal-based family investing.** *Problem*: young investors want to invest for parents or children too. *Bet*: linked family accounts with shared goals ("Papa's retirement ₹25L"). *Metric*: SIPs per household; AUM per active client.
- Vernacular fund explainer.** *Problem*: fund documents are written in English jargon. *Bet*: an AI explainer in 10 languages ("What does this fund actually own?"). *Metric*: first-investment rate among non-English users.

INVESTING · ZERODHA

The broker that refuses to gamify

Zerodha built India's most profitable broker with almost no marketing, a spartan app and a habit of warning users not to trade.

Who it is for. Serious traders and long-term investors who value speed, reliability and honesty over hand-holding. Positioning: *"the discount broker with the best technology, and no tricks."* Zerodha charges **zero brokerage on equity delivery** (buy-and-hold) and a flat ₹20 on intraday and F&O orders.

Core loop. Learn on Varsity, Zerodha's free education site → open an account → trade on Kite → fast, reliable execution builds trust → trade more, recommend it to friends. Zerodha spends almost nothing on ads. Its growth came from traders recommending it to other traders.

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Kite (web and app)	"The app freezes when the market moves"	Minimalist and fast; built in-house	Order latency, uptime
Console	"Tax time is painful"	Tax P&L and reports in one place	Retention, support tickets
Coin	"I want direct funds with my stocks"	Direct MFs held in the same demat	AUM
Varsity	"I don't understand markets"	Free, deep, unbranded education	Quality of new sign-ups
Nudges and kill switch	"I overtrade when I'm emotional"	Warnings before risky orders; self-block a segment	Complaints, long-run retention
GTT orders and Kite Connect API	"I can't watch the screen all day"	Standing orders; paid API for algo builders	Orders per active trader

Business model. FY26 revenue was flat at about **₹8,500 Cr**, and profit was **₹4,283 Cr** (Entrackr, Aug 2026), still the highest of any Indian broker. Its share of NSE active clients fell to about 15%, but customer assets reached about **₹9 lakh crore, the largest of any broker**. Nithin Kamath now says AUM, not active clients, is the number that matters: *"The money in the trading account can come and go, but AUM typically sticks around."* Margin trading now brings in about 10% of revenue.

Moat. Branding: a reputation for honesty that has held up for years. Process power: a lean, in-house technology team running at very low cost. Counter-positioning: it refuses ads and gamification, which rivals depending on F&O volume cannot easily copy. Switching costs: traders' habits and their API code are built around Kite.

Metrics. *North Star (as Zerodha now frames it):* customer assets (AUM). *Inputs:* new accounts, AUM per client, MTF book, Coin SIPs. *Guardrails:* uptime on high-volume days, the share of users who trade against a nudge, complaints.

Strengths: profit, trust, technology. **Weaknesses:** revenue is still tied to trading activity and SEBI rules. The minimalist app feels intimidating to beginners, which is the segment Groww won.

What I would build next at Zerodha

1. **Portfolio health check.** *Problem:* long-term investors hold overlapping funds and forget to harvest tax losses. *Bet:* a yearly "health report" in Console with one-tap fixes. *Metric:* AUM retention; share of clients acting on suggestions.
2. **Family and HUF accounts under one login.** *Problem:* households manage 3–4 accounts separately. *Bet:* one family view, shared nominee and succession details, and consolidated tax reports. *Metric:* accounts per household; AUM per family. (Guardrail: no loss of privacy between family members who want separate views, such as an adult child who does not want parents to see their trades.)

INVESTING · SMALLCASE

Invest in ideas, not stocks

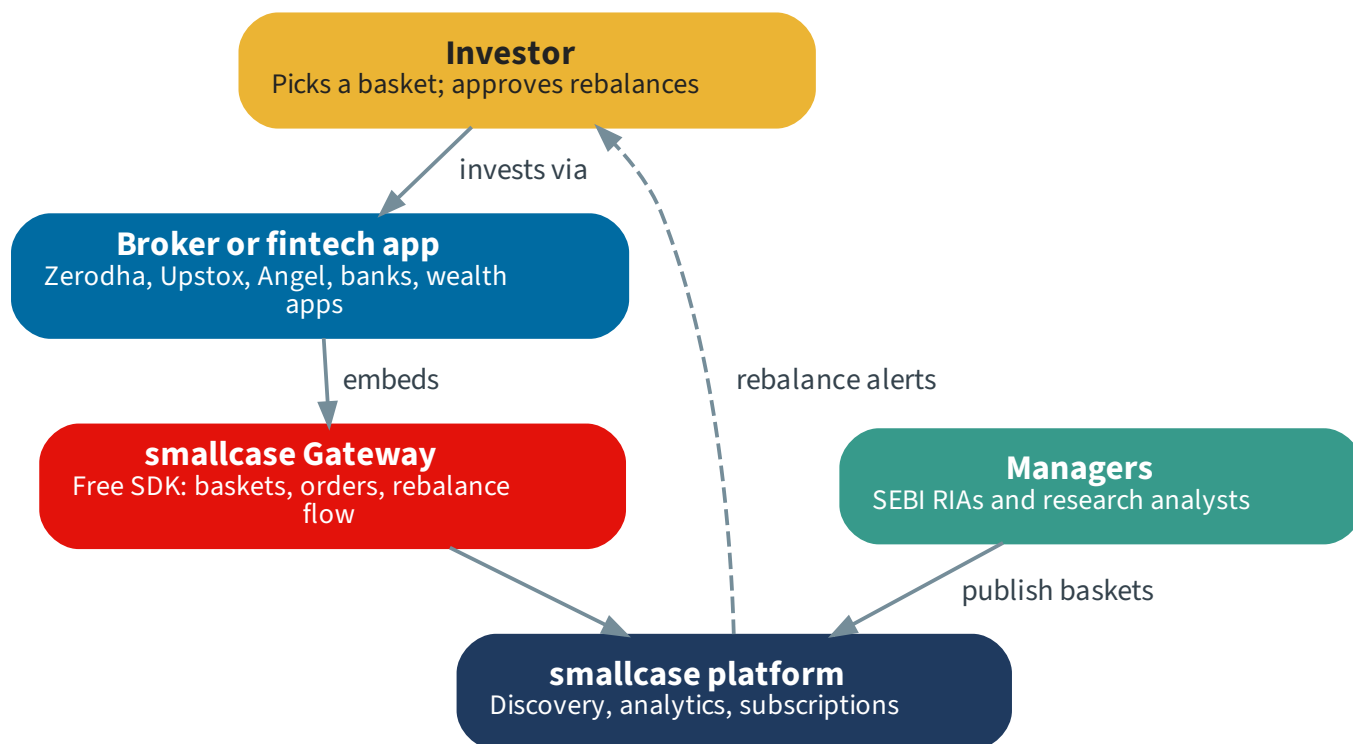
smallcase does not hold your money or your shares. It sells ideas, packaged as baskets, and delivers them through other people's brokers.

Who it is for. Investors who want a ready-made portfolio built around a theme or strategy ("Top 100 stocks", "Electric mobility", "Dividend aristocrats") but do not want a mutual fund's fees or lack of visibility. On the supply side, it serves SEBI-registered advisers and research analysts who want to reach investors.

How it works. A *manager* (an adviser or analyst) builds a basket of 5–30 stocks with weights. You buy it with one click, and the shares land in **your own demat account** at your own broker. When the manager rebalances, you get a notification and approve the changes. You see every stock you own, which a mutual fund does not show you day to day.

How smallcase sits between brokers and managers

The platform never holds money; the broker executes, the manager supplies ideas



Source: smallcase Gateway documentation; simplified

Business model. FY25 revenue was ₹106 Cr (+57%), close to breakeven, with over 10 million users (company data). Revenue comes from a flat fee (about ₹100) on transactions in free baskets, a share of subscription fees on paid managers' baskets, and fees from partners using the platform. The smart part is **Gateway**, a free software kit that brokers embed in their own apps. Brokers get a ready-made investing product, and smallcase gets distribution without paying for customers. Once a broker has built its flows around Gateway, replacing it is painful. It is a **switching cost disguised as a feature**.

Moat. Network effects between managers and investors: more investors attract better managers, and better baskets attract more investors. Switching costs at partner brokers. A cornered resource: years of integration with the order systems of most Indian brokers.

Metrics. *North Star*: assets invested through smallcases. *Inputs*: new baskets bought, rebalance acceptance rate, active managers, partner integrations. *Guardrails*: churn after drawdowns, accuracy of performance disclosures, complaints about managers.

What I would build next at smallcase

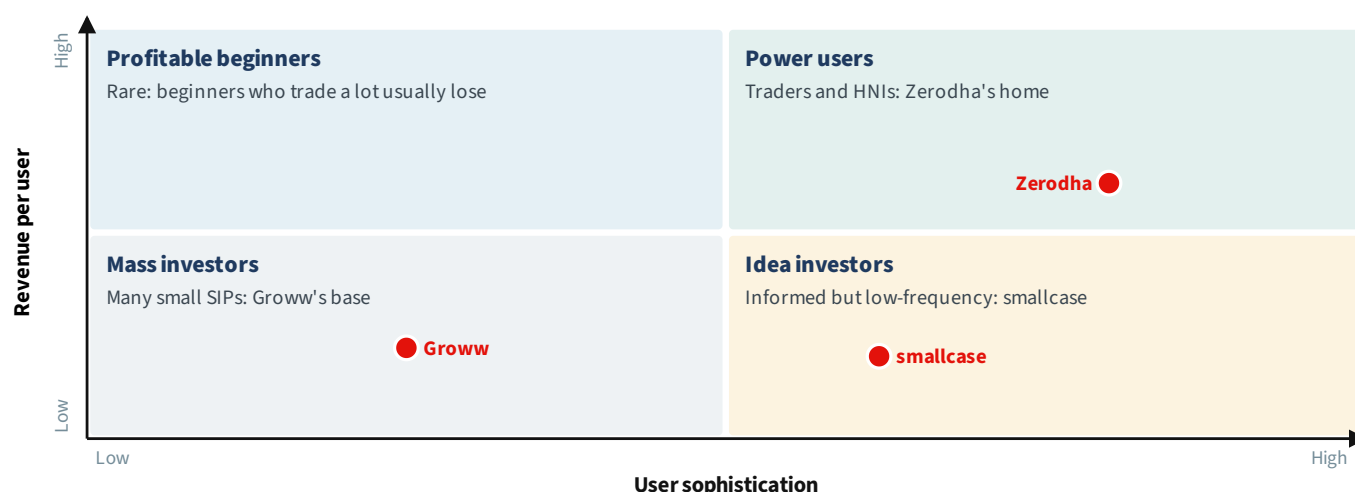
1. **Pre-approved rebalancing.** *Problem:* many users ignore rebalance alerts, so their portfolios drift from the strategy. *Bet:* let users pre-approve rebalances within limits they set (for example, no single trade over 10%). *Metric:* rebalance completion rate; tracking error against the model portfolio.
2. **Tax-aware rebalancing.** *Problem:* rebalancing can trigger short-term capital gains. *Bet:* show the tax cost of each change and offer a tax-efficient alternative. *Metric:* retention after the first rebalance.

Comparing the three

	Groww	Zerodha	smallcase
Core user	First-time investor	Active trader, serious investor	Theme-seeking investor; advisers
Anchor habit	Monthly SIP	Daily trading	Rebalance approvals
Main revenue	Brokerage + MTF + AMC + loans	Brokerage (F&O) + MTF	Basket fees, subscriptions, partner fees
Moat	Brand with beginners, low CAC	Trust, low cost, technology	Two-sided network, Gateway switching costs
Main risk	Low value per user; F&O temptation	Revenue tied to trading, SEBI rules	Depends on brokers and market mood

User sophistication versus revenue per user

Where each player's core user sits (author's judgement)



Likely interview questions

1. "Groww's F&O revenue falls 30% after a new SEBI rule. What do you do?" Separate the short term (cost, reassure users) from the long term (MTF, AMC, wealth, loans). Name the trade-off: do not push risky trading to fill the gap.
2. "Design a feature to stop retail investors from overtrading." Zerodha's nudges and kill switch are the benchmark. Measure long-run retention and complaints, not orders.
3. "What should Zerodha's North Star be?" Weigh active clients against AUM against revenue. AUM matches long-term trust. Active clients can be gamed.
4. "Should Groww show 'Most bought' lists?" Social proof helps beginners but encourages herding. Suggest context, such as showing the risk level next to each name.
5. "How would you grow smallcase's AUM 3x?" Use distribution (more Gateway partners), supply (better managers) and conversion (pre-approved rebalances).
6. "Estimate daily orders on Zerodha." Active clients × share trading daily × orders per trader. Say your assumptions out loud.

Recall: investing

1. What is the difference between monetising "breadth" and "intensity"? Give one example of each.
2. Why did SEBI tighten F&O rules in 2024, and which kind of broker did it hurt more?
3. Why is a monthly SIP a good "anchor habit" for an investing app?
4. Explain smallcase Gateway and why it creates switching costs.
5. Why does Nithin Kamath prefer AUM to active clients as a metric?
6. Name two guardrail metrics for an F&O feature.
7. (Payments) Why do UPI apps sell loans and insurance?

PRODUCT DOSSIER • FOOD DELIVERY

The three-sided marketplace that learned to make money

Zomato and Swiggy took a decade to turn a ₹450 biryani order into a profit. The lessons in that climb are what interviewers probe.

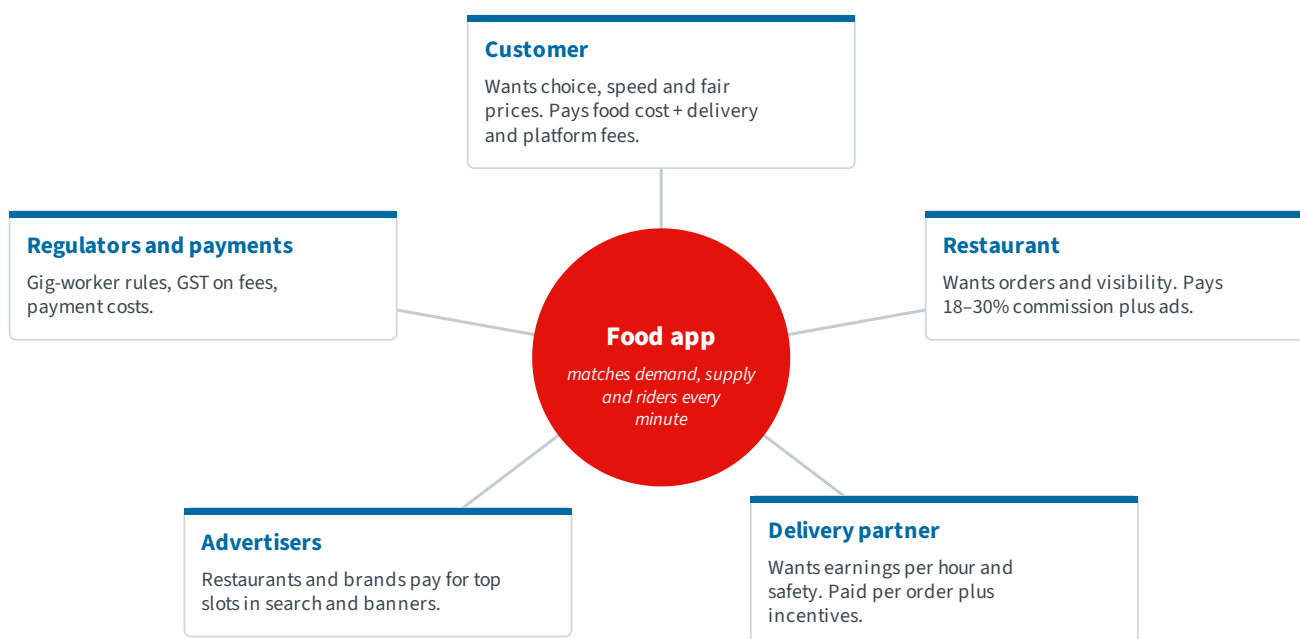
Friday, 9:15 p.m., heavy rain in Bengaluru. Orders on both apps jump sharply. Riders are fewer, because many stay home. Within minutes the apps show a small "rain fee", widen delivery-time estimates, and quietly stop showing restaurants that are more than a few kilometres away. None of this is visible as a "feature". It is the marketplace balancing three groups at once: hungry customers, busy kitchens, and delivery partners who are getting wet.

The job, and the market

A customer hires a food app to **"get the food I'm craving, now, without cooking or going out."** A restaurant hires it to **"fill my kitchen with orders beyond the tables I have."** A delivery partner hires it to **"earn a steady income per hour, on my own schedule."** A good answer about this industry always names all three.

One order, three customers

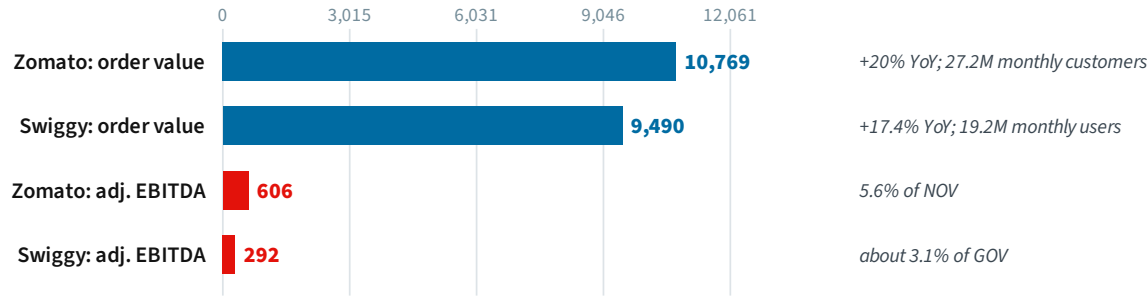
The platform must keep all three sides coming back



India's food delivery market is a **duopoly**. Zomato (owned by Eternal) leads, Swiggy follows, and a handful of challengers compete for what is left.

The duopoly, by order value

Q1 FY27 (Apr–Jun 2026), ₹ crore per quarter

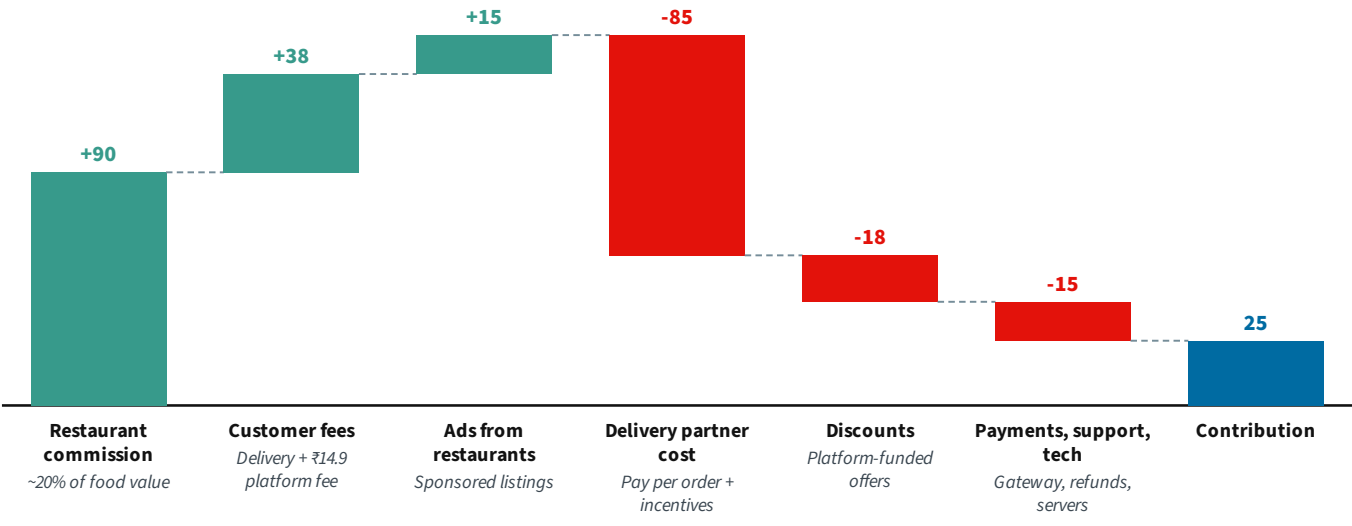


Source: Eternal and Swiggy shareholder letters via MediaNama, YourStory (Jul 2026). Zomato reports NOV (net order value); Swiggy reports GOV (gross), so the gap is slightly understated

Both companies are now profitable in food delivery. It took ten years. The route there tells you most of what matters.

Where the money goes on a ₹450 food order

₹ per order, illustrative; calibrated to reported margins of 3–6% of order value



About ₹25 per order is left before marketing and overheads. Every ₹5 of rider cost or discount matters.

Source: Illustrative, built from company disclosures on take rates, platform fees and margins

The lever that moves this waterfall most is **delivery cost per order**. It falls when a rider completes more orders per hour, which requires **density**: many orders in a small area. That is why the apps limit how far away a restaurant can be during peak hours, **batch** two orders on one trip, and pay incentives to keep riders logged in at dinner time.

FOOD DELIVERY · ZOMATO

From restaurant reviews to India's most profitable food app

Zomato started as a place to read menus. Its advantage is still discovery: knowing what you want to eat before you do.

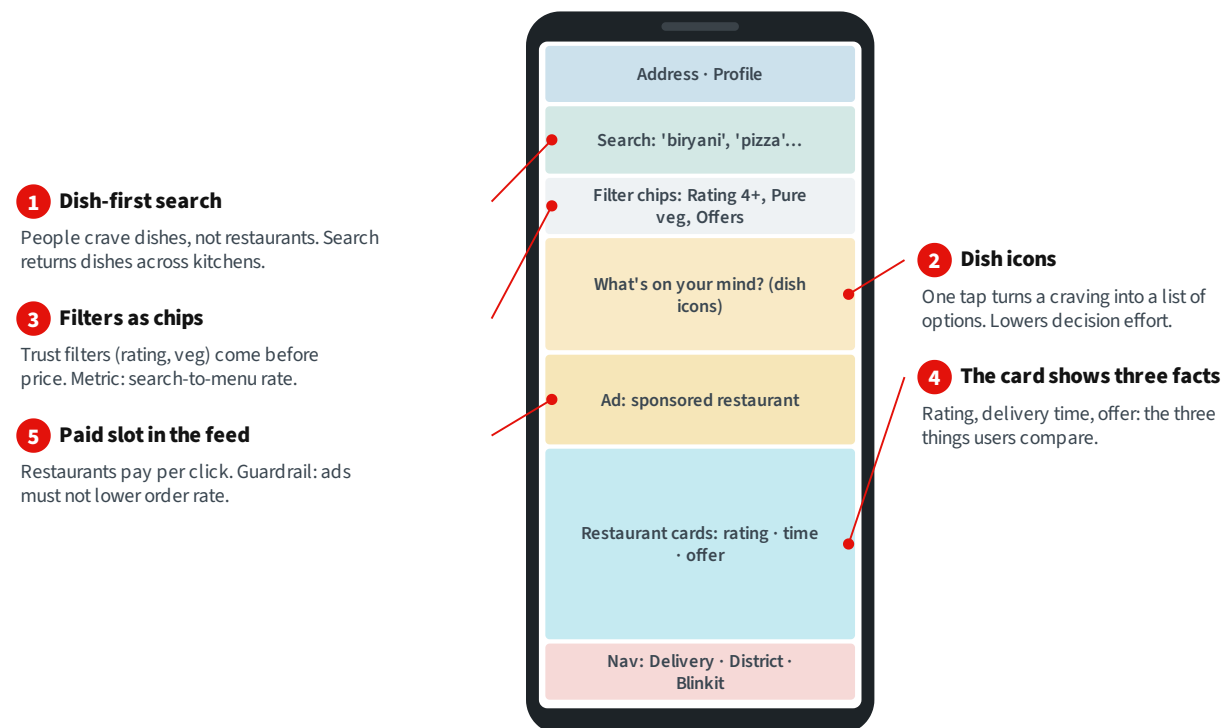
Who it is for. Urban diners aged about 18–40, in over 800 cities. Positioning: "better food for more people." The brand voice is witty and self-aware, and its push notifications have become part of its marketing. Zomato is part of **Eternal**, which also owns Blinkit (quick commerce), District (going out) and Hyperpure (supplies for restaurants).

Core loop. Open the app → discover (search, recommendations, ratings) → order → get it in about 30 minutes → rate → better recommendations next time → order again. The **supply loop** runs underneath: more orders → more restaurants list and advertise → more choice → more customers.

First run. Phone number and OTP → location permission → a home screen showing restaurants that deliver *right now*. The biggest drop-off is the first order. New users see first-order offers and "Top rated" filters, which reduce the risk of a bad first meal.

Zomato delivery home, annotated

Built to turn a vague craving into an order in under a minute



Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric it moves
Ratings and reviews	"Will this place be good?"	Zomato's origin; separate delivery and dining ratings	First-order conversion
Live tracking and rider chat	"Where is my food?"	Map plus ETA cuts anxious support calls	Support contacts per order
Zomato Gold	"Delivery fees add up"	Low-priced membership: free delivery + discounts on eligible orders	Order frequency, retention
Healthy mode (2025)	"I want to eat better but can't tell what's healthy"	Health scores on dishes; a healthy filter	Share of health-focused orders
Food Rescue	"Cancelled orders waste food"	Cancelled orders are offered nearby at a discount	Cancellation cost, waste
Platform fee	Zomato: "tiny margins on each order"	A flat ₹14.9 per order in major cities	Revenue per order (guardrail: conversion)
Restaurant ads and Hyperpure	Restaurants: "I need visibility and supplies"	Pay-per-click ads; B2B ingredients delivered	Ad revenue, restaurant retention

Business model. Food delivery NOV was ₹10,769 Cr in Q1 FY27 (+20%), with adjusted EBITDA of ₹606 Cr (5.6% of NOV). There are 328,000 restaurant partners and 638,000 delivery partners (Eternal Q1 FY27). The platform fee alone brought in about ₹154 Cr in the quarter (Inc42). Revenue per order comes from commission, customer fees, and ads.

Growth loops. (1) *Content and brand*: witty notifications and social posts get shared, which acts as free acquisition. (2) *Restaurant flywheel*: more orders → more restaurants onboard and advertise → more choice. (3) *Cross-sell within Eternal*: Blinkit and District users become Zomato users and the other way round.

Moat. Local **network effects**: in each neighbourhood, more restaurants and more riders make the service better for everyone. **Scale economies** in delivery: higher density gives lower cost per order. **Data**: ten years of what people order, when, and where. The

weakness is that both switching costs and multi-homing are easy. Most heavy users have both apps and compare prices.

Metrics. *North Star*: orders delivered per week, or NOV. *Inputs*: monthly transacting customers, orders per customer, search-to-order conversion, restaurant availability at peak (% of top restaurants online at 8 p.m.), median delivery time. *Guardrails*: cancellations, order accuracy complaints, rider earnings per hour, total fees as a % of the bill.

2025–26 moves. The parent company was renamed **Eternal** in 2025. Zomato launched Healthy mode and healthy subscriptions. It shut its quick-food experiments *Zomato Quick* and *Everyday* but kept **Bistro**, the Blinkit-branded 10-minute café app for ₹50–150 items, which is growing slowly (about 10 kitchens a quarter). Management argues that "discount-led growth" by rivals has peaked.

What I would build next at Zomato

1. **"Decide for me" for groups.** *Problem*: a group of four takes 20 minutes to agree on dinner. *Bet*: each person votes on dishes in a shared link; the app proposes one order from one restaurant that satisfies everyone's constraints (veg, budget, spice). *Metric*: group orders per week; time from opening the link to order.
2. **Restaurant menu engineering assistant.** *Problem*: small restaurants don't know which dishes lose them money on delivery. *Bet*: show each restaurant dish-level conversion, repeat rate and packaging complaints, with suggested changes. *Metric*: restaurant GOV growth; restaurant churn.
3. **Health-goal plans.** *Problem*: people who order daily want to hit a protein or calorie goal. *Bet*: weekly meal plans built from nearby menus, delivered on a schedule. *Metric*: orders per subscriber; 60-day retention.

FOOD DELIVERY · SWIGGY

The convenience platform

Swiggy's bet is that one membership and one delivery fleet can serve food, groceries, dining out and more. Food delivery pays for that bet.

Who it is for. The same urban customer as Zomato, with a stronger hold in South India. Positioning: *"unparalleled convenience"*, across food, Instamart groceries, Dineout table reservations and Scenes events. Swiggy was built from day one around owning **the delivery experience**. It was the first to run its own large fleet rather than relying on restaurants' riders.

Core loop. The food loop is the same as Zomato's. On top of it sits a *platform loop*: a Swiggy One member → free delivery on food and Instamart → uses more services → the membership pays for itself → renews.

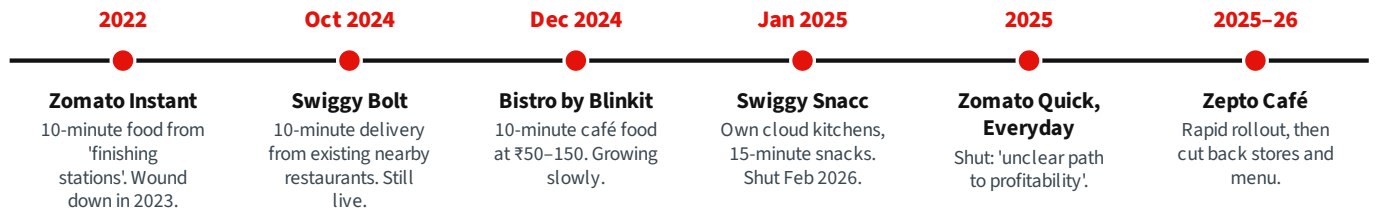
Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Swiggy One	"I pay delivery fees on three apps"	One membership across food, Instamart and Dineout	Cross-service users, frequency
Bolt (10-minute food)	"I want a snack now, not in 35 minutes"	Only nearby restaurants and quick-to-make items	Orders under 15 min, repeat rate
99 Store and Toing	"Food delivery is too expensive for daily meals"	Low-price meals; Toing is a separate budget app	New users, orders per user
Dineout and Scenes	"Where do we go out tonight?"	Table booking with bill discounts; events	Out-of-home GOV (profitable)
Builders Club / AI stack (2026)	Developers: "Let AI assistants order food"	Opens Swiggy's commerce stack to developers and agents	Orders from partner surfaces

Business model. Q1 FY27 food GOV was ₹9,490 Cr (+17.4%) with adjusted EBITDA of ₹292 Cr and 19.2 million monthly transacting users. Group revenue was ₹6,812 Cr (+37%) and the net loss narrowed to ₹791 Cr, mostly because Instamart losses shrank (YourStory, Inc42, Jul 2026). Food delivery funds the group. Instamart is where the losses have been.

What went wrong, and what it teaches. Swiggy launched **Snacc**, a 15-minute cloud-kitchen snack app, in January 2025 and **shut it in February 2026** because "the broader economics made it challenging to scale." Zomato closed Quick and Everyday. Zepto Café scaled back its menu and footprint. Only Swiggy's **Bolt**, which uses existing restaurants rather than new kitchens, and Zomato's small Bistro survived. The lesson: speed is a cost, so a faster promise must come from supply you already have.

The quick-food experiments, 2022–2026

Most tried to add speed with new kitchens; most closed



Source: Company announcements and press reports (TechCrunch, YourStory, Business Standard)

Moat. The same as Zomato's, but slightly weaker at number two: lower order density in many cities means a higher cost per order. Swiggy's distinct asset is the **cross-category membership** plus one shared fleet.

Metrics. *North Star:* weekly transacting users across the platform. *Inputs:* food orders per user, Swiggy One penetration, cross-category users, delivery time. *Guardrails:* food adjusted-EBITDA margin (it must keep funding Instamart), cancellations, rider earnings.

What I would build next at Swiggy

- Office lunch subscriptions.** *Problem:* office workers order lunch daily but pay high fees on small orders. *Bet:* pooled office deliveries at fixed slots with lower fees. *Metric:* orders per rider-hour at lunch; subscriber retention.
- One cart across food and Instamart.** *Problem:* customers want a dessert from a restaurant and ice cream from the store in one delivery. *Bet:* a combined cart with a single rider when both are within range. *Metric:* AOV per trip; cross-category orders.

FOOD DELIVERY · MAGICPIN

The challenger on an open network

magicpin cannot outspend the duopoly. So it rides ONDC, a government-backed open network, and competes on lower commissions and lower prices.

Who it is for. Price-sensitive customers who compare prices, and restaurants unhappy with duopoly commissions. Positioning: "the same food, cheaper." magicpin began in 2015 as a hyperlocal discovery app that gave cashback for spending at local shops. It now calls itself **India's third-largest food delivery app** and is the largest food seller app on ONDC. It handled around 150,000 orders a day in late 2024 (Business Standard, Oct 2024).

How ONDC works. ONDC (Open Network for Digital Commerce) separates the pieces a marketplace normally owns. A *buyer app* (such as Paytm or magicpin) shows the menu. A *seller app* connects the restaurant. A *logistics provider* delivers. Each piece can be a different company, so the restaurant can be found in many apps at once, usually at lower commission.

An order on ONDC versus inside Zomato

Open network: many front doors, shared supply



Source: ONDC documentation; simplified

Key features. **magicNOW**, 15-minute food delivery from nearby restaurants, which grew to about 13% of orders in 2025 (Inc42). **Lower prices** on the same restaurants, because commissions are lower. **magicPoints** loyalty from its discovery days. A partnership with **Rapido's Ownly** food service to challenge the duopoly together.

Business model. Revenue tripled to **₹870 Cr in FY24** (Business Standard). It earns from commissions, delivery fees and brand deals. ONDC incentives, which once subsidised orders, have been reduced, and that tests how many customers stay without them.

Moat and risk. The main advantage is **counter-positioning**: Zomato and Swiggy cannot match low commissions without cutting their own profits. The risk is that customers return to the duopoly for better selection and faster delivery once discounts end.

Metrics. *North Star*: repeat orders per week. *Inputs*: restaurants live at peak, price gap with Zomato and Swiggy on the same dish, delivery time, magicNOW share. *Guardrail*: contribution per order without incentives.

What I would build next at magicpin

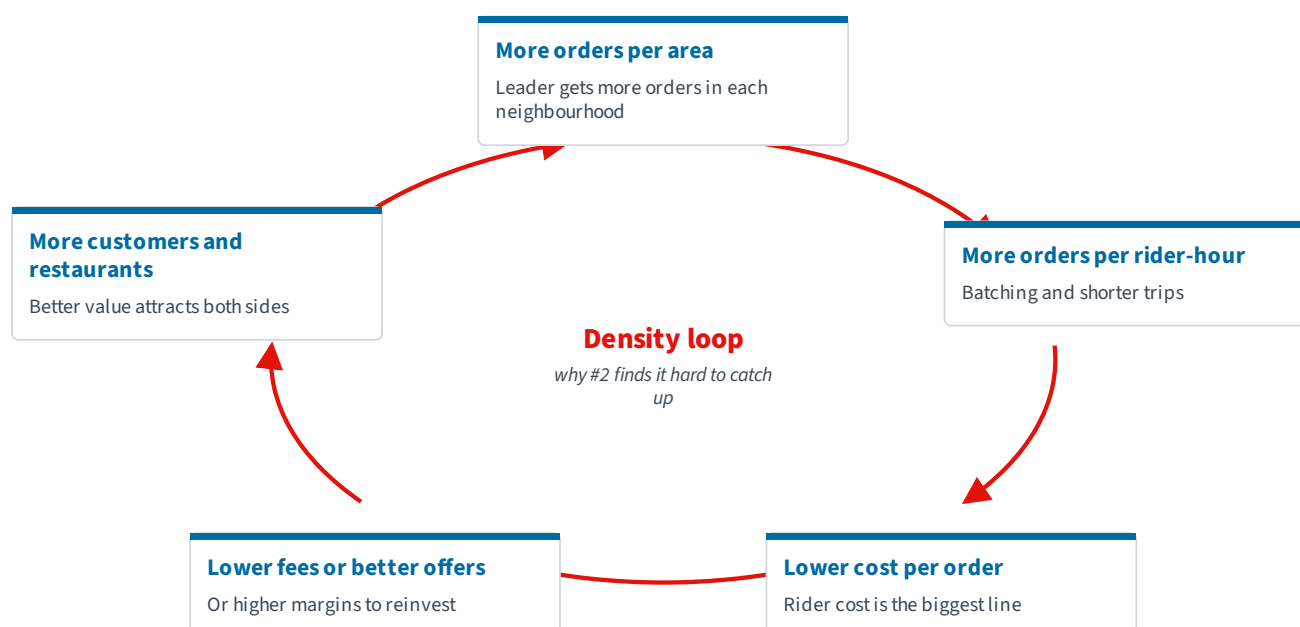
1. **"Same dish, lower price" proof.** *Problem*: users do not believe magicpin is cheaper. *Bet*: show the price of the same dish on other apps at checkout. *Metric*: first-order conversion from price-comparison visitors.
2. **Restaurant-direct loyalty.** *Problem*: restaurants want to own their regular customers. *Bet*: let restaurants run their own loyalty on magicpin at no extra cost. *Metric*: restaurants live; orders per restaurant.

Comparing the three

	Zomato	Swiggy	magicpin
Positioning	Best discovery, best food	Convenience across categories	Cheaper, open network
Scale (Q1 FY27)	₹10,769 Cr NOV/quarter	₹9,490 Cr GOV/quarter	Much smaller
Profit	5.6% of NOV	~3% of GOV	Depends on incentives
Membership	Gold	Swiggy One (cross-category)	magicPoints
Speed bet	Bistro (small)	Bolt	magicNOW
Moat	Density, data, brand	Density, cross-category fleet	Counter-positioning on commission

Why the leader tends to stay the leader

Higher order density lowers costs, which pays for the next customer



Likely interview questions

1. **"Orders on Swiggy dropped 8% week-on-week in one city. Diagnose."** Split the drop into users and orders per user. Check restaurant availability, delivery time, fees and app issues. Look for a local cause such as rain, a festival, or restaurants going

offline.

2. **"Should Zomato raise the platform fee from ₹14.9 to ₹19.9?"** Estimate revenue gained against conversion lost. Test it in a few cities. Use the fee as a share of the bill as a guardrail.
3. **"Design a feature for restaurant partners."** Pick one segment (small restaurants), one problem (low visibility or menu losses), and one metric (restaurant GOV or churn).
4. **"Why did 10-minute food mostly fail?"** Speed needs dense supply, and new kitchens cost too much for low-value orders. Bolt works because it uses existing kitchens.
5. **"Improve delivery partner retention."** Focus on earnings per hour, predictable shifts, safety and insurance. Metric: 90-day active partners.
6. **"Estimate daily food delivery orders in India."** Monthly users $\times$ orders per month $\div$ 30. Cross-check against the reported order value $\div$ average order value.

Recall: food delivery

1. Name the three sides of a food-delivery marketplace and what each one wants.
2. Which cost line decides food-delivery unit economics, and what lowers it?
3. Why did Snacc and Zomato Quick shut while Bolt survived?
4. Explain ONDC's buyer app / seller app / logistics split in two sentences.
5. What is counter-positioning? Use magicpin as the example.
6. Give Zomato a North Star, three inputs and two guardrails.
7. (Investing) What is the difference between monetising breadth and intensity?

PRODUCT DOSSIER • GROCERY AND QUICK COMMERCE

Ten minutes, and the bill for it

Quick commerce is India's fastest-growing retail format. In mid-2026 the leader turned its first profit, the challengers were cutting back, and Amazon arrived with patient capital.

It is 10:52 p.m. A student in Gurugram realises there is no milk for the morning and, more urgently, no charger for his laptop. He opens Blinkit, adds both, and pays ₹1,340. At 11:03 a rider is at the door. Somewhere within two kilometres, a **dark store**, a small warehouse closed to walk-in shoppers, packed the order in under two minutes.

In three years this format went from a pandemic experiment to about **\$11.3 billion of annual order value in FY26**, up from \$1.6 billion in FY23 (analyst estimates cited by Business Standard, Jul 2026). Quick commerce now sells chargers, cosmetics and toys as well as groceries, and it has forced Amazon, Flipkart and even Myntra to promise delivery in minutes.

The job, and the market

Customers hire quick commerce for **"I need this now, and I don't want to plan."** It replaces the walk to the kirana store and the monthly supermarket trip. Brands hire it for **"shelf space and ads in front of the most valuable urban shoppers."** That second job is where much of the profit comes from.

Who wins the quick-commerce order

Share of order value among the top three, FY26 (%)



Blinkit alone did ₹17,132 Cr of order value in Apr–Jun 2026, +86% YoY (Eternal Q1 FY27).

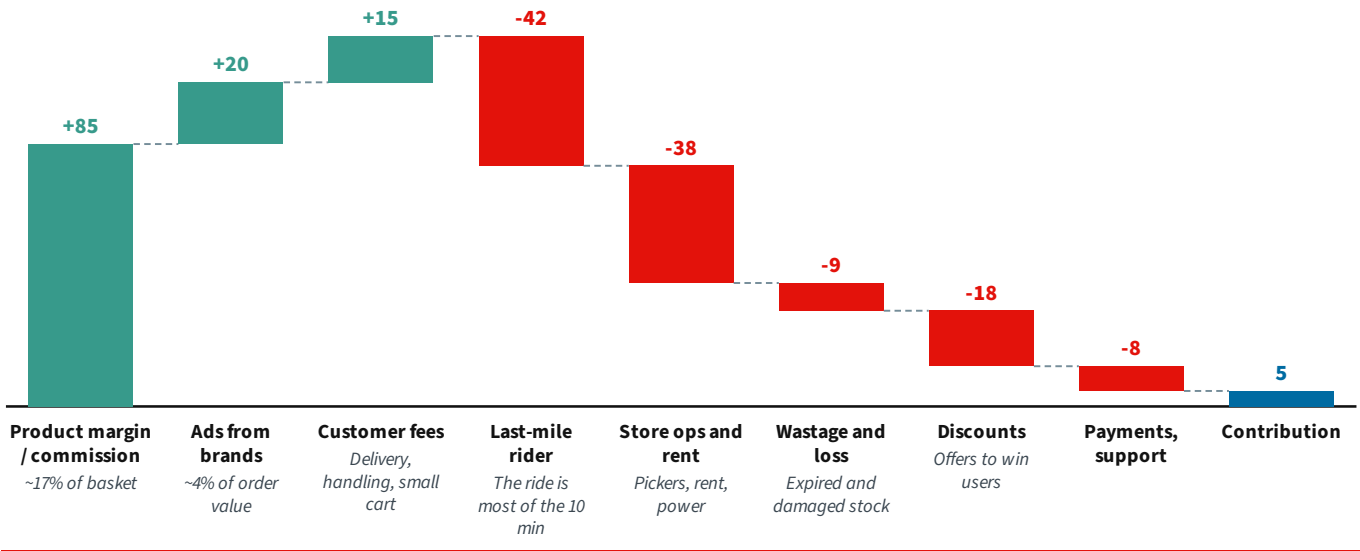
Source: Analyst estimates cited by Business Standard (Jul 2026); excludes Flipkart Minutes, Amazon Now, BB Now, JioMart

What a dark store is, in everyday terms

Everyday world	In technology
A kirana store with no customers inside	Dark store 2,500–4,000 SKUs in a 3,000–4,000 sq ft unit, laid out for pickers, not shoppers
A cricket fielder placed where the ball usually goes	Demand-based stocking Each store stocks what its 2–3 km radius buys most, predicted by data
A relay team	Picker → packer → rider Order picked in ~2 minutes; rider leaves immediately; most of the 10 minutes is the ride
Rent paid whether or not anyone orders	Fixed cost per store A new store loses money until orders per day rise; density decides everything

Where the money goes on a ₹500 quick-commerce basket

₹ per order for a mature store, illustrative

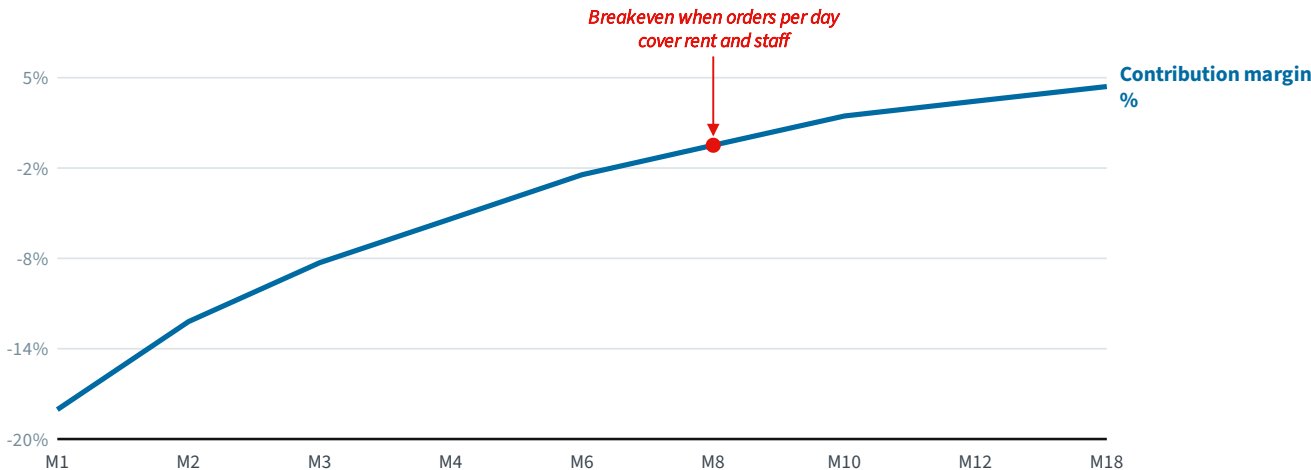


Ads and a bigger basket turn a loss into a profit. A ₹300 basket with the same fixed costs loses money.

Source: Illustrative; calibrated to Blinkit and Instamart disclosures (margins near breakeven, inventory loss ~1.8% of order value)

Why a new dark store loses money for months

Contribution margin by months since opening, illustrative cohort



Source: Illustrative shape; Eternal says a steady-state store does ~₹11 lakh of order value a day

That curve explains the headlines of 2025–26. A company that opens hundreds of stores at once reports bigger losses even while every older store is improving. When expansion slows, the same company suddenly "turns profitable". Always ask an interviewer **what share of stores are less than six months old**.

QUICK COMMERCE · BLINKIT (THE BENCHMARK)

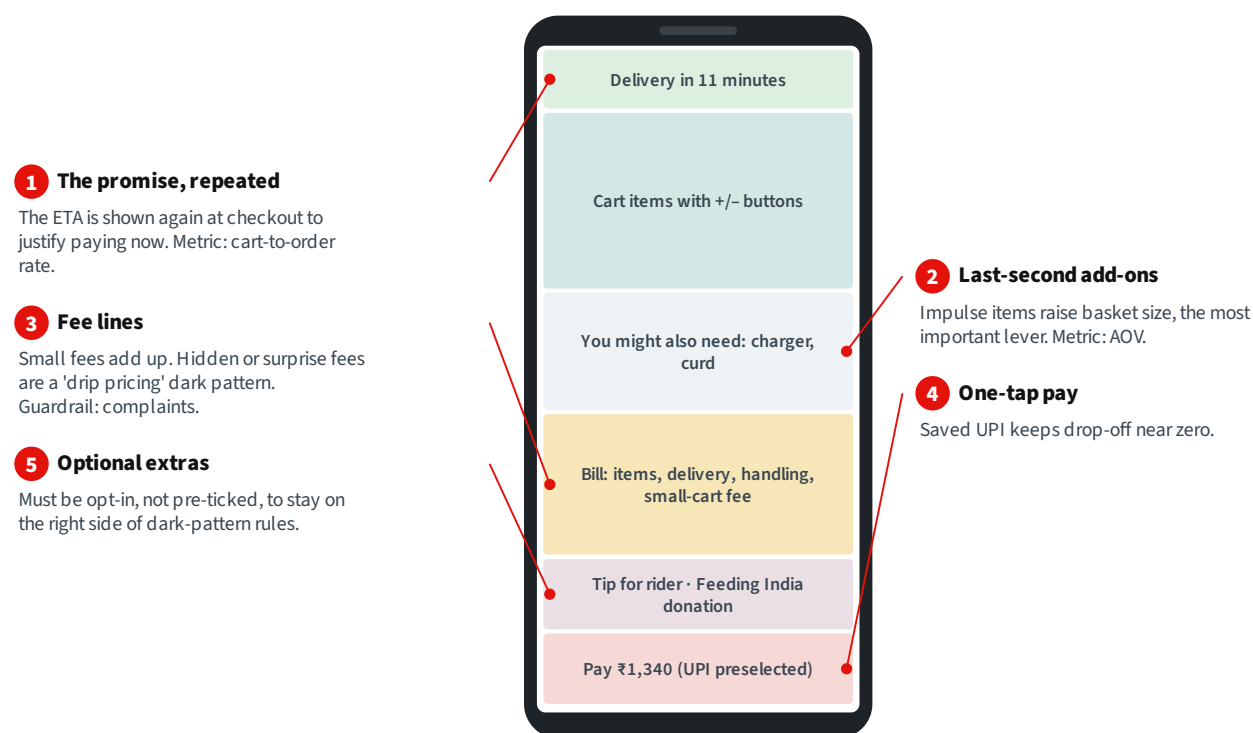
The leader that chose infrastructure over discounts

Blinkit is not on the ISB list, but every quick-commerce answer is measured against it.

Why it leads. Blinkit had 2,443 dark stores, 31.8 million monthly customers, and ₹8.27 lakh of order value per store per day in Q1 FY27. It posted its **first adjusted EBITDA profit, ₹102 Cr** (Eternal shareholder letter, Jul 2026). Its bet is infrastructure, not discounts. It now spends about ₹2.5 Cr to build each store, up from ₹1 Cr, on bigger stores with more products. It has also moved to a **first-party (1P) inventory model**: Blinkit buys and owns the stock rather than hosting third-party sellers. This became possible after Eternal restructured to be Indian-owned and controlled, since India's FDI rules stop foreign-owned e-commerce firms from holding inventory. Owning inventory gives better margins and more control over availability, but Blinkit now carries the risk of unsold stock (inventory losses were 1.8% of order value).

Blinkit cart and bill, annotated

The last screen before payment is where trust is won or lost



The lesson for interviews. Blinkit shows that quick commerce can be profitable, but only when stores are **dense, mature and full of high-margin products and ads**. Its guardrails are the ones to quote: inventory loss %, fill rate (share of items ordered that are in stock), delivery time, and fee complaints.

QUICK COMMERCE · ZEPTO

The fastest-growing challenger that ran into its cash

Zepto was built to be faster and leaner than everyone. In 2026 it had to pause its IPO and cut back its café.

Who it is for. Young urban households and students who value speed and variety. Positioning: "groceries and more in 10 minutes", with a sharper, younger brand than Blinkit. Zepto was founded in 2021 by two Stanford dropouts and grew faster than any Indian consumer company of its time.

Core loop. A late-night need → Zepto opens to a fast, image-heavy home screen → order → delivered in about 10 minutes → the next unplanned need goes to Zepto too. **Zepto Pass**, its membership, adds free delivery and member prices to lock in frequency.

Zepto home, annotated

A store built for impulse, not for a list

1 ETA is the headline

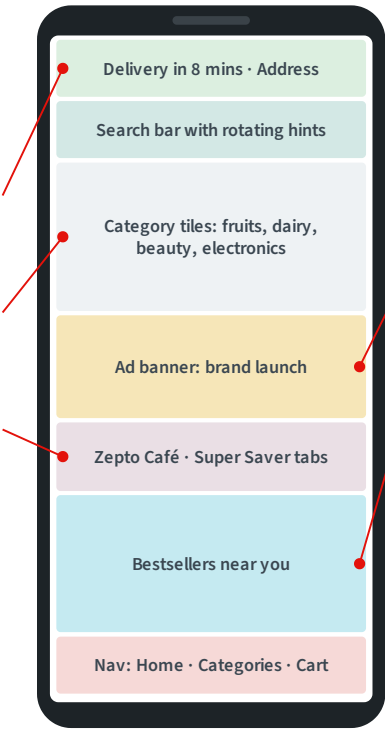
Speed is the brand. Showing 8 minutes turns a need into an order.

3 Categories beyond grocery

Beauty and electronics carry higher margins than milk. Metric: AOV and margin mix.

5 Sub-brands as tabs

Café and Super Saver target different occasions and price points.



2 Brand-paid banner

Ads are a large profit line; brands bid for the top slot.

4 Local bestsellers

Stocked for this area's demand. Metric: fill rate.

Feature	User problem	Design choice	Metric
10-minute promise	"I forgot something"	Dense dark stores, picking in ~2 minutes	Delivery time, order frequency
Zepto Pass	"Fees add up"	Membership with free delivery and member prices	Orders per member, churn
Zepto Café	"I want a coffee or snack with my groceries"	Kitchens inside dark stores	Attach rate (scaled back in 2025–26)
Super Saver	"It's cheaper at DMart"	Value range with larger packs	AOV, price-sensitive users
Ads platform for brands	Brands: "I need visibility where shoppers are"	Sponsored listings and banners	Ad revenue as % of GOV

Business model and 2026 reality. FY26 revenue was about ₹22,623 Cr, with a **net loss of ₹5,905 Cr** and an adjusted EBITDA loss of about ₹79 per order (Indian Retailer; Business Standard, Jul 2026). In July 2026 Zepto **put its IPO on hold** and chose to raise about ₹1,000 Cr privately at around \$4.5 billion, well below the ~\$7 billion it was valued at in late 2025. Dark-store expansion slowed, and **Zepto Café cut stores and menu items** (Business Standard, Sep 2026). Zepto has had the highest orders per store in the industry. Its problem is not demand but **the cash needed to reach maturity** across a young store network.

Moat. Operational speed (process power) and a young brand. Weaker than Blinkit on density and parent-company cash. Easy multi-homing: most users also have Blinkit.

Metrics. *North Star:* orders per week from repeat customers. *Inputs:* orders per store per day, AOV, fill rate, share of mature stores. *Guardrails:* contribution per order, cash burn per month, inventory loss.

What I would build next at Zepto

- 1. **Planned-basket mode.** *Problem:* the monthly grocery shop still goes to DMart or BigBasket. *Bet:* a "monthly list" that delivers in a chosen slot at lower cost, using spare rider capacity in the afternoon. *Metric:* AOV of planned orders; rider utilisation off-peak.
- 2. **Store-level P&L cockpit for brands.** *Problem:* brands cannot see which stores sell their products. *Bet:* self-serve store-level sales and ad results. *Metric:* ad revenue per brand; brand retention.

QUICK COMMERCE · SWIGGY INSTAMART

Bigger baskets, fewer users, first breakeven

Instamart chose profit over size in 2026. It dropped four million unprofitable users and pushed basket size to the highest in the industry.

Who it is for. Swiggy's food customers first, and increasingly families doing larger top-up shops. Positioning: "everything for your home, in minutes", with a standalone Instamart app alongside the Swiggy app.

Core loop. A Swiggy food user sees Instamart in the same app → tries it → Swiggy One gives free delivery on both → the household's grocery top-ups move to Instamart.

Feature	User problem	Design choice	Metric
Megapods (larger dark stores)	"They never have what I need"	10,000+ SKUs in bigger stores	Fill rate, AOV
Maxxsaver-style basket offers	Swiggy: "Small baskets lose money"	Discounts unlocked above a basket value	AOV (about ₹700)
Swiggy One	"Separate fees for food and groceries"	One membership for both	Cross-category users
400+ brand partnerships	"I want premium and new brands"	Exclusive launches, bundles	Margin mix, ad revenue

Business model. Q1 FY27 GOV was ₹7,907 Cr with contribution margin at +0.2% of GOV, after breakeven in May 2026. The margin had been at -5.6% as recently as Q4 FY25. There are **1,171 dark stores in 131 cities**, and over 45% of stores are contribution-positive. Swiggy deliberately **shed over 4 million unprofitable users** (Inc42, Jul 2026). Adjusted revenue per order is about ₹108.

Strengths and weaknesses. Shared fleet and membership with food, and the highest AOV in the industry. But it is number three by share, has fewer stores than Blinkit, and its parent is still loss-making.

What I would build next at Instamart

1. **"Cook tonight" bundles.** *Problem:* users decide on dinner and then hunt for ten ingredients. *Bet:* recipes from Swiggy's food data turned into one-tap ingredient carts. *Metric:* AOV; cross-use of food and Instamart.
2. **Household restock predictions.** *Problem:* running out of staples. *Bet:* "You usually buy atta every 18 days; add it?" *Metric:* repeat orders; share of planned items.

GROCERY · BIGBASKET

The scheduled-grocery pioneer that had to become fast

BigBasket taught India to buy vegetables online. Quick commerce then made its core promise feel slow.

Who it is for. Families who buy fresh produce and do a large weekly shop, and who value quality and range. Owned by the **Tata group** since 2021 and linked to the **Tata Neu** app and loyalty points.

What changed. BigBasket built India's best supply chain for fresh produce around next-day delivery slots. As Blinkit and Zepto made 10 minutes normal, it moved its whole consumer business to **BB Now**, delivering in 15–30 minutes, by August 2024. It also runs **BB Daily** (morning milk subscriptions) and a B2B arm, and it is testing quick food.

Business model. FY26 revenue was ₹10,498 Cr (+6%) and the consolidated loss widened **59% to ₹3,192 Cr** (MediaNama, Sep 2026). The consumer arm lost ₹3,073 Cr on ₹8,223 Cr of revenue. Advertising revenue grew 19% to ₹242 Cr. Parent Tata Digital lost ₹4,974 Cr, about 64% of it from BigBasket (Inc42).

Moat and weakness. It has real **process power** in fresh-produce sourcing and quality. The weakness is that it arrived late to speed, grew only 6%, and has a weaker app habit than the leaders.

What I would build next at BigBasket

1. **"Freshness guarantee" as the brand.** *Problem:* quick-commerce produce quality is inconsistent. *Bet:* farm-date labels and no-questions replacement on fruit and vegetables. *Metric:* share of orders with fresh items; complaint rate.
2. **Tata Neu household bundle.** *Problem:* Tata's customers are spread across many apps. *Bet:* BB Daily plus BB Now plus NeuCoins as one household plan. *Metric:* households with two or more Tata services.

QUICK COMMERCE · AMAZON FRESH AND AMAZON NOW

The patient giant

Amazon is using India as its global test lab for delivery in minutes, backed by Prime and a balance sheet no startup can match.

Who it is for. Amazon's existing customers, especially **Prime members**, who already trust Amazon for everything else. **Amazon Fresh** offers scheduled grocery slots in many cities. **Amazon Now** is its delivery-in-minutes service, launched in Bengaluru in 2025.

The strategy. Andy Jassy said on his June 2026 India visit that Amazon Now orders had **"doubled every quarter since launch"** and that Prime members **triple their shopping frequency** after they start using it. The plan is to go from 15+ cities to **300+ cities**, with micro and urban fulfilment centres stocking groceries, beauty, fashion and electronics (Outlook Business, Jun 2026). Amazon's advantages are the Prime base, supplier relationships, an ads business that already knows what each shopper buys, and the ability to lose money for years.

Risk. Amazon arrives late in cities where Blinkit and Zepto have density. It has a history of pausing India experiments. And quick commerce's fixed costs punish anyone without scale.

What I would build next at Amazon Now

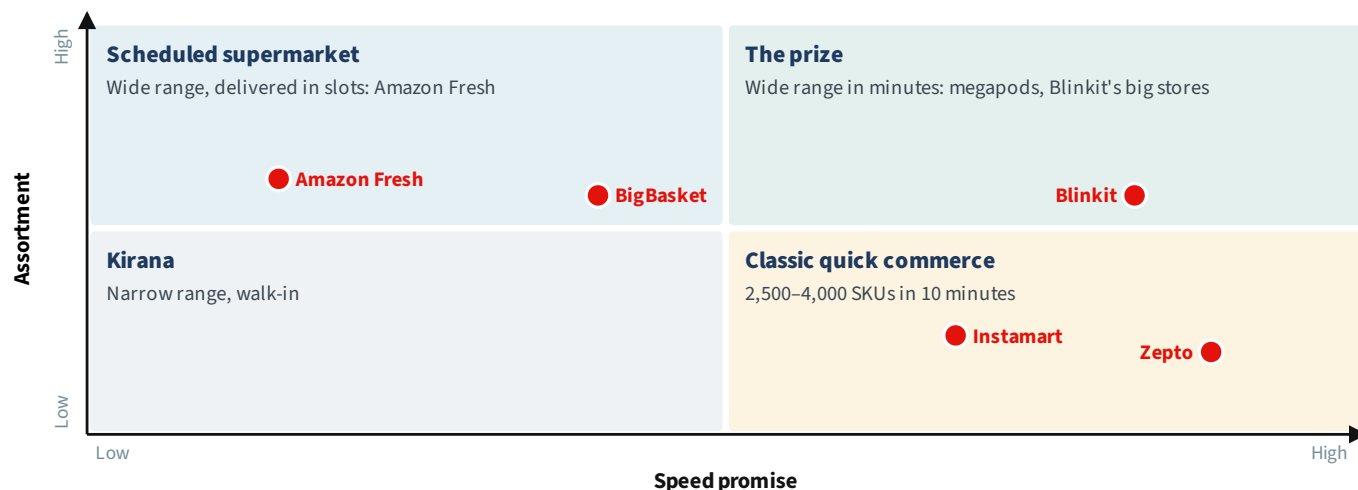
1. **Prime "Now" pass inside Prime.** *Problem:* Prime members don't think of Amazon for a 10-minute need. *Bet:* free minutes-delivery for Prime above a basket value. *Metric:* Now orders per Prime member; Prime renewal rate.
2. **Scheduled plus instant in one cart.** *Problem:* a user wants milk now and a microwave tomorrow. *Bet:* one checkout that splits delivery speeds automatically. *Metric:* AOV; cross-category orders.

Comparing the players

	Blinkit	Zepto	Instamart	BigBasket	Amazon Now
Stores	2,443	Fewer, highest orders per store	1,171	BB Now network	Scaling to 300+ cities
Latest economics	Adj. EBITDA +₹102 Cr (Q1 FY27)	FY26 loss ₹5,905 Cr	CM +0.2%	FY26 loss ₹3,192 Cr	Not disclosed
Edge	Density, 1P margins, ads	Speed, orders per store	AOV, shared fleet	Fresh supply chain	Prime, capital, ads
Main risk	Store capex, inventory	Cash runway	Scale gap	Slow growth	Late to density

Assortment versus speed promise

Where each format sits (author's judgement)



Likely interview questions

1. "Blinkit's AOV fell from ₹525 to ₹518 in a quarter. Is that bad?" Not necessarily. New users and new cities have smaller baskets. Split the change by cohort and category before judging.
2. "How many dark stores does a city of 50 lakh people need?" Serviceable households $\times$ order frequency $\div$ orders one store can handle per day. Then check that each store sits within a 2–3 km radius.
3. "Should Zepto keep Zepto Café?" Compare its contribution per order with the lift it gives grocery frequency. Kill it if it is only adding cost.
4. "Design a feature to increase basket size without discounts." Options include complete-the-recipe carts, bundles, and a free-delivery threshold. Guardrail: users must not feel manipulated.
5. "Why is Amazon a threat even though it is late?" Prime frequency, ads data, capital, and existing supplier terms.
6. "Delivery times went up by 2 minutes in Pune. Diagnose." Check picking time against riding time, rider supply at peak, store stock-outs forcing substitutions, and new stores still learning demand.

Recall: quick commerce

1. What is a dark store, and why does a new one lose money for months?
2. Name the three biggest cost lines on a quick-commerce order and the two biggest revenue lines beyond product margin.
3. Why did Blinkit's shift to a 1P inventory model need a change in who owns Eternal?
4. What did Instamart give up to reach contribution breakeven?
5. What is "drip pricing", and where on a checkout screen does it appear?
6. Give three reasons Zepto paused its IPO in 2026.
7. (Food delivery) Why does density matter even more in quick commerce than in food delivery?

PRODUCT DOSSIER • RIDE HAILING

The marketplace that must work in the next four minutes

Uber leads cabs, Rapido leads bikes and is climbing fast, and Ola shows how a market leader can fall. The fight is now about who drivers work for, not only who riders choose.

Monday, 8:40 a.m., Silk Board junction, Bengaluru. A software engineer is late for a 9:30 meeting. A cab would take 55 minutes and cost ₹420. A bike taxi weaving through traffic would take 25 minutes and cost ₹110. She books the bike. Uber, Ola and Rapido spend

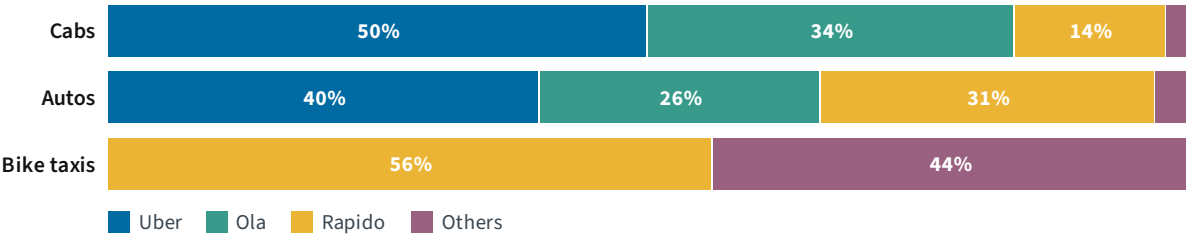
most of their product effort on this four-minute window: how long a ride takes to arrive, whether the driver accepts, whether he cancels, and whether the price feels fair.

The job, and the market

Riders hire ride hailing for "get me there reliably, at a price I expected, and safely." Drivers hire it for "fill my day with paying rides and let me keep as much of the fare as possible." Unlike food delivery there is no restaurant in between. That makes this a pure **two-sided marketplace**, and it makes the balance between the two sides unforgiving: if a rider waits too long they leave, and if a driver waits too long between rides they log off.

Who leads each type of ride

Approximate share of rides by vehicle type in India, 2025 (%)

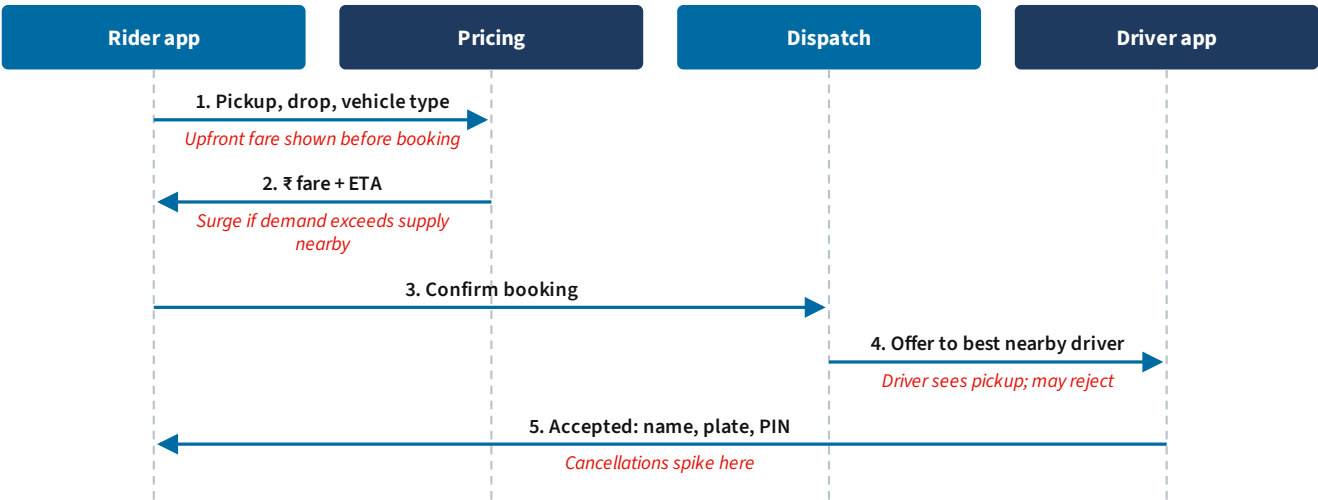


Rapido leads bikes and is now the main challenger in autos and cabs; Uber's CEO has called it his biggest competitor in India.

Source: Industry estimates compiled by Equentis and press reports (2025); shares are approximate and vary by city

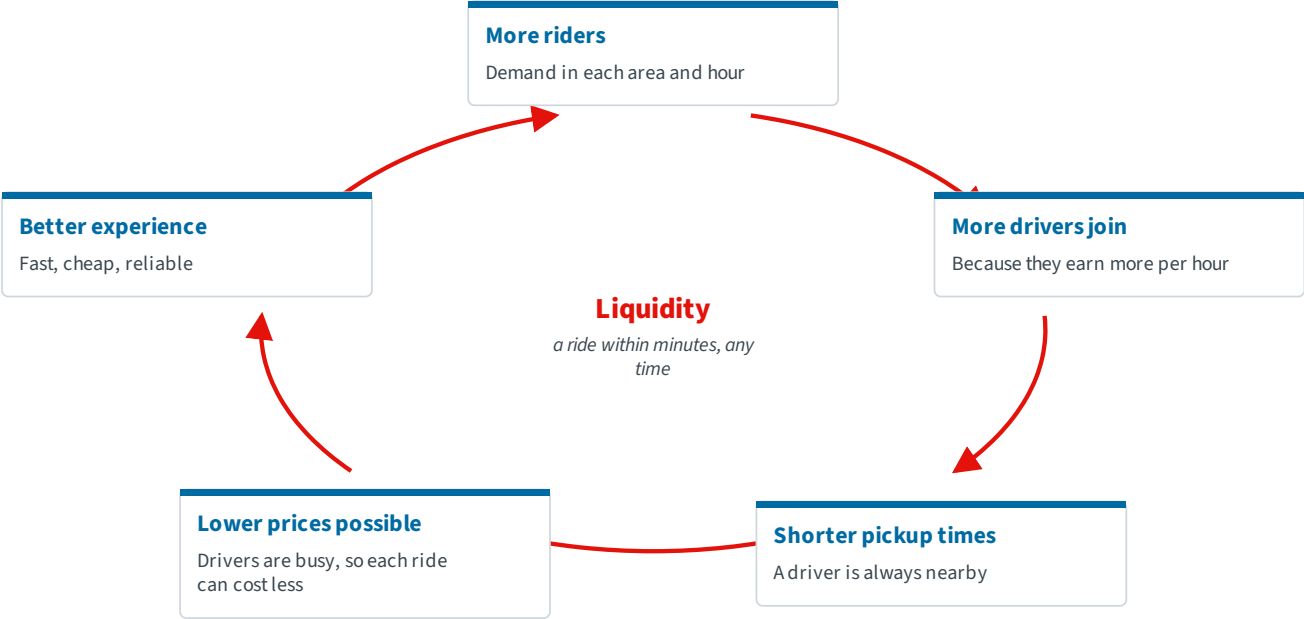
What happens in the first minute of a ride request

Matching is the product; everything else is decoration



The liquidity flywheel

Uber's founding logic, which every ride app still runs on



The big shift of 2025–26: commission versus subscription

Traditionally the app kept 20–30% of each fare as commission. Rapido charged drivers a flat daily or monthly subscription instead (₹5–29 a day or about ₹500 a month depending on city, per Inc42), and let them keep the whole fare. Uber adopted the model for autos in February 2025, and Ola rolled out "zero commission" nationwide in June 2025 (about ₹67 a day). The platform's revenue no longer rises with each ride. It rises with the number of drivers who pay the subscription.

Commission versus subscription, for a driver doing 12 rides a day

Why drivers moved; illustrative ₹300 average fare

Commission model	Subscription model
● Platform keeps ~25% of each ₹300 fare = ₹75 per ride, ₹900 a day	● Platform keeps A flat ~₹30–70 a day, whatever the rides
● Driver's view The more I drive, the more I pay	● Driver's view Predictable cost; busy days are mine
● Platform's view Revenue grows with every ride	● Platform's view Cheaper fares win riders, but revenue no longer grows per ride

Subscription wins drivers and lets fares fall 10–15%. It works as long as the platform earns from volume elsewhere: ads, financing, insurance, delivery.

Source: Illustrative; subscription fee range from Inc42 (2025)

RIDE HAILING • UBER

The global benchmark, adapted for India

Uber is profitable worldwide and uses India to test products for the rest of the world: autos, bikes, buses and a subscription for drivers.

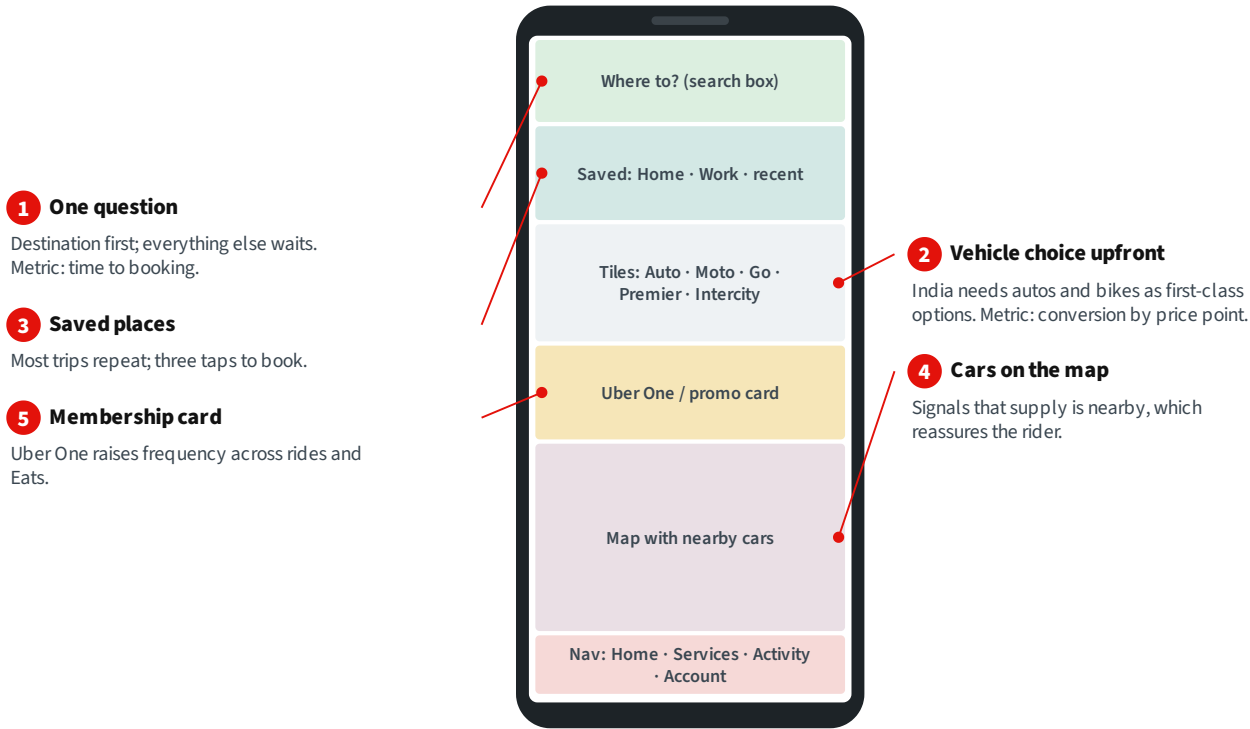
Who it is for. Riders who value reliability and safety over the lowest price, and business travellers. Positioning: "go anywhere, get anything." Globally Uber's quarterly **gross bookings reached \$58.0 billion (+22%) in Q2 2026**, with **3.9 billion trips, 208 million monthly active customers** and **\$2.8 billion of adjusted EBITDA**. Trailing free cash flow passed \$10 billion (Uber Q2 2026 release). India is one of its largest markets by trips.

Core loop. Open → "Where to?" → pick a vehicle type from a list with prices → a driver arrives in minutes → ride → rate → the saved places and payment method make the next booking three taps.

First run. Phone number, OTP, and optional payment set-up (cash is allowed in India, which removes a big barrier). The riskiest moment is the **first ride**: a long ETA or a driver cancellation sends the new user to a rival app.

Uber home screen, annotated

One question on the screen: where to?



Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Upfront pricing	"Will the meter cheat me?"	Fixed fare shown before booking	Booking conversion, disputes
Ride PIN	"Is this the right car?"	Rider tells a 4-digit PIN to start the trip (India-first)	Safety incidents, wrong pickups
Share trip, SOS, RideCheck	"I don't feel safe at night"	Live location to family; alerts on unusual stops	Night-time rides, safety NPS
Auto, Moto, Shuttle, Intercity	"A cab is too expensive for this trip"	A mode for every budget and distance	Trips per user
Zero-commission autos (2025)	Drivers: "Commission eats my earnings"	Daily subscription	Active auto drivers, ETA
Uber One and Uber for Business	"I ride often and want perks"; companies need travel billing	Membership; central billing	Frequency; B2B trips

Business model. Globally Uber earns a take rate on gross bookings, plus advertising, membership and delivery. In India it now combines commission (cabs) with subscription (autos). Its economics depend on **utilisation**: the share of a driver's logged-in time spent carrying a paying rider.

Moat. Network effects that are *local*, city by city. Global scale economies in mapping, pricing and safety technology. Brand trust. The weakness is that drivers and riders use several apps at once, and in India a cheaper rival can win a city fast.

Metrics. *North Star*: completed trips. *Inputs*: ETA at pickup, request-to-completion rate, active drivers at peak, driver utilisation. *Guardrails*: rider and driver cancellation rates, safety incidents per million trips, driver earnings per hour, surge frequency.

What I would build next at Uber India

1. **Commute passes.** *Problem*: office-goers pay surge prices at 9 a.m. every day. *Bet*: a weekly pass for a fixed route and time, priced below average surge, with guaranteed pickup. *Metric*: weekday trips per pass holder; driver utilisation at peak.
2. **Cancellation-proof matching.** *Problem*: drivers accept and then cancel when they see the drop location or the payment mode. *Bet*: show drop area and payment mode before acceptance, and reward high-completion drivers with priority. *Metric*: driver cancellation rate; ETA.

RIDE HAILING • OLA

How a market leader lost its lead

Ola once had more of India's cab market than Uber. By 2026 its revenue had nearly halved and investors had written its value down to a fraction of its peak.

Who it was for. Indian riders in every tier of city. Ola launched in 2010 and was India's answer to Uber, with autos, bikes and local payment options early.

What happened. Revenue for Ola's ride-hailing business fell **42% to ₹1,171 Cr in FY25**, with a loss of ₹662 Cr (company filings reported in the press). One investor marked the company down to a small fraction of its once-\$7 billion-plus valuation, and a loan of about \$65 million falls due in December 2026. The causes are worth learning as a pattern:

- **Divided attention.** Leadership time and money went to Ola Electric (scooters, listed separately), Krutrim (AI), and other ventures.
- **Driver trust.** Complaints about payouts and incentives pushed drivers towards rivals. In a two-sided market, losing drivers means losing riders a few weeks later.
- **Service quality.** High cancellation rates and customer-support complaints hurt its reputation with riders.
- **A late response to Rapido.** Ola moved to zero commission in June 2025, after Rapido had already won the loyalty of drivers.

What it built well. **Ola Maps**, an in-house mapping stack that replaced Google Maps in 2024 to cut costs, and early work on electric fleets.

What I would build next at Ola (a turnaround plan)

1. **Win back drivers first.** *Problem*: supply is the constraint. *Bet*: guaranteed minimum hourly earnings in five core cities for 90 days, funded by closing weak cities. *Metric*: active drivers at peak; ETA.
2. **Fix the first ride.** *Problem*: returning users had bad experiences. *Bet*: a "no cancellation" guarantee with automatic credit when a driver cancels. *Metric*: 30-day retention of reactivated riders.

RIDE HAILING • RAPIDO

The bike taxi that rewrote the rules

Rapido started with the cheapest possible ride, a seat on the back of a motorbike, then changed how drivers are paid. It is now the challenger everyone copies.

Who it is for. Price-sensitive commuters, students and workers in traffic-heavy cities and tier-2 towns. Positioning: *"the fastest, cheapest way through traffic."* Rapido operates in **400+ cities** and raised **\$240 million at a \$3 billion valuation** in 2026, led by Prosus (Yahoo Finance, 2026).

Core loop. A cheap bike ride → saves time in traffic → becomes a daily commute habit → the same user tries Rapido autos and cabs → cheaper fares, because drivers pay no commission, keep users loyal.

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Bike taxi	"Traffic makes cabs slow and expensive"	Two-wheelers are fast and cost a fraction of a cab	Trips per user
Driver subscription (no commission)	Drivers: "I lose a quarter of every fare"	Flat daily/monthly fee	Driver supply, fares 10–15% lower
Autos and cabs on the same app	"I need a bigger vehicle sometimes"	Cross-sell to existing riders	Share of non-bike trips
Ownly (food delivery, 2025)	Restaurants: "Commissions are too high"	Uses Rapido's fleet; lower commission	Orders, rider utilisation
Parcel delivery	"I need to send keys across town"	Same bikes, same app	Off-peak utilisation

Business model. Subscription fees from drivers, rather than commission, plus delivery and parcel services. The subscription makes Rapido cheaper for riders, which is **counter-positioning**: Uber and Ola would have to give up their commission income to match it. They partly did.

Risk. Bike taxis are illegal in some states or face bans. Karnataka's mid-2025 ban was a serious blow in Rapido's home market. Revenue that does not rise with rides has to be made up elsewhere. Food delivery puts Rapido up against Zomato and Swiggy.

Metrics. *North Star*: completed trips per week. *Inputs*: subscribed active drivers, ETA, share of trips outside bikes, trips per rider. *Guardrails*: safety incidents, regulatory status by state, driver churn.

What I would build next at Rapido

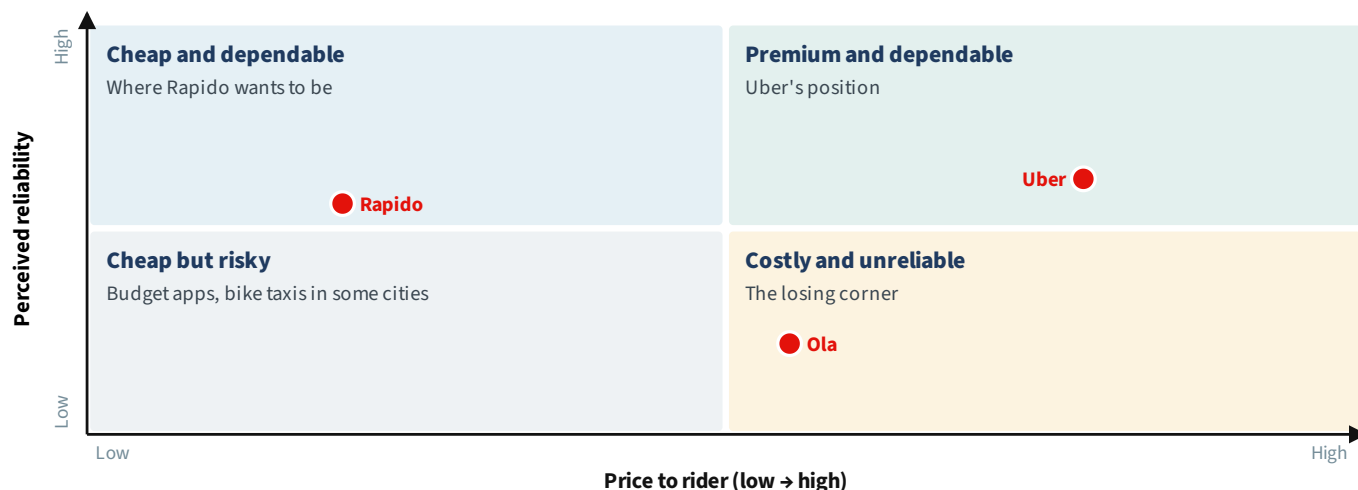
- 1. Women-safe bike rides.** *Problem*: many women avoid bike taxis for safety. *Bet*: opt-in women drivers, live trip sharing, helmet hygiene kits. *Metric*: share of women riders; safety incidents.
- 2. Driver financing.** *Problem*: many drivers want to own an EV bike but lack credit. *Bet*: partner loans repaid through the daily subscription. *Metric*: drivers financed; driver retention at 12 months.

Comparing the three

	Uber	Ola	Rapido
Positioning	Reliable, safe, global	Indian, all vehicle types	Cheapest, fastest in traffic
Driver model	Commission (cabs) + subscription (autos)	Zero commission (subscription)	Subscription
Strength	Brand, technology, profits globally	Maps, EV experience	Bikes, low fares, driver loyalty
Weakness	Higher prices	Lost trust, weak finances	Regulation, thin revenue per ride
Next frontier	Autonomy (globally), commute products	Survival	Food, parcels, cabs

Price versus reliability

How riders perceive each app in 2026 (author's judgement)



Likely interview questions

1. **"Uber ride cancellations spiked 20% this week. Diagnose."** (IIMA casebook) Split by who cancelled (rider or driver), city, vehicle type, and payment mode. Check any change in dispatch or pricing. A new fare rule often makes drivers cancel long trips.
2. **"Should Uber move cabs to the subscription model?"** Model driver supply and fare elasticity against lost commission income. Pilot it in one city. Guardrail: ETA and driver earnings.
3. **"Design Ola for school children."** (IIMA) The parent is the customer and the child the user. Think verified drivers, fixed routes, live tracking, and pickup PINs.
4. **"What metric would you use for a ride-hailing marketplace?"** Completed trips, balanced by ETA (rider side) and utilisation (driver side), with cancellation and safety as guardrails.
5. **"How would you launch Rapido in a new tier-2 city?"** Recruit drivers before riders, focus on a few busy corridors to build density, and offer a launch fare.
6. **"Why did Ola lose share?"** Talk about leadership focus, driver trust, service quality and a late response to the rival's pricing model.

Recall: ride hailing

1. Why is liquidity the core product of a ride-hailing app? Draw the flywheel from memory.
2. Explain commission versus subscription from a driver's and a platform's point of view.
3. What is counter-positioning, and how did Rapido use it?
4. Name four India-specific features in Uber's app and the problem each one solves.
5. Give three reasons Ola lost its lead.
6. Pick a North Star, two input metrics and two guardrails for a ride-hailing app.
7. (Quick commerce) How is a new dark store's losing phase similar to launching ride hailing in a new city?

PRODUCT DOSSIER • E-COMMERCE

Selection, trust and the festive sale

Flipkart owns Bharat and the big sale. Amazon owns Prime households and the flywheel. Myntra shows how a focused vertical can out-earn both. All three are now being squeezed by zero-commission rivals and ten-minute delivery.

October, 11:59 p.m. Three million people in India have Flipkart open, thumbs hovering, waiting for the Big Billion Days sale to start at midnight. A phone they have watched for weeks will drop by ₹8,000 with a bank card offer, an exchange bonus for their old phone,

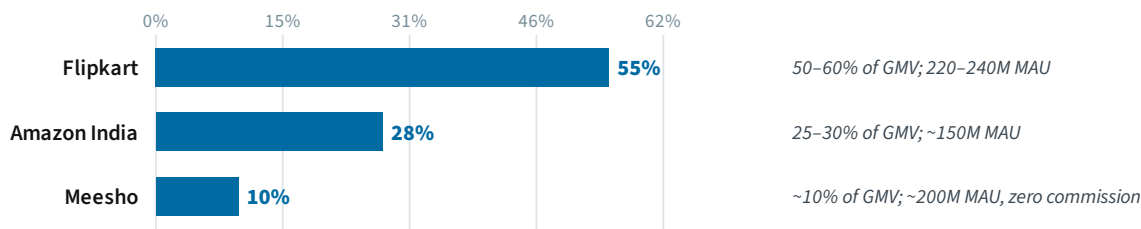
and a no-cost EMI. By 12:10 a.m. several models are sold out. For many Indian households this sale is e-commerce: a planned, once-a-year purchase of the phone, the TV or the fridge. The 2026 edition begins on 9 October.

The job, and the market

Shoppers hire e-commerce for **"the widest choice at the best price, delivered to my door, with easy returns if it goes wrong."** Sellers hire it for **"customers across India I could never reach from my shop."** In India, trust is part of the job. Cash on delivery (COD), easy returns and brand guarantees exist because many buyers still worry about getting a fake or broken product.

India's e-commerce market, FY25

Share of gross merchandise value (GMV) and monthly active users, approximate



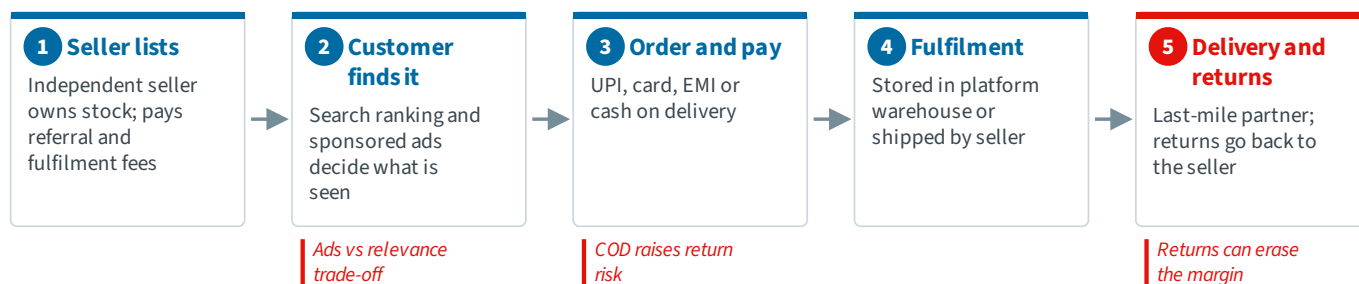
Source: ICICI Securities via Entracker (2026). Market ~\$70B GMV in FY25; smartphones are 30–40% of GMV

Three rules shape Indian e-commerce and appear in almost every interview answer.

- 1. Foreign-owned marketplaces cannot own inventory.** India's FDI rules make Amazon and Walmart-owned Flipkart act as *marketplaces*: independent sellers own the stock, and the platform charges fees. This is why "seller" programmes and seller fees matter so much in India.
- 2. Returns and COD are costly.** A cancelled COD order sent back to the warehouse (**RTO**, return to origin) costs shipping both ways and earns nothing.
- 3. Ads are now a major profit line.** E-commerce and retail media were worth about **₹22,000 Cr in 2025, 23% of India's digital ad spend, up 50%** (FICCI-EY, Mar 2026). Sponsored listings earn money on every search.

The marketplace, explained

Who does what in a typical Amazon or Flipkart order



E-COMMERCE • AMAZON

The flywheel company

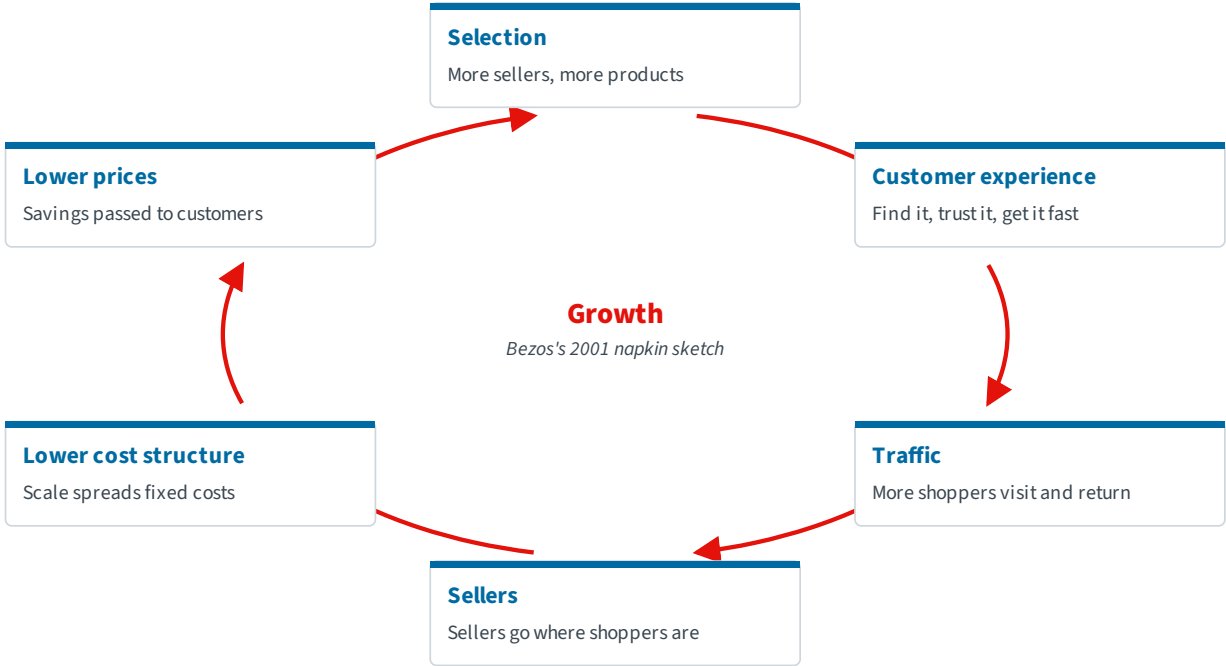
Amazon runs the same loop everywhere: more selection and lower prices bring more customers, which bring more sellers. In India it adds Prime, ads and now delivery in minutes.

Who it is for. Urban and metro households, especially **Prime members** who want reliability, fast delivery and genuine products. Positioning: *"Earth's most customer-centric company."* Globally Amazon's **Q2 2026 revenue was \$200.6 billion (+20%)**. AWS grew 37% and advertising 26% (Amazon Q2 2026 results).

Core loop. This is the famous flywheel Jeff Bezos sketched on a napkin in 2001.

The Amazon flywheel

Every part speeds up the next; lower costs keep it spinning



First run. Browsing needs no login, and search works immediately. The login comes at checkout, where saved addresses and UPI make repeat purchases fast. For new users the key moment is the **first delivery**: arriving on the promised date is what makes them trust Amazon.

Amazon.in app home, annotated

Search, Prime and speed compete for the top of the screen

1 Search is the product

Most purchases start with a typed query. The AI assistant answers questions like 'best phone under ₹20k'.

3 Speed as a tab

Amazon Now puts delivery in minutes one tap from the main store.

5 Personal history

Picks up where the user left off; raises return visits.

2 Bank-offer banners

Card and EMI offers decide big-ticket purchases in India.

4 Sponsored slots

Ads earn on every scroll. Guardrail: sales per search must not fall.

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Prime (full, Lite, shopping-only plans)	"Delivery fees and waits"	Free fast delivery plus video and music; cheaper tiers for India	Prime members, orders per member
Alexa for Shopping (formerly Rufus)	"Which one should I buy?"	AI answers product questions from reviews and specs	Search-to-purchase conversion

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Reviews and A-to-Z guarantee	"Is it genuine? What if it breaks?"	Social proof plus a refund promise	First-order conversion, returns
Sponsored Products	Sellers: "Nobody sees my listing"	Pay-per-click ads inside search results	Ad revenue per search
Amazon Now (2025)	"I need it in minutes"	Micro fulfilment centres in cities	Prime frequency (3x for users)
Zero referral fee under ₹1,000 (2026)	Sellers: "Fees kill low-price items"	Removed for 12.5 crore products	New sellers, low-price selection

Business model. In India, Amazon earns referral and fulfilment fees from sellers, advertising, Prime fees and payments. From **16 March 2026** it removed referral fees on items under ₹1,000 across 1,800+ categories, following Flipkart and responding to Meesho (YourStory, Mar 2026). The fee income it gives up is expected to come back through more selection, more orders and more ads.

Moat. Scale economies in logistics and technology. Branding: trust in genuine products and returns. Switching costs through Prime: once you have paid for the year, you shop where the benefits are. And the data behind the ads business.

Metrics. *North Star:* purchases by active customers per month (or Prime members' annual spend). *Inputs:* selection (in-stock listings), delivery promise accuracy, search conversion, Prime sign-ups. *Guardrails:* return rate, counterfeit complaints, the share of search results that are ads, seller fee burden.

What I would build next at Amazon India

1. **Vernacular voice shopping for Bharat.** *Problem:* new internet users find text search hard. *Bet:* Alexa for Shopping in Hindi, Tamil and Bengali, with voice answers and product videos. *Metric:* first purchases by non-English users; conversion rate.
2. **"Delivery speed you choose" pricing.** *Problem:* users pay for speed they do not need, and Amazon pays for it too. *Bet:* let users pick "in minutes", "tomorrow" or "in 4 days, save ₹20". *Metric:* delivery cost per order; order frequency.

E-COMMERCE • FLIPKART

India's own marketplace, still waiting to list

Flipkart wins on phones, value and the festive sale. It is also building fintech, quick commerce and a value app, and it has pushed its IPO further out.

Who it is for. Value-conscious buyers across Bharat, first-time online shoppers, and anyone buying a smartphone. Positioning: "India's own" e-commerce, with the biggest sale of the year. Flipkart has been owned by Walmart since 2018.

Core loop. A big-ticket purchase in a sale (a phone, with EMI and exchange offer) → a positive delivery experience → the user returns for fashion and household items → Flipkart Pay Later and the co-branded card increase buying power → the next sale.

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Big Billion Days	"I wait all year for the best price on a phone or TV"	Sale events with bank offers and early access for members	Sale-period GMV, new users
Exchange offers and no-cost EMI	"I can't afford ₹25,000 at once"	Old phone value + instalments	Conversion on high-value items
Vernacular app and voice search	"I don't read English comfortably"	Hindi and regional-language shopping	Tier-2/3 user share
Shopsy	"I want very low prices"	A separate value app with low-price sellers	Users from Meesho's segment
Flipkart Minutes	"I need it now"	Quick commerce from dark stores	Frequency, share of wallet
super.money	"I pay by UPI anyway"	Flipkart's own UPI app with cashback	UPI share (~1.7%), data on spending

Business model. FY25 revenue was ₹20,493 Cr (+14%) with a loss of ₹1,494 Cr (company filings). In November 2025 Flipkart dropped commission on goods under ₹1,000, which it said would cut sellers' costs by about 30% in that price range. It moved its holding company back to India (a "reverse flip") in March 2026 ahead of a listing that has now slipped, possibly to 2028. Several senior leaders left in 2025–26.

Moat. Brand and scale in smartphones and large appliances. Exclusive phone launches. Walmart's backing. Its weaknesses are growth slower than the market, losses, and competition from both value marketplaces (Meesho) and quick commerce for the everyday purchases that build frequency.

Flipkart versus Amazon: two strategies for one market

Flipkart	Amazon India
● Customer Value-seeking, Bharat, sale-driven	● Customer Metro, Prime households
● Hero category Smartphones and appliances	● Hero category Everything, delivered reliably
● Loyalty Sales, EMI, exchange offers, Flipkart Black	● Loyalty Prime: shipping + video + music
● New bets Shopsy, Minutes, super.money	● New bets Amazon Now, Alexa for Shopping, Bazaar

Flipkart wins big moments; Amazon wins everyday habit. Both now fight quick commerce for the habit and Meesho for the price.

Metrics. *North Star:* annual transacting users. *Inputs:* purchases per user outside sale periods, share of GMV from non-phone categories, Pay Later users, Minutes orders. *Guardrails:* return and RTO rate, seller satisfaction, sale-day uptime.

What I would build next at Flipkart

- 1. "Sale-proof" price trust. *Problem:* users suspect prices are raised before a sale and then "discounted". *Bet:* show the 90-day price history on every sale item. *Metric:* sale conversion; complaints about fake discounts.
- 2. Phone lifecycle programme. *Problem:* users buy a phone every 2–3 years and forget Flipkart in between. *Bet:* protection plan + repair + guaranteed buy-back value, with reminders to upgrade. *Metric:* repeat phone purchases; protection attach rate.

E-COMMERCE • MYNTRA

The vertical that became a profit machine

Myntra, owned by Flipkart, sells one thing (fashion and beauty) to one kind of customer. In FY25 its profit rose eighteen-fold.

Who it is for. Fashion-conscious shoppers aged about 18–35, in metros and, increasingly, in smaller cities: more than 70% of Myntra's new customers in 2025 came from outside the metros. Positioning: "India's fashion destination", mid-to-premium and brand-led, distinct from Flipkart's value focus.

Core loop. Discover (feed, creators, trends) → try (size help, try-on) → buy → return if it does not fit → come back for the next occasion. Fashion is visual and driven by occasions, so Myntra works like a **media product** as well as a store: it gives users a reason to browse even when they do not need anything.

Myntra product page, annotated

The page's job is to prevent a return before the order is placed

1 Many images

Fashion is judged by eye; more angles mean fewer surprises.

3 Discount shown clearly

Fashion shoppers are deal-driven; sale events like EORS matter.

5 Wishlist as intent

Wishlists feed price-drop alerts and sale reminders.



2 Size advice from data

Fit feedback from past buyers cuts size-related returns. Metric: return rate.

4 Speed on some items

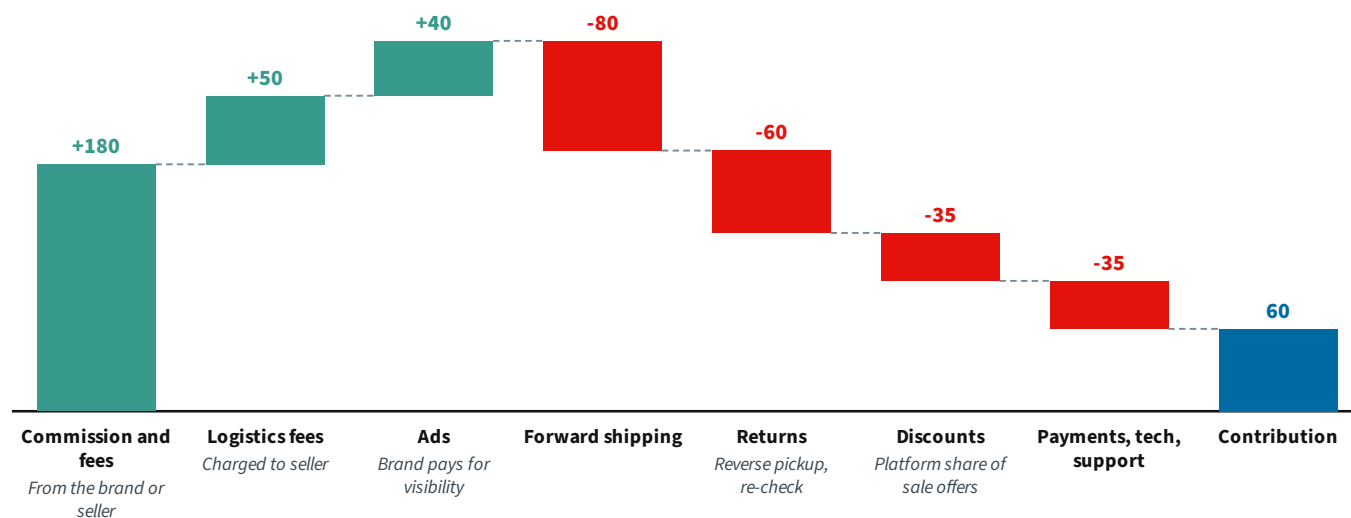
M-Now delivers fashion in about 30 minutes in 10 cities.

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
EORS (End of Reason Sale)	"I wait for sales to buy brands"	Twice-yearly sale; 2026 edition from 29 May	Sale GMV, new users
Size and fit advice	"It won't fit and I'll have to return it"	Fit data from past buyers and returns	Return rate
M-Now (30-minute fashion)	"I need an outfit for tonight"	Dark stores with ~10,000 styles in 10 cities	Occasion orders, frequency
FWD and creator content	Gen Z: "I discover fashion on Instagram"	Trend feed and a creator programme inside the app	Sessions per user
Brand ads	Brands: "I need visibility at launch"	Sponsored listings and banners	Ad revenue (+28% in FY25)

Business model. FY25 operating revenue was ₹6,043 Cr (+18%) and net profit ₹548 Cr, up 18-fold (Inc42). Revenue came from marketplace fees (₹2,052 Cr), logistics services charged to sellers (₹2,919 Cr) and **advertising (₹915 Cr, +28%)**. Ads are the main driver of profit growth.

Where the money goes on a ₹1,000 fashion order

₹ per order, illustrative; returns are the line that makes fashion hard



Cutting return rates by a few points is worth more than most new features.

Source: Illustrative; revenue mix direction from Myntra FY25 filings (Inc42)

Moat. Brand relationships (exclusive labels and launches), a clear fashion identity, and fit data that improves with every return. It is also protected from being a pure price competitor because it sells brands, not commodities.

Metrics. *North Star:* net GMV after returns. *Inputs:* monthly transacting users, orders per user, AOV, return rate, ad revenue per brand. *Guardrails:* customer NPS on returns, delivery promise accuracy, ad load in the feed.

What I would build next at Myntra

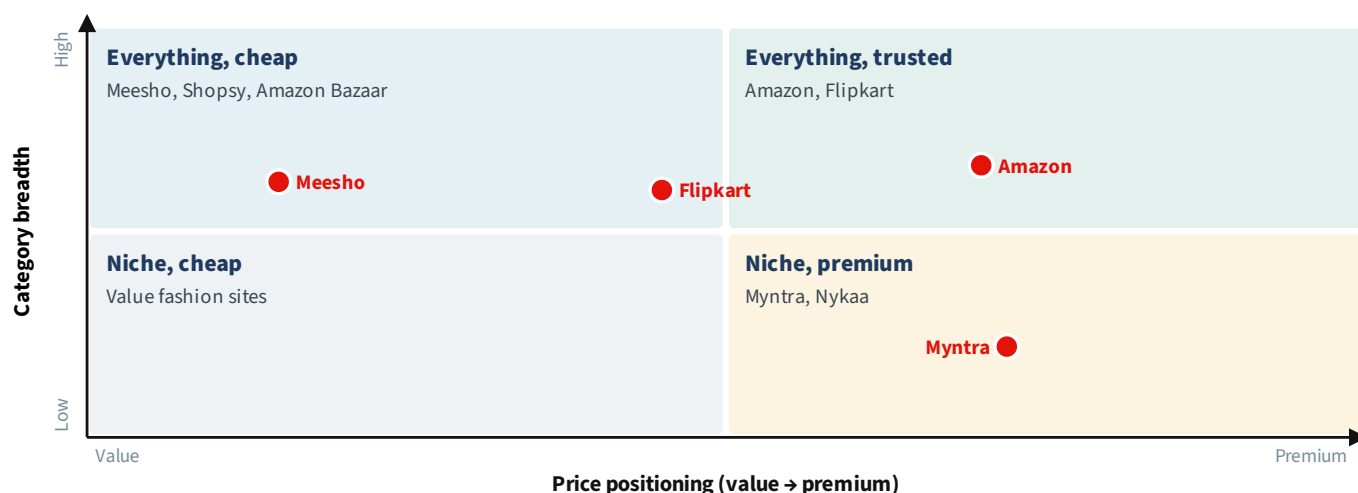
- Occasion planner.** *Problem:* shoppers buy for weddings, festivals and trips, and search one item at a time. *Bet:* an "occasion" mode that builds a full look within budget with delivery by a date. *Metric:* items per order; conversion of occasion sessions.
- Fit profile you carry across brands.** *Problem:* sizes differ by brand. *Bet:* a personal fit profile that translates your size for every brand. *Metric:* size-related returns; first-purchase conversion with new brands.

Comparing the three

	Amazon India	Flipkart	Myntra
Core customer	Metro, Prime households	Value-seeking, Bharat, phones	Fashion-conscious, 18–35
Loyalty engine	Prime	Sales, EMI, exchange	Sales (EORS), content
Profit drivers	Seller fees, ads, Prime	Seller fees, ads, fintech	Fees, logistics, ads
Speed bet	Amazon Now	Flipkart Minutes	M-Now
Main threat	Quick commerce, Meesho	Meesho, quick commerce, IPO delay	Returns, Instagram-native brands

Category breadth versus price positioning

Where each player sits (author's judgement)



Likely interview questions

1. **"Cart additions have declined 10% on Amazon. Diagnose."** (IIMA casebook) Is the fall in sessions, product views or add-to-cart rate? Check prices, stock, a UI change, and competitor sales.
2. **"Amazon wants to cut Prime's price. Should it?"** (IIMA casebook) Look at elasticity by segment, the cost of benefits, and cannibalisation. Test a cheaper tier instead of cutting the main price.
3. **"How would you reduce returns on Myntra?"** Target size-related returns first with fit data, better images and reviews. Guardrail: conversion rate.
4. **"Should Flipkart compete with Meesho on price?"** Shopsy lets it compete without cheapening the main brand. Watch seller quality and fraud.
5. **"What should Amazon measure for Alexa for Shopping?"** Conversion after an assistant session versus search alone, and answer accuracy. Guardrail: returns on assistant-led purchases.
6. **"Design Big Billion Days for a first-time user from a small town."** Pre-sale education, EMI eligibility checks, a vernacular walkthrough and COD trust signals.

Recall: e-commerce

1. Why must Amazon and Flipkart run marketplaces rather than own inventory in India?
2. Draw Amazon's flywheel from memory and explain the role of "lower cost structure".
3. What is RTO, and why does cash on delivery raise it?
4. Which revenue line drove Myntra's profit growth in FY25?
5. Why did Amazon and Flipkart remove fees on low-priced items in 2025–26?
6. Give Myntra a North Star and two guardrails, and explain why returns are central.
7. (Quick commerce) How is Amazon Now's strategy different from Zepto's?

PRODUCT DOSSIER • SOCIAL MEDIA

From friends to feeds to machines that know you

Social apps began as ways to see what your friends did. Today most of what you see comes from strangers, picked by AI. The teardowns below show who adapted, who did not, and how each one makes money from your attention.

A 21-year-old in Pune opens Instagram "for a minute" at 11 p.m. The first Reel is from a comedian she does not follow. The second is a cooking hack, the third a friend's story, the fourth an ad for a skincare brand. She did not know the brand existed, but it fits her so

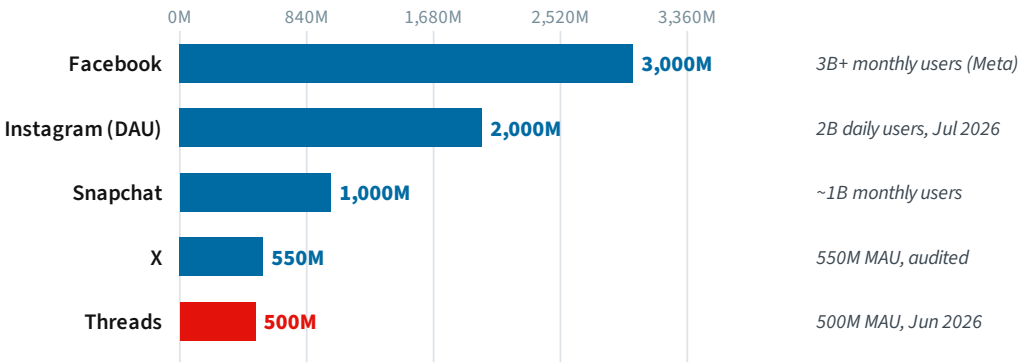
well she saves it. It is 11:40 when she puts the phone down. No friend sent her any of those Reels. A recommendation system chose them, one swipe at a time, from millions of candidates.

The job, and the market

People hire social apps for several jobs, and each app is built around one of them. **"Keep up with my people"** (Facebook's original job, Snapchat's today). **"Entertain me when I'm bored"** (Reels, TikTok-style feeds). **"Tell me what's happening and let me react"** (X, Threads). **"Show off, and be seen"** (Instagram's grid). Advertisers hire them all for one job: **"find the exact people likely to buy, and prove it worked."**

How big each network is

Latest reported users, 2026. Note the different measures: daily (DAU) vs monthly (MAU)



Source: Meta Q2 2026 call; Threads (Meta, Jun 2026); X audited figures in SpaceX S-1 (Mar 2026); Snap Q2 2026

The biggest shift of the decade is from the **social graph** (you see what people you know post) to the **interest graph** (you see whatever the algorithm predicts you will watch). TikTok proved the interest graph wins attention. Meta rebuilt Facebook and Instagram around it.

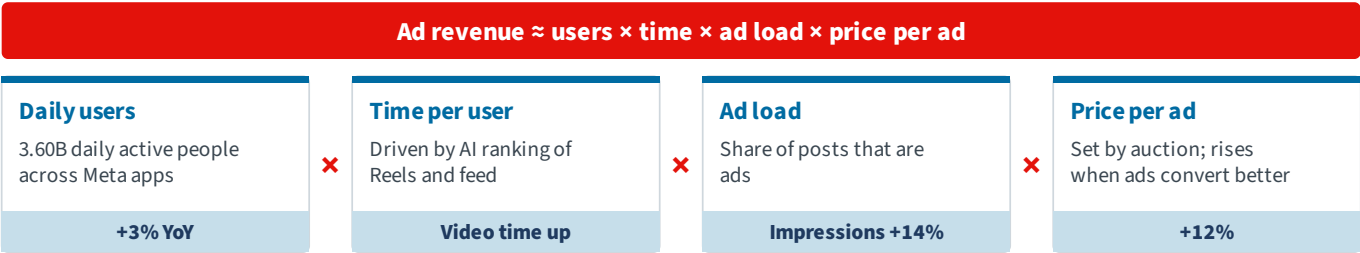
Social graph versus interest graph

Social graph (2008–2018)	Interest graph (2019–)
● What you see Posts from friends and pages you follow	● What you see Anything, from anyone, ranked by predicted interest
● Growth Invite friends; value grows with your network	● Growth Great content from strangers; works from day one
● Limit Feed runs out; friends post less over time	● Limit Weaker ties to friends; creators, not friends, supply content

The interest graph solved the cold-start problem and the 'friends stopped posting' problem. The price is that the app feels less personal, which is why Instagram keeps adding friend features.

How Meta's ad revenue is built

The formula to use in any social-media revenue question



Source: Meta Q2 2026: revenue \$60.8B (+28%); ad impressions +14%, average price per ad +12%

Price per ad rises when ads **convert better**. Meta says new AI models lifted ad conversions by up to 15.7% on Facebook, and its automated campaign product Advantage+ has reached a **\$75 billion annual run rate** (Meta Q2 2026 call). Better targeting makes

each ad worth more, advertisers bid more, and Meta earns more without showing more ads.

SOCIAL · INSTAGRAM

The app that kept reinventing itself

Instagram copied Snapchat's Stories, then TikTok's short videos, and grew each time. It now has two billion daily users and is India's favourite social app.

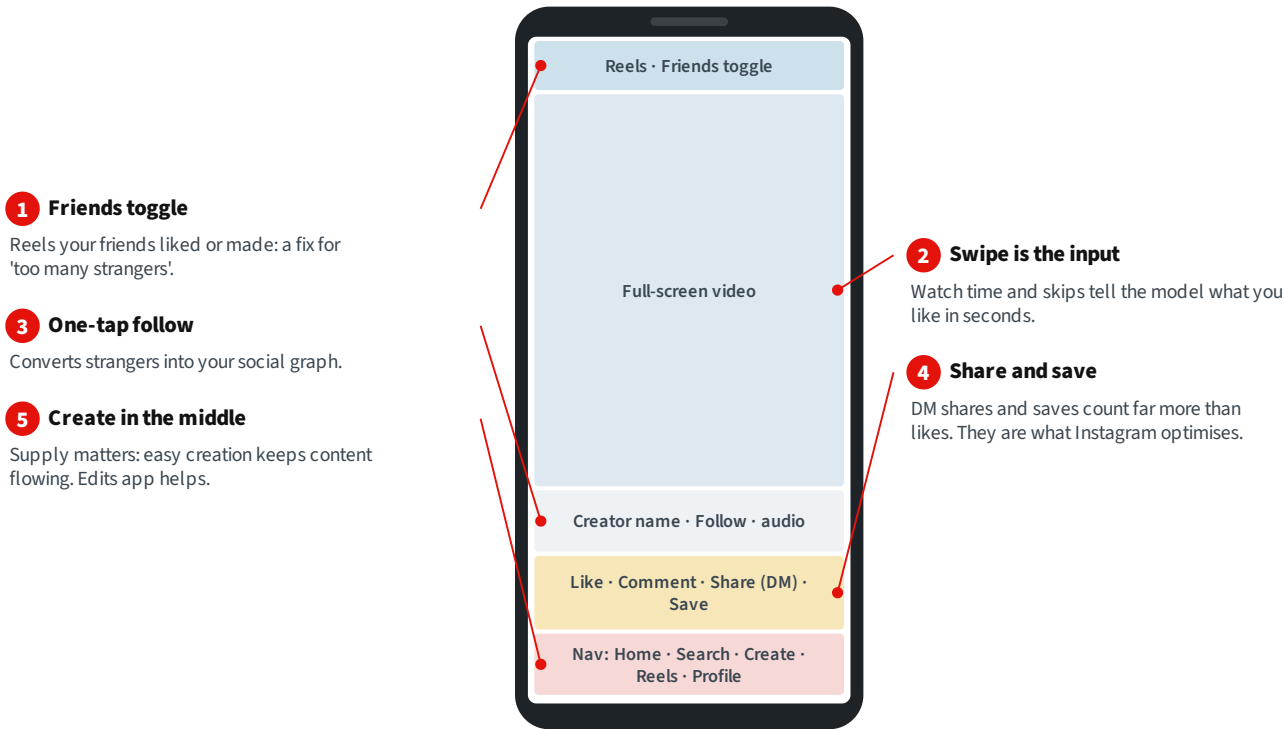
Who it is for. Everyone aged about 16–35, and creators and small businesses of every kind. India is Instagram's largest market. Positioning: "bringing you closer to the people and things you love." In practice it is three products in one: a **friends app** (Stories, DMs), an **entertainment app** (Reels), and a **shop window** for creators and brands.

Core loop. Watch Reels → share one with a friend in DMs → the friend replies and watches more → both post Stories → the algorithm learns what each person likes → more relevant Reels. Sharing in DMs is the loop Instagram now optimises hardest, because a shared Reel is a strong signal and also brings a friend back.

First run. Sign up → follow suggestions (contacts, popular accounts) → the Reels tab works immediately, even with zero follows, because it runs on the interest graph. An empty feed used to be the biggest risk. Reels removed it.

Instagram Reels tab, annotated

One full-screen video; every button is a signal to the ranking system



Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Reels (up to 3 min)	"I'm bored; entertain me"	Full-screen, AI-ranked, endless	Time spent, DAU
Stories and Close Friends	"I want to share without a permanent post"	Disappears in 24 hours; smaller audience	Posting frequency
DMs, Blend, reposts	"I want to talk about what I watched"	Share Reels into chats; shared feeds with friends	Sends per user, DAU
Trial Reels	Creators: "Will my followers hate this?"	Test a Reel on non-followers first	Creator posting rate
Your Algorithm	"My feed feels random"	Users see and edit the topics Instagram thinks they like	Satisfaction, session quality
Edits (separate app)	Creators: "Editing needs another app"	Meta's own video editor	Reels uploaded

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Teen Accounts	Parents: "Is my child safe?"	Private by default, content limits, sleep mode	Regulatory risk, parent trust

Business model. Advertising: feed, Stories and Reels ads, bought through Meta's auction. Creators earn through brand deals, subscriptions and gifts. Instagram's revenue is not reported separately. It is the largest growth engine inside Meta's Family of Apps.

Moat. Network effects (your friends and favourite creators are here). Scale economies in AI: more users produce more data, which gives better ranking and better ads. Switching costs: your profile, followers and DMs. Branding among young users.

Metrics. *North Star:* daily active users who share or create (not only watch). *Inputs:* Reels watch time, DM sends per user, creator uploads, follow rate from Reels. *Guardrails:* time-well-spent surveys, teen safety reports, ad load, creator churn.

What I would build next at Instagram

1. **"Local now" Reels for India.** *Problem:* users want to know what's happening in their own city (events, food, traffic). *Bet:* a city channel mixing creators and local businesses, with maps. *Metric:* local sessions per user; local business ad spend.
2. **Creator storefront with UPI.** *Problem:* Indian creators sell through DMs and payment screenshots. *Bet:* native product tags and UPI checkout in DMs. *Metric:* creator GMV; creators earning monthly.

SOCIAL · THREADS

Meta's fast follower

Threads borrowed Instagram's social graph to skip the cold-start problem. It reached 500 million monthly users in three years.

Who it is for. People who want text-based public conversation without X's toxicity or politics. Positioning: *"a new, open space for real-time conversation."*

How it launched. On day one in July 2023, users could sign in with Instagram and import their followers. That borrowed an existing **atomic network**, the smallest group that makes a network useful, so new users saw activity immediately. 100 million sign-ups came in five days. Many then drifted away, which is a lesson in itself: *borrowed graphs bring sign-ups; content and habit bring retention.*

Features that fixed retention. Direct messages, **Communities** (topic groups that came out of beta in 2026), **Live Chats** during events, **ghost posts** that disappear after 24 hours, and **Your Algo**, which lets users tell the feed what to show for 1, 3 or 7 days (TechCrunch, Jun 2026). Ads now run on Threads globally.

Results. **500 million monthly users in June 2026**, up 100 million in ten months. By January 2026 Threads had overtaken X in daily mobile users by some measures (TechCrunch, citing Similarweb). *North Star:* daily posters and repliers. *Guardrail:* share of feed from accounts the user doesn't follow, which must not crowd out conversation.

What I would build next at Threads

Cricket and cinema live rooms for India. *Problem:* Indian fans react to matches and film releases in scattered places. *Bet:* official match threads with live scores and verified voices. *Metric:* DAU on match days; replies per user.

SOCIAL · FACEBOOK

The giant going back to friends

Facebook is still the world's largest social network. Its challenge is staying relevant to young people while its biggest users age.

Who it is for. Over three billion monthly users, skewing older than Instagram, with strength in groups, Marketplace and communities, especially outside the US. Positioning in 2025–26: a return to *"friends"*, plus video.

What changed. Facebook rebuilt its feed around AI-recommended video, and **video time spent rose 9% globally** in Q2 2026 (Meta call). It also added a **Friends tab** showing only friends' content, and put Messenger back inside the main app: messenger.com shut in

April 2026 and users were redirected to facebook.com/messages (Social Media Today).

Key features and their jobs. **Groups** ("people who share my interest or problem"): a big reason people stay. **Marketplace** ("buy and sell used goods locally"): a high-intent daily habit and the subject of an IIMA metrics case. **Dating** and **Events**: attempts to win young adults back. **Community Notes** replaced third-party fact-checking in the US in 2025, a model borrowed from X.

Metrics. *North Star*: daily active users who interact with friends or groups. *Inputs*: Marketplace listings and messages, group posts, video time. *Guardrails*: young-adult share of DAU, integrity (fake accounts, scams on Marketplace).

What I would build next at Facebook Marketplace

Verified local sellers with escrow via UPI. *Problem*: buyers fear scams on used-goods deals. *Bet*: seller verification plus payment held until pickup is confirmed. *Metric*: listings that sell; scam reports per 1,000 transactions.

SOCIAL · X (FORMERLY TWITTER)

The town square that became part of a rocket company

X shrank as a business after 2022. It kept its role in news and politics, and it is now tied to xAI's Grok and SpaceX.

Who it is for. Journalists, politicians, investors, tech and crypto communities, sports fans: anyone who wants **real-time news and argument**. Positioning under Elon Musk: *"the everything app"* and a platform for free speech.

X since the acquisition

From a \$44B take-private to a unit of SpaceX



Source: Company announcements; SpaceX S-1 filing (May 2026) via Social Media Today

The numbers. The SpaceX filing showed **550 million MAU** (March 2026), below the 600 million the company had claimed, and about **350 million posts a day**. **Ad revenue was \$1.8 billion in 2025**, down from \$4.4 billion in 2022. There are 6.3 million paying subscribers across X Premium and SuperGrok, and **Grok reaches 117 million monthly users** (Social Media Today, May 2026).

What X does uniquely well. **Community Notes**: crowd-sourced context added to misleading posts, shown only when people who usually disagree both rate a note helpful. It is a clever design that Meta copied. X is also still the fastest place for breaking news.

Weaknesses. Brand safety concerns for advertisers, a user base that fell after 2022, heavy dependence on one leader's decisions, and a less than 1% paid conversion.

What I would build next at X

Verified-source news mode. *Problem*: in a crisis users cannot tell rumours from reports. *Bet*: a toggle showing only posts from verified news organisations and Community-Noted posts. *Metric*: DAU during breaking news; advertiser return on brand-safe inventory.

SOCIAL · SNAPCHAT

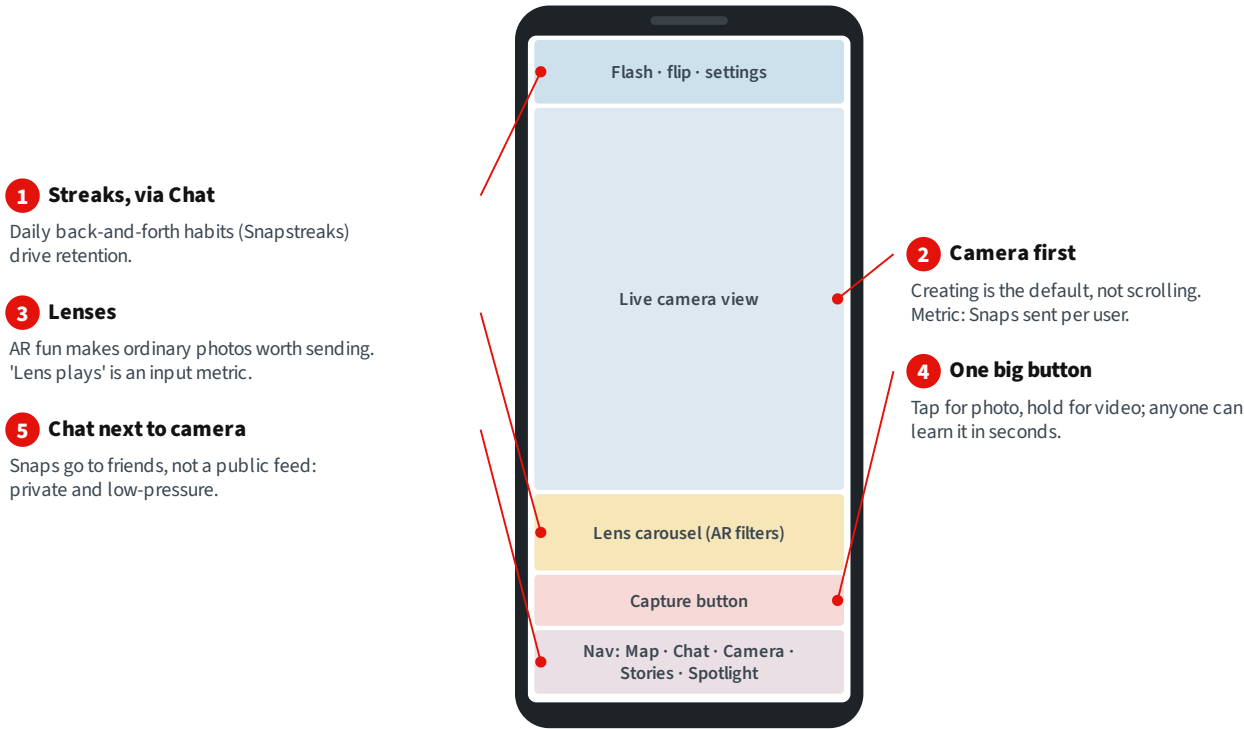
The camera company

Snapchat opens to a camera, not a feed. That one decision still defines it, and India has become its biggest growth market.

Who it is for. Teens and young adults who talk to close friends through pictures. Positioning: *"the fastest way to share a moment"*, private, playful and not about follower counts. Snap reported **about 1 billion monthly users** and added **10 million daily users in Q2 2026**, mostly outside North America and Europe, with India a major contributor (Snap Q2 2026).

Snapchat opens to the camera

The default screen is the product strategy



Business model. Ads (AR lens ads, Stories ads, Spotlight) plus **Snapchat+ subscriptions**, which drove "other revenue" up **85% to \$316 million** in Q2 2026. Total quarterly revenue was about **\$1.6 billion (+19%)**. Snap is also betting on AR hardware: **Specs** glasses priced at \$2,195.

Moat. Close-friend network effects, where your best friends and your Streaks are here. Branding with young people. An AR engine and creator ecosystem (Lens Studio). Its weakness is monetisation per user: Indian users bring growth but earn far less in ad revenue than US users.

Metrics. *North Star:* daily users who send a Snap. *Inputs:* Snaps per user, Lens plays, Stories views, Snapchat+ conversion. *Guardrails:* teen safety reports, revenue per user by region.

What I would build next at Snapchat India
Festival and college Lenses with local brands. *Problem:* Indian users are active but low-value for advertisers. *Bet:* sponsored AR Lenses for Diwali, IPL and college fests, sold self-serve to Indian SMEs. *Metric:* India revenue per DAU; Lens plays per user.

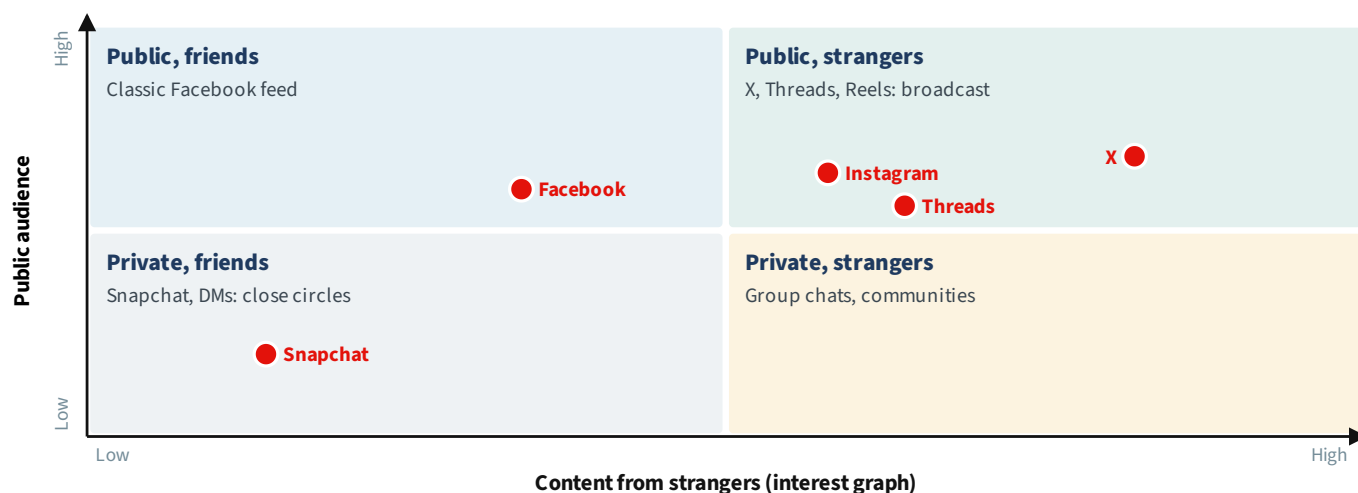
Comparing the five

	Instagram	Threads	Facebook	X	Snapchat
Main job	Entertain + share with friends	Public text conversation	Groups, Marketplace, video	Real-time news and debate	Close-friend visual chat

	Instagram	Threads	Facebook	X	Snapchat
Graph	Interest + social	Borrowed Instagram social + interest	Social + interest	Interest (public)	Close social
Money	Ads	Ads (new)	Ads	Ads + subscriptions	Ads + Snapchat+
2026 scale	2B DAU	500M MAU	3B+ MAU	550M MAU	~1B MAU
Risk	Teen safety, TikTok-style fatigue	Retention	Ageing users	Advertisers, governance	Monetising RoW users

Public versus private, friends versus strangers

Where each app's core experience sits (author's judgement)



Likely interview questions

1. **"Instagram's DAU fell 3% in India. Diagnose."** (IIMA: Instagram low adoption) Split by age, platform and region, and check whether it is new users or returning ones. Look at a Reels ranking change, app performance, or a competitor such as YouTube Shorts.
2. **"What metric would you use for Instagram creator commerce?"** (IIMA) Creator GMV, supported by creators transacting monthly and buyer conversion. Guardrails: ad load and feed quality.
3. **"How would you grow Threads in India?"** Content supply first: cricket, cinema and news creators. Then local-language support and notifications for live events.
4. **"Should X make everyone pay?"** Estimate conversion against user loss. Network effects collapse if the free tier shrinks, so keep reading free and charge for reach or features.
5. **"Design Facebook Reactions today."** (IIMA) Richer signals than a like, helping ranking. Measure reactions per post and whether more people post.
6. **"How does Meta make money if the product is free?"** Walk through users × time × ad load × price per ad, and explain why better AI raises the price per ad.

Recall: social media

1. Explain the difference between the social graph and the interest graph, with one app for each.
2. Write Meta's ad revenue formula and say which term AI improvements raise.
3. How did Threads avoid the cold-start problem, and why was that not enough?
4. What makes Community Notes' design resistant to one side gaming it?
5. Why does Snapchat open to the camera, and what metric does that choice protect?
6. Give Instagram a North Star metric that is better than "time spent", and explain why.
7. (E-commerce) How is Instagram becoming a competitor to Myntra?

PRODUCT DOSSIER · SUPER-APPS

One app to rule them all, and why it rarely works

WeChat became the operating system of daily life in China. Almost everyone who tried to copy it elsewhere failed or retreated. The reasons are one of the best strategy lessons in product management.

A morning in Shenzhen. Li pays for her baozi breakfast by scanning a QR code in WeChat. On the metro she books a doctor's appointment through a hospital's **mini program**, a small app that runs inside WeChat and needs no download. She splits lunch with colleagues in their group chat, pays her electricity bill, and hails a car. All of it happens inside one green app she opened at 7 a.m. and never closed.

A morning in Mumbai looks different. Priya pays for chai on PhonePe, orders lunch on Swiggy, books a cab on Uber, a train on IRCTC, and chats on WhatsApp. That is five apps from five companies, and she is happy with each. Several Indian companies have tried to make her use one app instead. None has managed it.

The job, and why it is so hard

A super-app promises the user "**do everything without switching apps, with one login and one wallet.**" It promises third-party businesses "**reach a billion users without building and marketing your own app.**" For it to work, three things must be true together.

The super-app recipe

Every layer must hold, starting from the bottom



The bottom layer is the one most copies lack. WeChat's anchor is messaging, which people open dozens of times a day. Without an anchor like that, every added service is just another icon nobody taps.

SUPER-APPS · WECHAT

The benchmark

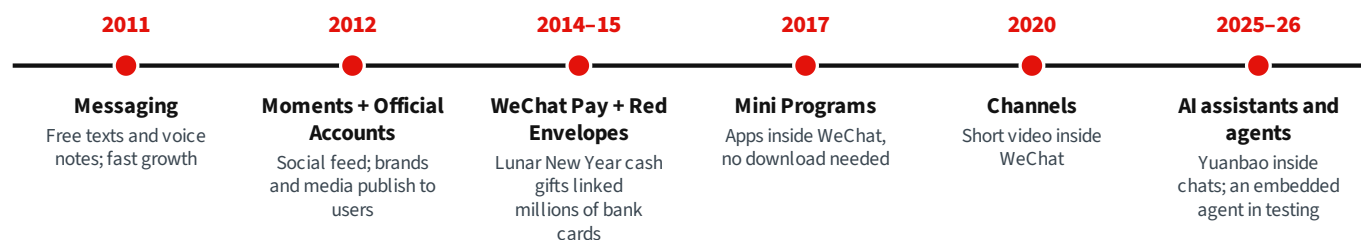
WeChat (Weixin in China) has about 1.4 billion monthly users. It is messaging, payments, social media, search and an app store rolled into one.

Who it is for. Almost every smartphone user in China, plus the Chinese diaspora. Positioning: not an app but "*a way of life*", the infrastructure of daily communication and commerce. It is owned by Tencent.

How it grew, layer by layer.

How WeChat built its layers

Each step used the habit from the step before

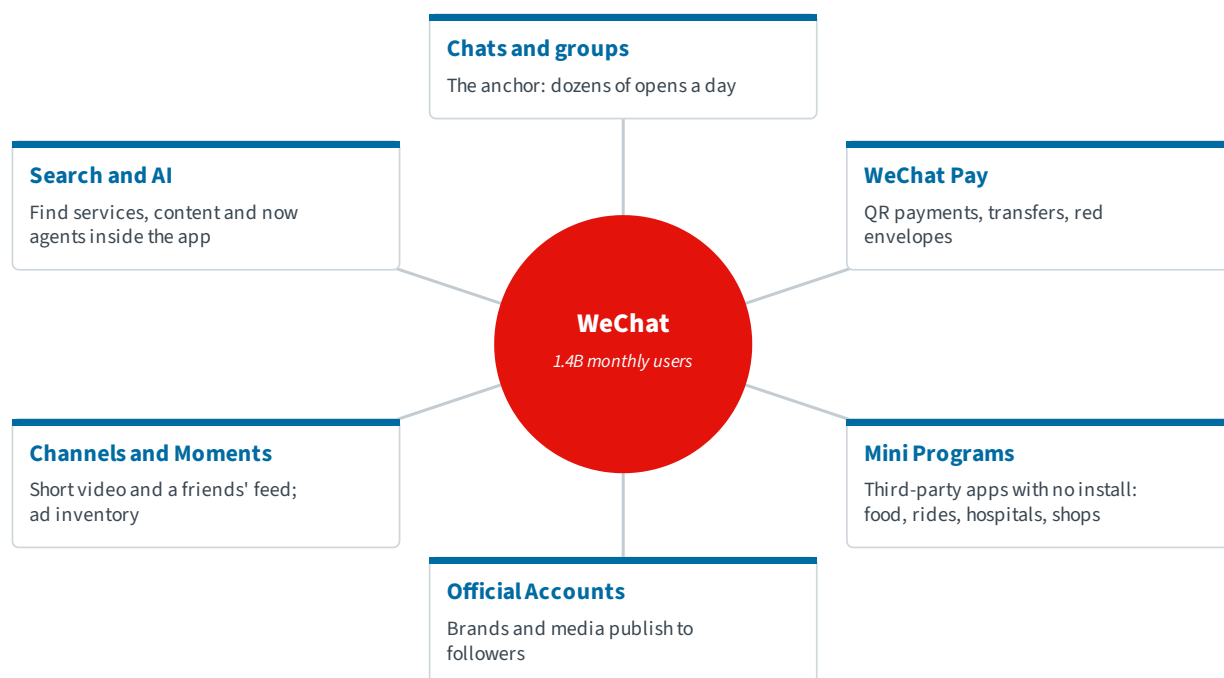


Source: Tencent announcements; industry histories

The growth hack everyone studies: Red Envelopes. At Chinese New Year people traditionally give cash in red envelopes. In 2014–15 WeChat let users send digital red envelopes in group chats, with random amounts and "grab it first" fun. To receive or send money you had to **link a bank card**. In a few days WeChat Pay gained a user base that had taken Alipay years to build. The lesson is to **attach a new product to an existing emotional ritual inside your anchor habit**.

The WeChat ecosystem

Messaging sits at the centre; everything else borrows its daily habit



Mini programs, explained. A mini program is to WeChat what a website is to a browser. A café can build one in weeks. Users open it by scanning a QR code at the counter, it already knows who they are and how they pay, and it disappears when they are done. For businesses it removes the two biggest costs of an app: **building it for two platforms, and getting people to install it**.

Business model. Tencent earns from **marketing services** (ads in Moments, Channels, mini programs and search: RMB 43.6 billion in Q2 2026, +22%), **fintech** (payment fees, wealth products, loans), **cloud services** for mini-program developers, and games distributed through WeChat. Tencent is now spending heavily on AI (Tencent Q2 2026, via China Internet Watch).

Moat. Among the strongest in the world: **direct network effects** (everyone you know is on it), **platform network effects** (users attract mini programs, which attract users), and **switching costs** (your contacts, payment history, and every service's account are tied to one identity).

Metrics. *North Star*: daily active users across communication and services. *Inputs*: messages per user, mini-program daily users, WeChat Pay transactions, Channels watch time. *Guardrails*: regulatory compliance, user trust around data, load time of mini programs.

What WeChat does next: the agent layer

The next version of the super-app may not need users to open mini programs at all. Tencent is testing an **AI agent inside WeChat** that can take a request ("book a table for four near the office on Friday") and carry it out across mini programs. If it works, the super-app becomes a **super-assistant**, and its moat, one identity plus one wallet plus thousands of services, becomes even more valuable.

SUPER-APPS · PAYTM

India's most famous super-app attempt

Paytm tried to be India's WeChat. It then shrank back to what it did best: payments for shopkeepers.

What Paytm tried. Between 2015 and 2021 Paytm added a mall, travel, movie and event tickets, games, a stockbroker (Paytm Money), insurance, lending and a payments bank, all around its **wallet**. In 2016, when demonetisation removed most cash from circulation overnight, Paytm's wallet became many Indians' first digital payment.

Paytm's arc

From wallet to super-app to focused merchant business



Source: Company filings and press reports

Why it did not become WeChat.

- The anchor disappeared.** Paytm's anchor was the wallet. UPI, launched in 2016, let anyone pay from a bank account in any app, for free. Once the wallet was not needed, the reason to open Paytm first went with it.
- No messaging habit.** Indians chat on WhatsApp, not Paytm, so Paytm had to *buy* each visit with cashback.
- Each vertical faced a focused specialist.** MakeMyTrip in travel, BookMyShow in tickets, Amazon and Flipkart in shopping, Zerodha in broking. A super-app's travel section is rarely better than a travel app.
- Regulation.** A bank inside an app with many businesses drew close regulatory attention, which led to the 2024 curbs.

What worked instead. Paytm focused on merchants: **1.57 crore storefronts with Soundbox devices**, merchant loans, and payments. Revenue grew 28% in Q1 FY27 and the company is profitable (Paytm Q1 FY27). Selling its ticketing business to Zomato in 2024 was the clearest signal that the super-app plan was over.

Why super-apps mostly fail outside China

Outside China the record is mostly retreat, with a few partial successes that prove the rule. **Grab** and **Gojek** in South-East Asia grew from rides to food and payments in markets that were fragmented and cash-heavy. **Kakao** (Korea) and **LINE** (Japan, Thailand) built on messaging anchors. **Tata Neu** (2022) had no anchor: Tata Digital lost **₹4,974 Cr in FY26**, and Neu is being refocused on a co-branded credit card and loyalty (Inc42, 2026). **X's** "everything app" plan depends on X Money, still in beta.

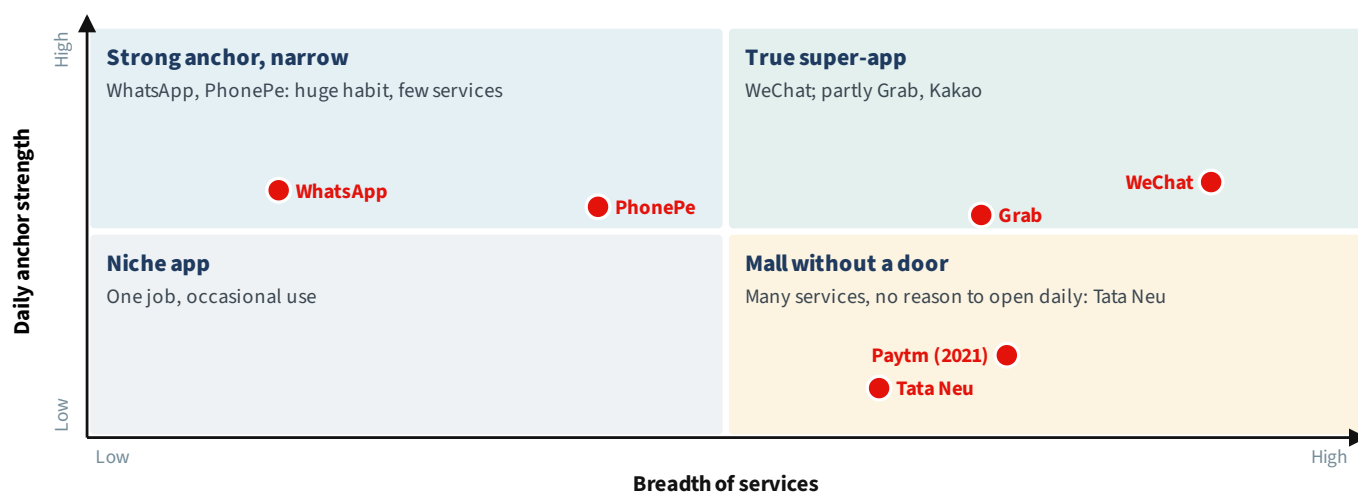
Why the super-app worked in China but rarely elsewhere

China, 2011–2017	India and the West
● Mobile first Most people's first internet device was a phone	● Strong app stores Apple and Google make installing specialist apps easy
● App stores fragmented No Google Play; installing apps was hard, so mini programs were easier	● Anchor owned by others WhatsApp owns chat; UPI makes payments work in every app
● Messaging monopoly WeChat became the anchor for a billion people	● Best-of-breed wins A focused app is usually better in its category
● Payments leapfrog Went from cash straight to QR codes, inside WeChat	● Regulators and privacy Antitrust, data-protection and banking rules limit bundling

A super-app needs a daily anchor, a wallet and weak app-store distribution all at once. India has UPI, but the anchor (WhatsApp) belongs to a company whose payments failed.

Anchor strength versus breadth of services

Where the attempts sit (author's judgement)



The rule to remember

Bundle around a habit, not around a logo. A super-app works when one very frequent job (chatting, paying) pulls users in daily, and other services ride on that visit. A group of good businesses placed under one icon, with no shared daily habit, is a portfolio, not a super-app.

Likely interview questions

1. **"Should PhonePe become a super-app?"** It has the anchor (payments) but UPI is interoperable, so the habit is weak. Suggest adding services that sit next to payments (bills, credit, insurance) rather than food or travel.
2. **"How would you make WhatsApp India's super-app?"** It has the anchor. Build business chats with native checkout, payments, and bills and tickets as mini-apps. The risks are trust and regulators.
3. **"Why did Tata Neu struggle?"** There was no daily anchor, the brands underneath did not work together smoothly, and loyalty points alone do not create a habit.
4. **"Design a mini-program platform for India."** Solve the cold start with a few high-frequency partners (IRCTC, utilities, metro tickets), then add a developer kit and discovery through QR codes.
5. **"What metric tells you a super-app is working?"** Services used per user and the share of users who use two or more services weekly, not total downloads.

Recall: super-apps

1. Name the four layers of the super-app recipe from bottom to top.
2. What is a mini program, and which two costs does it remove for a business?
3. Explain the Red Envelope growth hack and the lesson behind it.
4. Give three reasons Paytm did not become India's WeChat.
5. Why does UPI make an Indian super-app harder, not easier?
6. Give one super-app that partly succeeded outside China and the reason.
7. (Payments) What does WhatsApp Pay's history tell you about distribution versus habit?

PRODUCT DOSSIER • CLOUD

Renting the world's computers by the second

AWS, Microsoft Azure and Google Cloud run most of the internet you use. You do not need to be an engineer to understand what they sell, how they make money, and why AI has made their race the most expensive in business history.

A Bengaluru start-up appears on *Shark Tank India* on a Monday night. Within ten minutes, traffic to its app is fifty times normal. In 2006 that would have crashed the website: the company owned four servers in a rented rack, and buying more took weeks. Today its cloud provider notices the surge, starts forty more servers in seconds, and shuts them down at midnight when the traffic fades. The start-up pays for exactly those two hours. That is the cloud: **computers, storage and software rented over the internet, by the second, and paid for like electricity.**

Explain it like I'm not an engineer

The cloud in everyday terms

Everyday world	In technology
Using the power grid instead of running your own diesel generator	Cloud computing Rent computing power from a provider instead of owning servers; pay for what you use
A hotel room versus buying a flat	Pay-as-you-go versus capital expenditure No big upfront cost; you can check out any time. Long stays are cheaper with a commitment (reserved capacity)
A bank locker in many cities	Regions and availability zones Data centres in Mumbai, Hyderabad and elsewhere; copies in separate buildings so one fire does not take you down
Moving house with all your furniture	Data gravity and egress fees Moving large amounts of data out of a cloud is slow and costs money, which keeps customers in place
Hiring a cook versus buying a meal kit versus ordering in	IaaS, PaaS, SaaS How much of the work the provider does for you

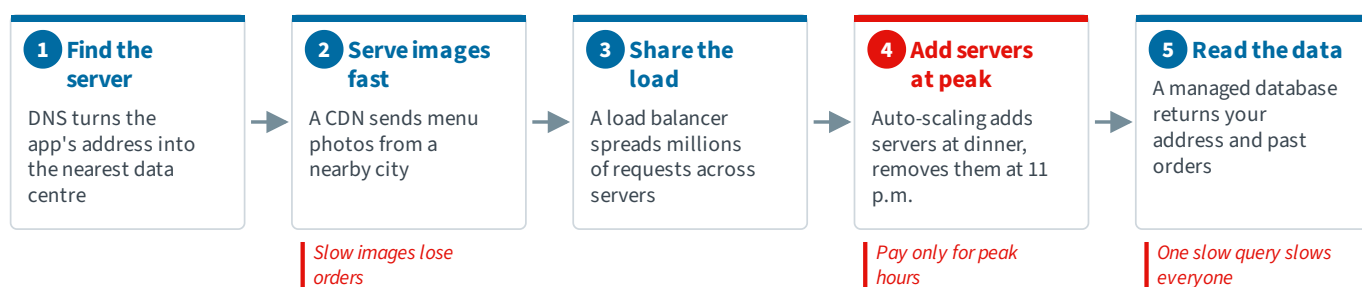
What the cloud sells, layer by layer

Higher layers do more of the work for you and cost more per unit

Layer	What it does	Everyday example
AI services	Rent AI models and GPUs: call Gemini, GPT or Claude through an API	A bank's chatbot built on Bedrock or Vertex AI
SaaS: software	Finished software you just log into	Gmail, Microsoft 365, Salesforce
PaaS: platforms	Managed databases, serverless functions: no servers to manage	A start-up's database on Amazon RDS
IaaS: infrastructure	Raw virtual computers, storage and networking	Renting 40 servers for a Shark Tank night
Physical layer	Data centres, chips, power, undersea cables	AWS's Mumbai and Hyderabad regions

What the cloud does when you open a food app at 8 p.m.

Five services from one provider, used in under a second



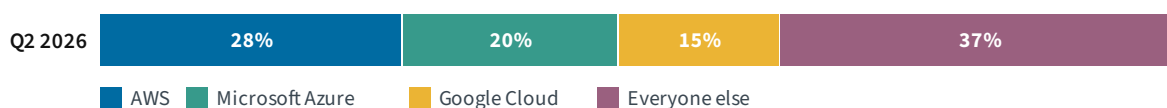
Source: Simplified; typical architecture for a consumer app

How a cloud company makes money. Customers pay per unit used: per hour of a server, per gigabyte stored, per million AI tokens processed. Large customers sign **multi-year commitments** in return for discounts. Those commitments become the provider's **backlog**, revenue it is contracted to earn later. The cost side is dominated by **capital expenditure** on data centres, chips and power. That is why the AI boom has pushed the big three to spend tens of billions of dollars a quarter.

The market

Who rents out the world's computers

Share of global cloud infrastructure spending, Q2 2026 (%)

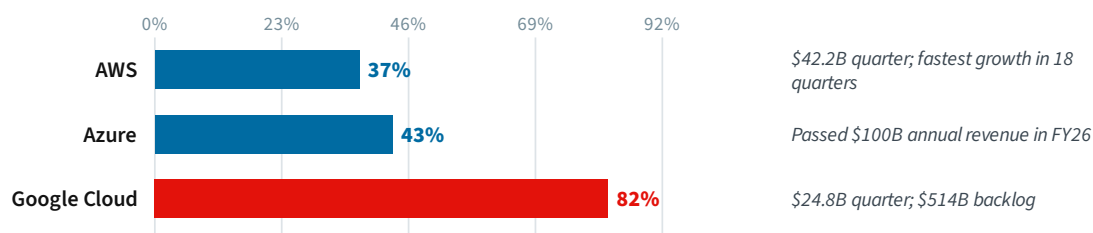


'Everyone else' includes Alibaba, Oracle and fast-growing 'neoclouds' such as CoreWeave. Generative-AI cloud services grew 165% YoY.

Source: Synergy Research Group, Q2 2026 (via 16IDC / The Register). Market \$143.4B in the quarter; +43% YoY, the fastest growth in eight years

How fast each is growing

Latest quarterly revenue growth, year on year (%)



Source: Amazon Q2 2026; Microsoft FY26 Q4 (Apr–Jun 2026); Alphabet Q2 2026. Google Cloud includes Workspace

AI changed the race. Before 2023, the contest was about moving companies' existing software to the cloud. Now it is also about who can supply the **GPUs and AI chips** to train and run models, and who has the best models on their platform. The smallest of the three is growing fastest because of that shift.

CLOUD · AMAZON WEB SERVICES (AWS)

The one that invented the category

AWS began by renting out Amazon's own spare infrastructure. Twenty years later it is the largest cloud and most of Amazon's profit.

Who it is for. Start-ups and enterprises that want the widest set of building blocks: from Indian start-ups like Swiggy and Zepto to banks and governments. Positioning: *"the broadest and deepest set of cloud services."* It was first to market in 2006 with S3 (storage) and EC2 (rentable servers), and it has kept the start-up community's loyalty since.

Core loop. A start-up gets free credits → builds on AWS → grows → its bill grows with it → AWS's scale lets it cut prices and add services → more start-ups choose AWS. This is the same flywheel as Amazon retail, applied to computing.

First run. Create an account with a card, get a free tier (small servers and storage free for a year) and, for start-ups, credits through AWS Activate. The console is powerful but overwhelming, with 200+ services. That is AWS's classic weakness for newcomers, now being softened with AI assistants.

Service	What it does in plain words	Problem it solves	Metric it moves
EC2	Rent virtual computers by the second	"I need servers now, not in six weeks"	Compute usage
S3	Store any amount of files cheaply, forever	"Where do I keep 10 crore photos?"	Stored data (it attracts other services)
RDS, DynamoDB	Databases AWS runs and backs up for you	"I don't want to hire a database admin"	Managed-service revenue
Lambda (serverless)	Run a bit of code only when something happens	"I don't want idle servers"	Developer adoption
CloudFront	Copies content close to users	"The video loads slowly in Patna"	Latency, data transfer
Bedrock, Trainium	Choose among AI models (including Anthropic's Claude); Amazon's own AI chips	"I want AI without building a model"	AI revenue, cost per token

Business model. AWS's **Q2 2026 revenue was \$42.2 billion, up 37%**, its fastest growth in 18 quarters (Amazon Q2 2026). It earns most of Amazon's operating profit. It has committed to large investments in India's cloud regions this decade.

Moat. Switching costs (data gravity, egress fees, engineers trained on AWS). **Scale economies** in buying chips, power and land. **Ecosystem:** thousands of partners and certified engineers. Its risk is **reliability at scale**. A major outage in AWS's US-East region in October 2025 took down many popular apps for hours, a reminder that concentration is a risk for customers too.

Metrics. *North Star:* consumption revenue from active customers. *Inputs:* new active accounts, net revenue retention, services per customer, backlog. *Guardrails:* availability (minutes of downtime), cost-per-unit trends, security incidents.

What I would build next at AWS India

- "Cost copilot" for start-ups.** *Problem:* Indian start-ups routinely overspend on idle servers. *Bet:* an assistant that finds waste each week and applies fixes with one click. *Metric:* retention of start-up accounts after credits expire (guardrail: short-term revenue dip).
- DPDP-ready compliance kit.** *Problem:* India's data-protection rules add consent and data-residency work. *Bet:* ready-made templates for consent logs, data mapping and breach reporting. *Metric:* regulated-industry customers onboarded.

CLOUD · MICROSOFT AZURE

The enterprise's default

Azure wins where companies already run on Microsoft, and it won early access to OpenAI's models. That combination made it the second-largest cloud.

Who it is for. Large enterprises and governments already using Windows servers, Active Directory, Office and Teams. Positioning: *"the cloud for the enterprise you already are."* Azure is sold by Microsoft's huge enterprise sales force, often together with Microsoft 365 licences.

Core loop. A company uses Microsoft 365 → signs an enterprise agreement → moves its Windows and SQL servers to Azure (discounts for existing licences) → adds Azure OpenAI and Copilot → more of its spending goes to Microsoft.

Product	Plain words	Problem it solves	Metric
Azure Virtual Machines and SQL	Rent servers and databases; bring your existing Microsoft licences	"We run on Windows; moving should be easy"	Migrations, consumption
Azure Arc (hybrid)	Manage your own servers and Azure from one place	"Some data must stay on our premises"	Regulated-industry wins
Azure OpenAI / AI Foundry	OpenAI's and other models with enterprise security	"We want GPT, but inside our compliance rules"	AI consumption
Microsoft 365 Copilot	AI assistant in Word, Excel, Teams	"Help my employees work faster"	Paid seats (30M+)

Business model. Azure grew **43%** in the April–June 2026 quarter and **passed \$100 billion of annual revenue** in fiscal 2026. Microsoft Cloud revenue was **\$59.3 billion** in the quarter (Microsoft, Jul 2026). Its partnership with OpenAI was restructured in 2025: Microsoft keeps a large stake, and OpenAI committed to buy a very large amount of Azure capacity.

Moat. Bundling and switching costs: identity (Active Directory), Office, Teams and Azure are sold as one relationship. **Branding** with CIOs, whose line is *"nobody gets fired for buying Microsoft."* The risk is **dependence on OpenAI** and the cost of AI capacity.

Metrics. *North Star:* Azure consumption revenue. *Inputs:* enterprise migrations, AI services consumption, Copilot seats, share of customers using 3+ Azure services. *Guardrails:* capacity shortfalls (customers waiting for GPUs), gross margin on AI services.

What I would build next at Azure

Copilot usage-to-Azure bridge. *Problem:* companies buy Copilot seats but cannot connect their own data safely. *Bet:* a guided "connect your data" flow that sets up search and permissions on Azure in a day. *Metric:* Copilot weekly active seats; Azure AI consumption per Copilot customer.

CLOUD · GOOGLE CLOUD

The data-and-AI specialist that became the fastest grower

Google Cloud was a distant third for years. Its own AI chips and Gemini models turned it into the fastest-growing cloud of 2026.

Who it is for. Data-heavy digital companies, media firms, retailers, and AI builders, including AI labs. Positioning: *"the cloud built by the company that invented modern AI."* Its engineering reputation, BigQuery data warehouse and TPUs are the draws.

Product	Plain words	Problem it solves	Metric
BigQuery	Ask questions of huge data sets in seconds, no servers to manage	"Our analysts wait hours for reports"	Data stored and queried
Vertex AI and Gemini	Build with Google's models and others	"We want AI built on our own data"	AI consumption
TPUs	Google's own AI chips, rentable	"GPUs are scarce and expensive"	AI capacity revenue

Product	Plain words	Problem it solves	Metric
Workspace	Gmail, Docs, Meet for businesses	"Collaboration tools"	Seats (reported inside Google Cloud)

Business model. Q2 2026 revenue was **\$24.8 billion, up 82%**, with a **backlog of \$514 billion** and a record **15% market share** (Alphabet Q2 2026; Synergy). The backlog comes from large multi-year AI capacity contracts. Google also announced a large AI data-centre hub in Visakhapatnam, India, in 2025.

Moat. Cornered resource: its own chips (TPUs) and frontier models (Gemini). **Scale economies** inherited from running Search and YouTube. The weaknesses are a smaller enterprise sales force and partner network than Microsoft's.

Metrics. *North Star:* consumption revenue. *Inputs:* backlog conversion to revenue, AI customers, BigQuery active users. *Guardrails:* capacity delivery on time, customer concentration (a few AI labs are a big share).

What I would build next at Google Cloud India

Indic-language AI starter packs. *Problem:* Indian enterprises want chatbots in 10+ languages. *Bet:* ready templates for support, collections and sales in Indian languages on Gemini, priced per resolved conversation. *Metric:* Indian enterprise AI customers; cost per resolution.

Comparing the three

	AWS	Azure	Google Cloud
Positioning	Broadest services, builders' choice	Enterprise default, Microsoft bundle	Data and AI specialist
Share (Q2 2026)	28%	20%	15%
Growth	+37%	+43%	+82%
AI edge	Bedrock (many models), Trainium chips	OpenAI partnership, Copilot	Gemini, TPUs
Main moat	Scale, ecosystem, switching costs	Bundling, enterprise relationships	Chips + models (cornered resource)
Main risk	Losing the AI narrative; outages	OpenAI dependence; capacity	Enterprise reach; customer concentration

Control versus convenience

The trade-off every company makes when choosing how to use the cloud

Full control, more work

Less work, less control



Chosen by banks with strict rules, or at huge scale

Chosen by start-ups that want speed

Likely interview questions

1. "Explain cloud computing to your grandmother." Use the power-grid or hotel analogy, then one concrete example (IRCTC Tatkal traffic at 10 a.m.).
2. "You are PM for a cloud database. What is your North Star?" Active databases with real usage, or consumption revenue. Guardrails: availability and cost per query.
3. "Why is Google Cloud growing fastest?" AI demand, own chips (TPUs), Gemini and large backlog contracts, starting from a smaller base.

4. **"Should a start-up go multi-cloud?"** Usually not early. It adds complexity. It makes sense at scale, for bargaining power with providers or to satisfy regulators.
5. **"How would you price a new AI service?"** Per token or per outcome, with committed-use discounts. Watch gross margin against GPU cost.
6. **"AWS had a major outage. You're the PM. What now?"** Communicate first, then root cause, then a customer credit policy, then design changes that stop one region's failure from spreading.

Recall: cloud

1. Explain IaaS, PaaS and SaaS with one everyday analogy and one example each.
2. What is "data gravity", and how does it create switching costs?
3. What is a backlog, and why does Google Cloud's matter?
4. Give one reason each for AWS's, Azure's and Google Cloud's advantage in AI.
5. Why does cloud growth require such large capital expenditure?
6. Place three kinds of customers on the control-versus-convenience scale.
7. (Social) How does Meta's AI spending relate to the cloud race?

PRODUCT DOSSIER · OTT VIDEO

Subscriptions, ads and cricket

Netflix proved streaming can be very profitable. JioHotstar proved India's version runs on cricket, bundles and ads. Prime Video uses shows to sell Prime. Three business models for one screen.

A Sunday evening in May 2026, an IPL match in its last over. Across India, hundreds of millions of people are watching on phones: on a bus in Lucknow, in a hostel in Kota, at a dhaba in Punjab. Each of them could choose Hindi, Tamil, Telugu or Bhojpur commentary. Every ad break is sold to the second. The next morning many of the same viewers will open Netflix or Prime Video for a series. Their evening swaps a live, ad-funded, mass event for private, subscription-funded content, and the two businesses could hardly be more different.

The job, and the market

Viewers hire streaming for **"entertain me tonight, with something I'll like, without hunting for it."** Sports fans hire it for **"let me watch the match live, everywhere."** Advertisers hire the ad-supported tiers for **"reach at TV scale, targeted like digital."** In India, telecom operators also hire OTT apps for a job of their own: **"give customers a reason to buy a bigger recharge."**

Four ways to pay for streaming

Most services now mix two or more

SVOD: subscription

Pay monthly, no ads.
Netflix's original model.
Revenue = subscribers × price.

AVOD: ads

Free to watch, paid by advertisers. YouTube; much of JioHotstar.

Hybrid: cheaper plan with ads

Netflix and Prime Video now run ads by default in many markets, with a paid ad-free option.

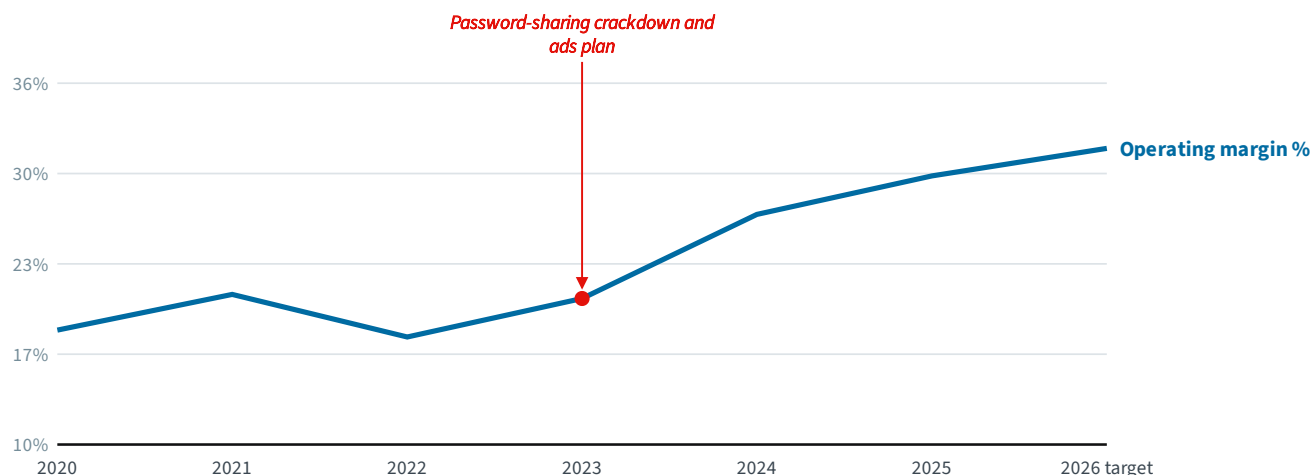
Bundle

Included with something else: a Jio recharge, Amazon Prime, a broadband plan. The partner pays.

Streaming spent a decade chasing subscribers at a loss, then switched to profit in 2022–23. Netflix led the change. It cracked down on password sharing in 2023, launched a cheaper ad-supported plan, and stopped reporting subscriber numbers in 2025 to focus attention on revenue and profit.

Netflix's operating margin, from growth to profit

Operating income as % of revenue



Source: Netflix annual reports; 2025 approximate; 2026 is the company's target (Q2 2026 letter)

India is the hardest market for this playbook. Indians watch a lot of video but pay little for it: YouTube is free, cricket comes bundled with a mobile recharge, and a Netflix Premium plan costs more than many households' monthly mobile bill. So in India, streaming services earn much less per user than they do in the US, and they rely far more on ads, bundles and cricket. Keep this in mind for any India pricing question.

OTT • NETFLIX

The subscription machine

Netflix's product is not a show. It is the confidence that there will always be something good to watch, found in under a minute.

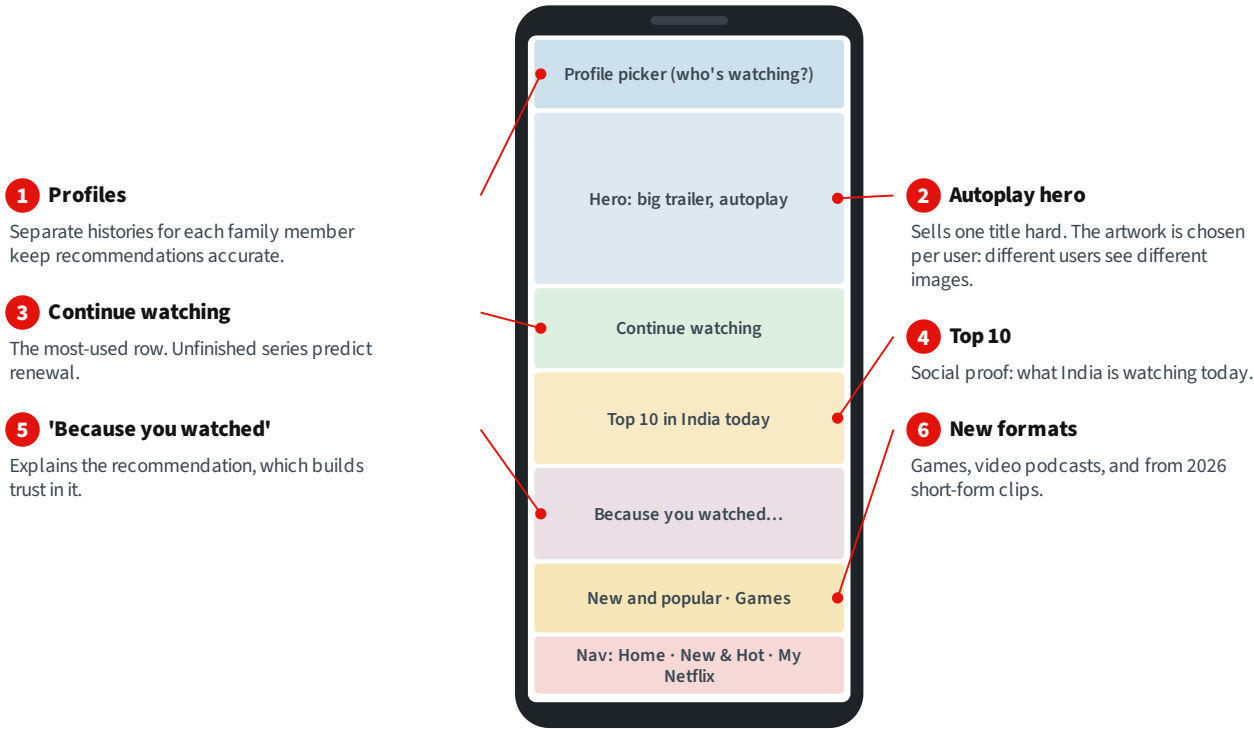
Who it is for. Paying households worldwide, and in India mostly urban, English-comfortable viewers who value series and films over live sports. Positioning: *"entertain the world."* In India it cut prices in 2021 to add a **mobile-only plan from ₹149 a month**, a product built for India's phone-first viewers.

Core loop. Open → a personalised home screen → press play within seconds → watch → finish a series → the algorithm suggests the next one → renew next month. The whole product aims at one outcome: **no month without something you want to watch**, because that is when people cancel.

First run. Sign up (plan choice, then payment), then pick a few titles you like so recommendations can start. The riskiest time is the **first 30 days**. A new member who doesn't find a show they love in the first weeks is the most likely to cancel.

Netflix home screen, annotated

Every row and every image is personalised

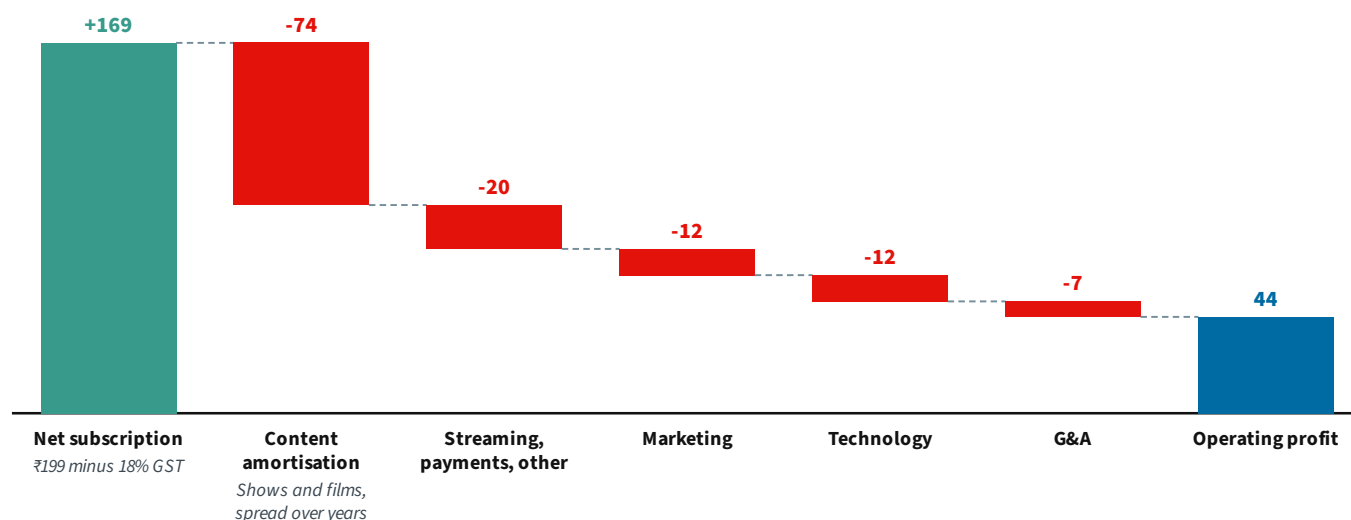


Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Personalised rows and artwork	"Too much choice; nothing to watch"	Each row and each thumbnail is chosen for you	Time to first play, hours per member
Profiles	"My kid's cartoons ruin my suggestions"	Separate histories per viewer	Recommendation accuracy
Downloads	"My internet is bad on the train"	Watch offline	Mobile-plan retention
Paid sharing (2023)	Netflix: "100M+ households watch without paying"	Extra-member fee; household detection	Revenue per account, sign-ups
Ads plan	"It's too expensive"	Cheaper plan with ads	New members, ad revenue
Live events, games, short-form	"I want more reasons to open Netflix"	Adds daily or weekly habits beyond series	Engagement, retention

Business model. 2026 revenue guidance is **\$51.0–51.4 billion** at a **31.5% operating margin**. Q2 2026 revenue was \$12.56 billion (+13%) and advertising is expected to roughly double to **about \$3 billion** in 2026 (Netflix Q2 2026). Netflix bid for Warner Bros. in December 2025, then **withdrew in February 2026** when Paramount Skydance made a higher offer. That decision kept Netflix a builder rather than a buyer of content.

Where a subscription rupee goes

A ₹199/month plan after GST, using Netflix's global cost structure; illustrative



Content is the main cost. A new member adds almost pure profit, because the shows are already paid for.

Source: Illustrative; cost shares approximated from Netflix's reported cost structure

Moat. Scale economies in content: a \$15–18 billion annual content budget spread over hundreds of millions of households, so the cost per member is low. **Data** on what the world watches. **Branding.** Global rights to its originals (a **cornered resource**: *Squid Game* exists only on Netflix).

Metrics. *North Star*: hours of satisfied viewing per member. *Inputs*: time to first play, completion rate, share of members watching a new release in 30 days, ads-plan reach. *Guardrails*: monthly churn, price-increase churn, ad load on the ads plan.

What I would build next at Netflix India

- Cricket-free evenings made easy.** *Problem*: during IPL season Netflix viewing in India drops. *Bet*: "match-length" picks (films under 2 hours, one-episode stories) promoted at match times to non-cricket viewers. *Metric*: hours per member during IPL months; churn in April–May.
- Regional-language original slate with subtitles in 10 languages.** *Problem*: growth outside English-speaking metros is slow. *Bet*: more Tamil, Telugu and Malayalam originals with strong subtitles. *Metric*: non-metro sign-ups; share of viewing in regional languages.

OTT · JIOHOTSTAR

India's giant, built on cricket and bundles

JioHotstar combines Disney's Hotstar with Reliance's JioCinema. It reaches more than half a billion Indians a month and runs the world's largest live-streaming events.

Who it is for. Mass India: cricket fans, TV-serial families, regional-language viewers, and Jio customers who get it bundled with a recharge. Positioning: "everything Indians watch, in every language." It was formed by the 2024 merger of Viacom18 and Star India into **JioStar**, and JioHotstar launched in February 2025.

Core loop. Cricket (IPL, ICC events) pulls in huge audiences → viewers discover serials, films and Disney/HBO content in the same app → bundled or cheap plans keep them → ad revenue from live sport and entertainment pays for rights → more rights.

JioHotstar during a live IPL match, annotated

Built for 50 million-plus people watching the same moment

1 Language choice

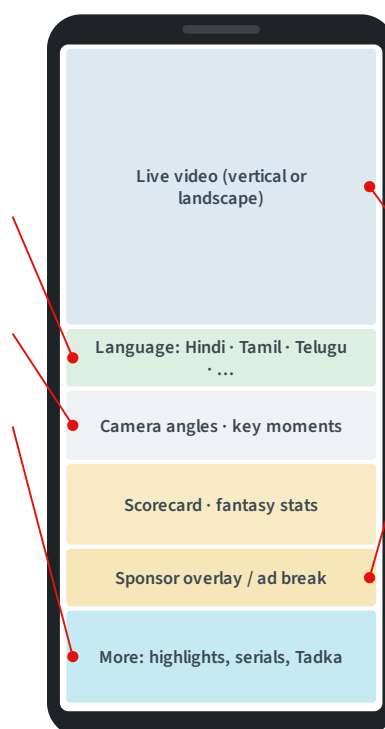
Regional commentary widened the audience; regional viewing grew 33%.

3 Key moments

Late joiners catch up without leaving live.

5 What to watch after

Cross-sell from cricket to serials is the retention engine.



2 Vertical viewing

Phone-first design; most viewers watch on mobile.

4 Ads sold per second

Live sport is the most valuable ad inventory in India.

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Multi-language commentary	"I want the match in my language"	10+ language feeds	Reach outside Hindi markets
Scale engineering	"It buffers at the big moment"	Built for tens of millions watching at once	Peak concurrency, buffering %
Cheap plans and Jio bundles	"I won't pay ₹500 a month"	Low-priced mobile plans; included in Jio recharges	Paid subscriptions
Tadka (short-form micro-content)	"I have five minutes"	Vertical short videos and micro-dramas	100M users in two months
Disney, HBO, NBCU libraries + TV serials	"Something for everyone at home"	One app for the family	Watch time outside cricket

Business model. Q1 FY27 (Apr–Jun 2026, with IPL) JioStar revenue was **₹10,946 Cr (+14%)** and operating EBITDA ₹933 Cr. JioHotstar averaged **530 million monthly active users**. IPL 2026 reached **700 million on digital** and 1.2 billion across TV and digital (JioStar via BestMediaInfo, Jul 2026). Revenue comes from advertising (especially sports), subscriptions (many through Jio bundles) and TV distribution.

Moat. Cornered resource: exclusive cricket and major studio rights. **Scale economies** in streaming technology and ad sales.

Distribution: Jio's hundreds of millions of telecom customers. The main risk is **rights costs**: it paid a very high price for cricket, and if ad markets weaken, those costs remain.

Metrics. *North Star*: monthly active viewers (reach), with watch time as a close second. *Inputs*: cricket-to-entertainment conversion, paid subscriptions, ad fill rate at peak, regional watch time. *Guardrails*: buffering rate at peak, ad frequency complaints, subscription churn after IPL.

What I would build next at JioHotstar

- 1. Post-IPL retention path.** *Problem*: millions of subscribers join for the IPL and leave in June. *Bet*: during the season, build each fan a personalised "after IPL" watchlist of serials and films, and offer a discounted renewal on the final day. *Metric*: 60-day post-season retention.
- 2. Shoppable ads during matches.** *Problem*: advertisers pay for reach but want sales. *Bet*: tap-to-buy from ads via JioMart and brand stores, with UPI. *Metric*: ad revenue per thousand viewers; conversion.

OTT · AMAZON PRIME VIDEO

The show that sells the shipping

Prime Video is not really a standalone business. It is one of the reasons people pay for Prime and stay.

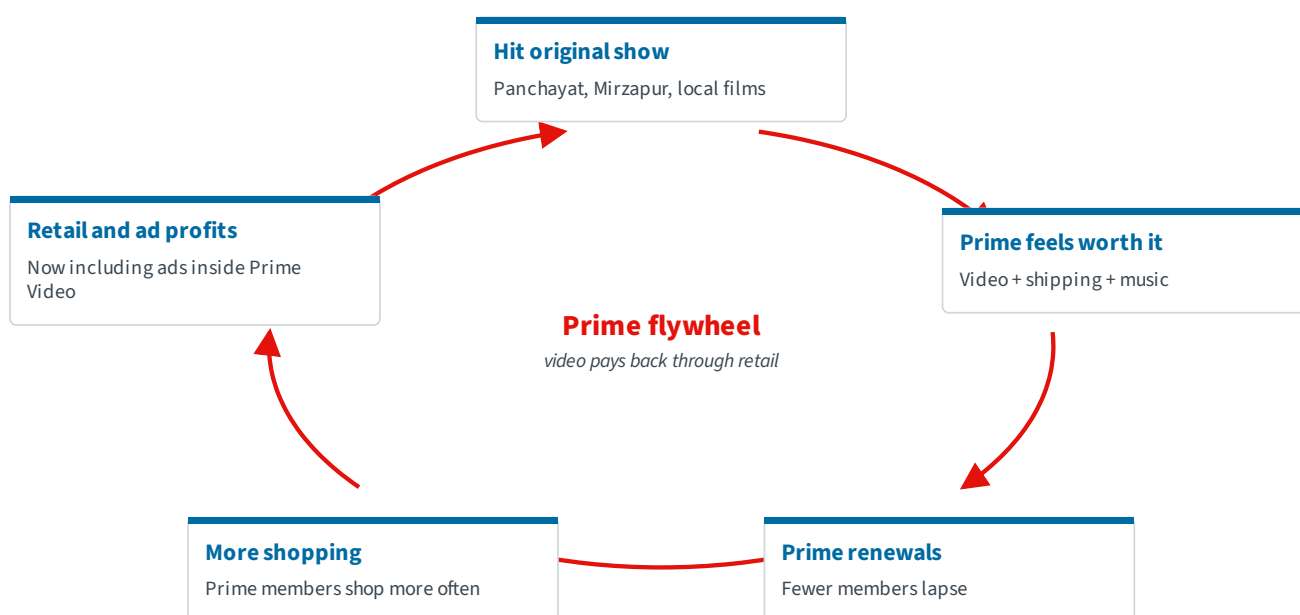
Who it is for. Amazon Prime members in urban India who want Indian originals (*Panchayat*, *Mirzapur*, *The Family Man*) plus Hollywood. Positioning: "*part of Prime*." The Prime annual fee in India is ₹1,499, which includes shipping, music and video, and costs less than many standalone OTT plans.

What changed in 2025. From 17 June 2025, Prime Video India shows **ads by default**. An ad-free add-on costs **₹129 a month or ₹699 a year** (afaqs!, 2025). Amazon's pitch to advertisers is different from JioHotstar's: not mass reach, but **ads matched to real shopping data**, with sales measured on Amazon.

Core loop. Prime member → watches a hit original → associates Prime with value → renews Prime → shops more on Amazon → Amazon earns from shopping and ads → funds more originals.

Why Amazon spends on shows it could sell for more

Prime Video's job is to make Prime renew



Moat. The **Prime bundle** (switching cost: an annual fee already paid), Amazon's **shopping data** for ads, and a deep balance sheet. Weaknesses: less live sport than JioHotstar, a smaller share of viewing time than YouTube or JioHotstar, and some user annoyance at ads being switched on by default.

Metrics. *North Star*: Prime members who stream monthly. *Inputs*: originals' reach in the first 30 days, streaming days per member, ad-free add-on uptake. *Guardrails*: Prime renewal rate, ad complaints, cancellations blamed on ads.

What I would build next at Prime Video

"Shop the scene." *Problem*: viewers want the kurta or the sofa they see on screen. *Bet*: pause-to-shop with Amazon listings, labelled clearly as ads. *Metric*: retail GMV attributed to Prime Video; ad-free upgrade rate (as a guardrail).

Comparing the three

	Netflix	JioHotstar	Prime Video
Model	Subscription + ads plan	Ads + cheap subscriptions + Jio bundle	Part of Prime; ads by default
Hero content	Global originals	Cricket, serials, regional	Indian originals, films

	Netflix	JioHotstar	Prime Video
India audience	Urban, English-comfortable	Mass, every language	Prime households
Moat	Content scale, data, brand	Sports rights, Jio distribution	Prime bundle, shopping data
Risk	Slow growth in India	Rights costs, post-IPL churn	Ad backlash, less live content

Live versus on-demand, mass versus premium

Where each service's core offer sits (author's judgement)



Likely interview questions

1. **"Netflix subscriptions in India declined this quarter. Diagnose."** (IIMA casebook) Split into sign-ups and churn. Check pricing, the release calendar, IPL clashes, payment failures, and competitors' launches.
2. **"How should Netflix price in India?"** (IIMA) Consider mobile plans, elasticity by segment, bundles with telcos, and ads versus a price cut.
3. **"Design a feature to retain JioHotstar subscribers after the IPL."** Use content bridges, personal watchlists, and a pause option instead of cancel.
4. **"Prime Video added ads by default. How do you measure success?"** Ad revenue and advertiser return on spend, against guardrails of Prime renewal and cancellations.
5. **"What should Netflix's North Star be now that it doesn't report subscribers?"** Engagement (hours per member) and revenue. Explain why hours predict churn.
6. **"Estimate peak concurrent viewers for an India–Pakistan match."** Smartphone users × cricket fans × share watching live × share on JioHotstar at the peak moment.

Recall: OTT

1. Name the four ways streaming is paid for and one example of each.
2. Why did Netflix's operating margin jump after 2023?
3. What is Prime Video's real job inside Amazon?
4. Give JioHotstar's moat in three words, and its biggest risk.
5. Why is a new subscriber almost pure profit for Netflix?
6. Pick a North Star and two guardrails for Prime Video's ads launch.
7. (Cloud) What does streaming an IPL final need from cloud infrastructure?

PRODUCT DOSSIER • MESSAGING AND EMAIL

The apps you open fifty times a day

WhatsApp is India's default way to talk, to sell and increasingly to buy. Telegram is its public, broadcast opposite. Messenger shows the cost of a wrong bundling decision. Gmail shows how an old product gets a new brain.

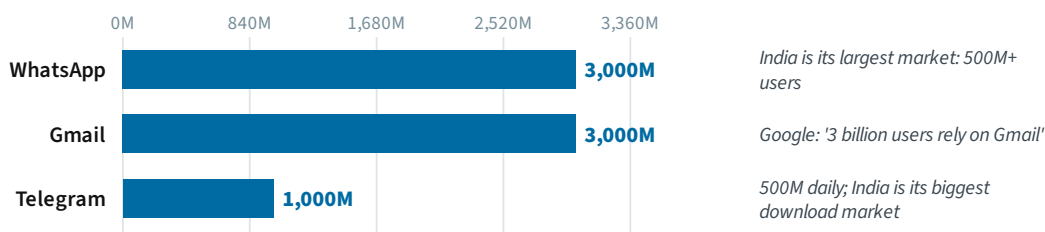
A kirana owner in Jaipur starts his morning on WhatsApp. There is a voice note from his supplier about the price of oil, a family group full of good-morning images, twelve customer orders typed in Hindi, a UPI payment confirmation, and a message from his bank about a loan offer. He has not opened any other app yet. Across the city, a college student has muted fourteen WhatsApp groups and is on Telegram, downloading last year's exam papers from a channel with 200,000 members.

The job, and the market

People hire messaging apps for **"talk to the people who matter, instantly, for free, privately."** That job has a special property: the app is only useful if the other person has it too. That is a **direct network effect**, the strongest kind. Businesses now hire the same apps for **"reach my customers where they already are, and let them reply."** Email serves an older, more formal job: **"a permanent, searchable record for work, accounts and anything official."**

How many people use each

Latest reported users, monthly (M)



Source: Meta (WhatsApp, 2025); Google (Gmail, Jan 2026); Telegram (Mar 2025). Messenger's standalone figure is no longer disclosed

Two philosophies of messaging

WhatsApp: private by default	Telegram: public by design
Encryption End-to-end for every chat; WhatsApp cannot read messages	Encryption Cloud chats by default; end-to-end only in 'secret chats'
Scale of groups Groups up to ~1,000; Communities join groups	Scale of groups Channels with unlimited followers; groups of 200,000
Discovery You need a phone number; little public discovery	Discovery Usernames, public links, search
Money Businesses pay per message; ads only in Updates tab	Money Premium subscriptions, ads in channels, mini apps and crypto

WhatsApp optimises for trust between people who know each other. Telegram optimises for reach to people who don't. Each design choice follows from that one decision.

How messaging makes money is the recurring puzzle in this dossier. Users will not pay to chat, and ads inside private conversations feel like someone reading over your shoulder. So each product finds a side door: businesses pay to reach customers (WhatsApp), power users pay for more (Telegram Premium), or the chat feeds a bigger ads business (Messenger inside Facebook). Gmail, older and more formal, can show ads in one tab and sell storage and AI. Keep this in mind: in any messaging interview, a monetisation idea that puts ads inside private chats will be marked down.

MESSAGING • WHATSAPP

India's operating system for conversation

WhatsApp began with a promise of "no ads, no games, no gimmicks." It now carries Meta's biggest new revenue line: businesses paying to talk to customers.

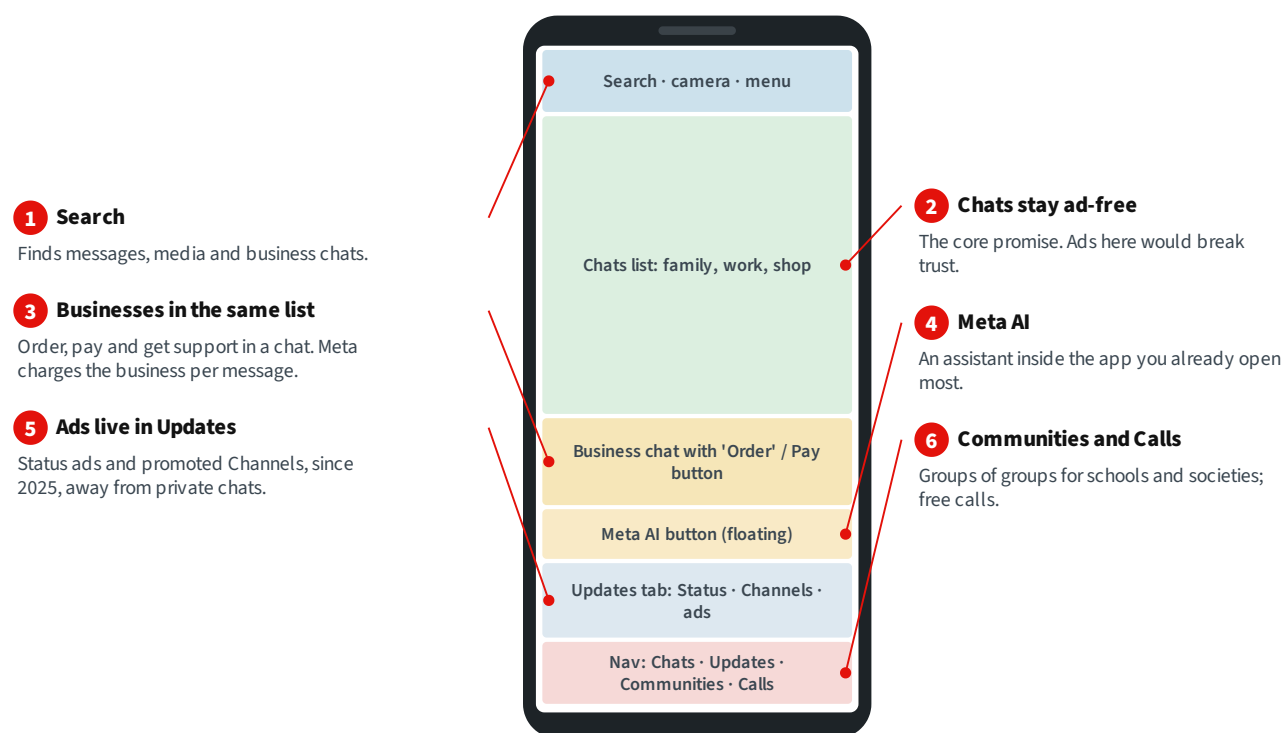
Who it is for. Almost everyone with a smartphone in India, the family, the shopkeeper and the office. Positioning: *"simple, reliable, private messaging."* The product has stayed deliberately plain. The Chats tab has barely changed in a decade, because the job has not changed.

Core loop. Receive a message → reply → the other person replies → the thread becomes a habit. Groups multiply the loop: one family group can generate hundreds of messages a day, each one a reason to open the app.

First run. Phone number → SMS code → your contacts who already use WhatsApp appear instantly. There is no empty state, because your phone book is the network. This is the reason WhatsApp won: **it borrowed a social graph everyone already had.**

WhatsApp, annotated

The Chats tab stays clean; new business lives in the other tabs

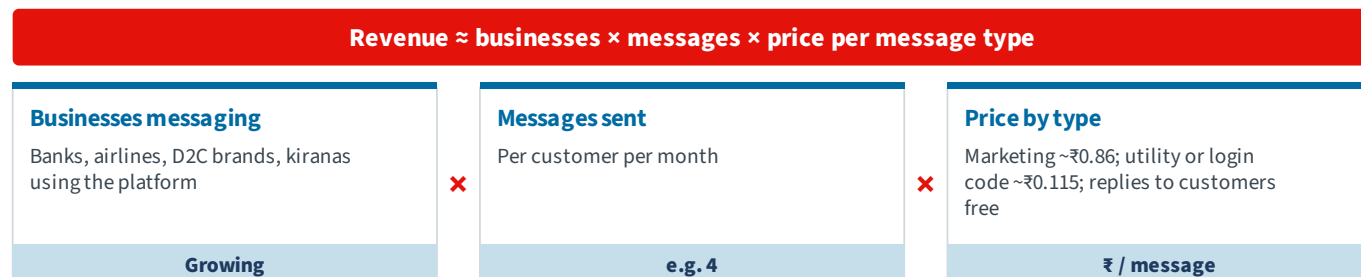


Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
End-to-end encryption	"Is anyone reading my chats?"	Only sender and receiver hold the keys	Trust, retention
Voice notes	"Typing in Hindi on a phone is slow"	Hold to talk; huge in India	Messages per user
Groups and Communities	"Our society needs one place for notices"	Groups nested under a Community with admin tools	Group activity
Status and Channels	"I want to share with everyone, or follow a creator"	Broadcast features, kept in a separate tab	Updates-tab DAU, ad revenue
Business app and platform	Businesses: "My customers are on WhatsApp"	Catalogue, labels, quick replies; paid platform for large firms	Paying businesses
Business AI agents	"I can't answer 500 chats a day"	AI that answers customers for the business	1M+ businesses weekly (Meta)
UPI payments and bill pay	"Pay without leaving the chat"	Built on UPI	Payments share (under 1%)

Business model. Consumers pay nothing. Money comes from three places. (1) **Business messaging:** since July 2025, businesses pay **per message** by category, and India has been billed in rupees since January 2026 (Meta's WhatsApp Business pricing pages). (2) **Click-to-WhatsApp ads** on Facebook and Instagram, which open a chat with a business. (3) Since 2025, **ads in the Updates tab** and paid Channel subscriptions. Meta's "other revenue", mostly WhatsApp business messaging, reached **\$1 billion in Q2 2026, up 73%** (Meta).

How WhatsApp earns from businesses

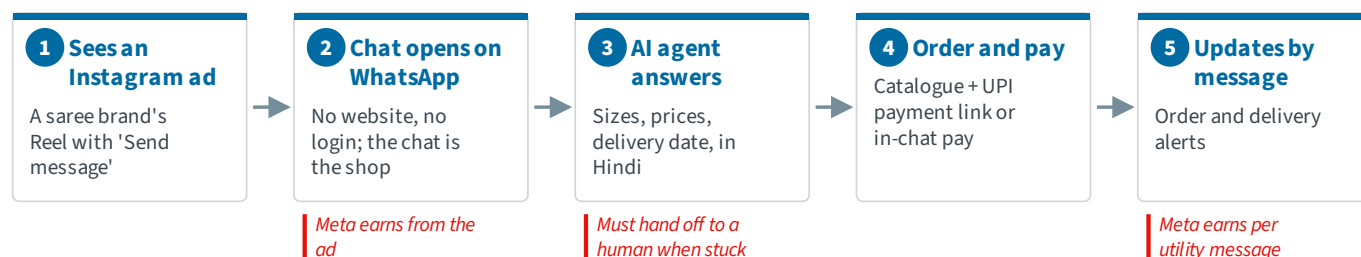
Business messaging revenue, India pricing (2026)



Source: Meta WhatsApp Business pricing, INR billing from Jan 2026 (approximate rates)

A click-to-WhatsApp purchase

How Meta connects its ads business to WhatsApp



Moat. Among the strongest in consumer technology: **direct network effects** (everyone you know is here), **switching costs** (years of chats, groups and media), and **habit**. The risks are misinformation spreading through forwards, which WhatsApp limits by capping forwards to five chats, regulators, and the temptation to monetise so hard that users stop trusting it.

Metrics. *North Star:* daily active users who send a message. *Inputs:* messages and calls per user, active groups, business conversations per week, Updates-tab reach. *Guardrails:* spam reports, blocks of businesses, forward-limit breaches, the share of users muting business chats.

2025–26 moves. Business AI agents went live at scale. Updates-tab ads and Channel subscriptions launched. Per-message pricing and INR billing arrived. In June 2026 **Kunal Shah**, the founder of CRED, was named head of WhatsApp, which signals a push into commerce and payments.

What I would build next at WhatsApp

- Spam-proof business inbox for users.** *Problem:* marketing messages from businesses crowd out personal chats. *Bet:* a "Businesses" folder with one-tap unsubscribe and a monthly cap per brand. *Metric:* user blocks of businesses (down); utility-message read rate (guardrail: marketing revenue).
- Kirana order book.** *Problem:* shopkeepers take orders in chat and lose track. *Bet:* turn any customer message into an order card with items, total and a UPI request. *Metric:* weekly active small businesses; payments started from chat.

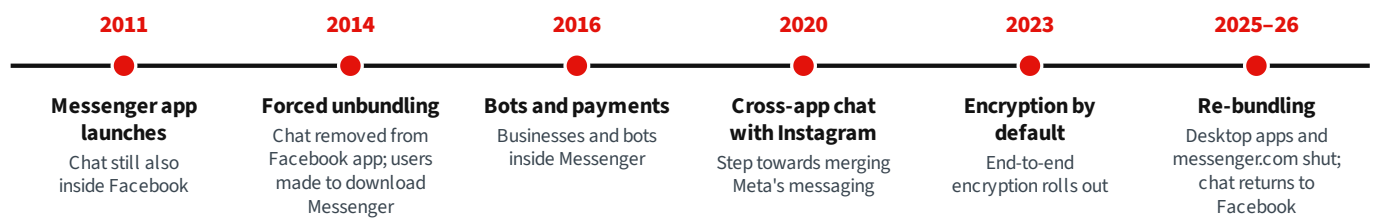
MESSAGING • MESSENGER

A lesson in bundling and unbundling

In 2014 Facebook forced users to download Messenger as a separate app. Twelve years later, Meta is folding it back into Facebook.

What happened. Facebook launched chat in 2008, then in 2014 **removed messaging from the Facebook app**, forcing a separate Messenger download. The logic was that a dedicated app would be faster and would let messaging grow on its own, and at first it did. Later Meta planned to merge Messenger, Instagram DMs and WhatsApp behind the scenes. That plan faded, and Messenger was slowly **re-bundled**: the Windows and Mac apps shut in 2025, and **messenger.com closed in April 2026**, redirecting users to facebook.com/messages (Social Media Today).

Messenger's path



Source: Meta announcements; press reports

The lesson. Unbundling works when the new app has a daily job strong enough to stand alone. That was true in 2014, when Messenger's chats were very active. Re-bundling makes sense when the separate app's usage is shrinking and the parent app is where the users are. *North Star then:* people sending messages. *Guardrail now:* messages per Facebook DAU must not fall after the merge.

What I would build next at Messenger

Marketplace conversations first. *Problem:* most active Messenger threads today are between buyers and sellers on Marketplace. *Bet:* make Messenger inside Facebook the best place to negotiate and close deals, with offers, pickup scheduling and scam warnings. *Metric:* Marketplace conversations that end in a sale.

MESSAGING • TELEGRAM

The public messenger

Telegram is part chat app, part broadcast network, part app store. It became profitable in 2024 with a tiny team and no venture capital.

Who it is for. People who want to follow large communities and channels: students, traders, news followers, crypto users. It also appeals to people who value large file sharing and cloud sync across devices. Positioning: *"fast, secure, powerful."* It has **over 1 billion monthly users and about 500 million daily**, and India was its **biggest download market in 2025** (Telegram; Business of Apps).

Core loop. Join a channel through a public link (exam notes, stock tips, a news source) → get daily posts → join the related discussion group → share links, which brings in more members.

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Channels (unlimited followers)	"I want to broadcast to lakhs of people"	One-way posts; public links; search	Channel subscribers, views
Supergroups (up to 200,000)	"Our community is too big for WhatsApp"	Admin tools, topics, slow mode	Group activity
Cloud chats and big files	"I switch devices; I share large PDFs and videos"	Messages stored on Telegram's servers; files up to 2 GB (4 GB with Premium)	Multi-device use

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Bots and mini apps	Developers: "Let me build inside Telegram"	Open bot platform; mini apps with TON payments	Mini-app users
Telegram Premium	Power users: "More limits, more features"	Paid tier with bigger limits and extras	15M subscribers (2025)

Business model. Premium subscriptions (**15 million subscribers** by mid-2025), ads in large public channels, and crypto-related income from the TON blockchain ecosystem. Revenue was **\$870 million in H1 2025 (+65%)**, and the company made its first annual profit, \$547 million, in 2024 (Telegram, via SQ Magazine).

Risks. Weak moderation: piracy of films and courses in India and illegal content globally. Founder Pavel Durov was arrested in France in 2024. Telegram's default chats are not end-to-end encrypted, although many users assume they are.

What I would build next at Telegram India

Verified educator channels. *Problem:* students can't tell genuine teachers from pirates and scammers. *Bet:* verified badges plus paid channel subscriptions paid through UPI, with revenue sharing. *Metric:* paid subscribers to verified channels; piracy reports (down).

EMAIL • GMAIL

An old product with a new brain

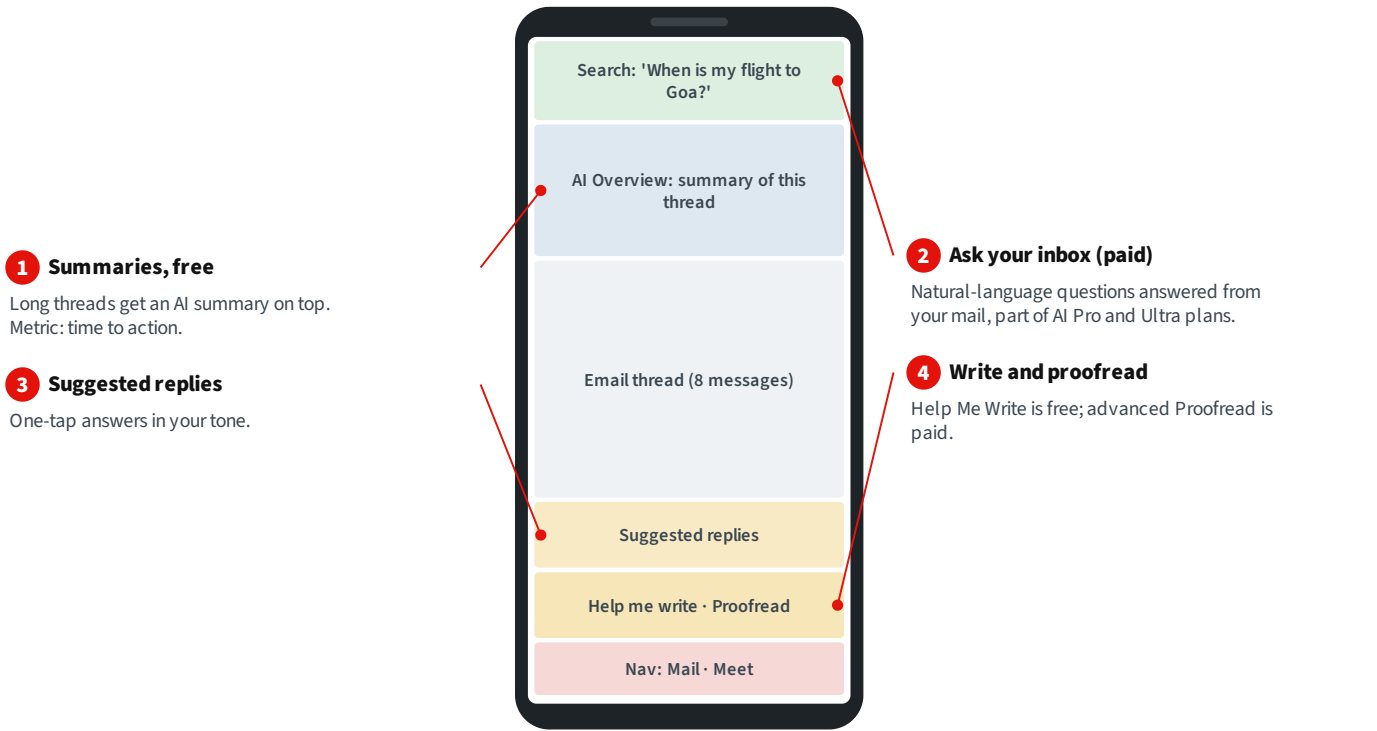
Gmail is 22 years old and has 3 billion users. In 2026 Google rebuilt it around Gemini, and chose carefully which parts to give away free.

Who it is for. Anyone who needs an email address, which is everyone with an Android phone. It is also the home of every bank statement, OTP, ticket and job offer. Positioning: *"email that's organised for you."* For businesses, Gmail is part of **Google Workspace**.

Core loop. A notification arrives → open → read, act or archive → search when you need something from years ago. Gmail's historic innovations were **search instead of folders** and 1 GB of free storage when rivals offered 4 MB (2004), then the **Primary / Social / Promotions tabs** (2013), and **Smart Compose** (2018).

Gmail with Gemini, annotated (2026)

AI sits at the top of long threads and inside the compose box



The 2026 product decision. In January 2026 Google announced that **AI Overviews for thread summaries, Help Me Write and Suggested Replies are free for everyone**, while **asking questions of your whole inbox and advanced Proofread need a paid Google AI Pro or Ultra plan**. A new **AI Inbox** that ranks important mail was sent to trusted testers (Google blog, Jan 2026). This is a textbook **freemium boundary**: the free features make the product better for all 3 billion users, and the paid features serve power users who get the most value.

Business model. Ads in the Promotions tab, Google One storage upgrades (the free 15 GB is shared with Photos and Drive, which drives upgrades), paid AI plans, and Workspace subscriptions for businesses.

Ecosystem power. Because Gmail is so big, its rules shape the whole email industry. In 2024 Google required bulk senders to authenticate their mail and offer **one-click unsubscribe**. That was a product decision that improved every Gmail user's inbox and cut spam.

Metrics. *North Star*: daily active users who act on an email (reply, archive, click). *Inputs*: search success rate, AI summary usage, spam caught, AI-plan conversion. *Guardrails*: false-positive spam (real mail sent to spam), AI summary errors, privacy complaints.

What I would build next at Gmail

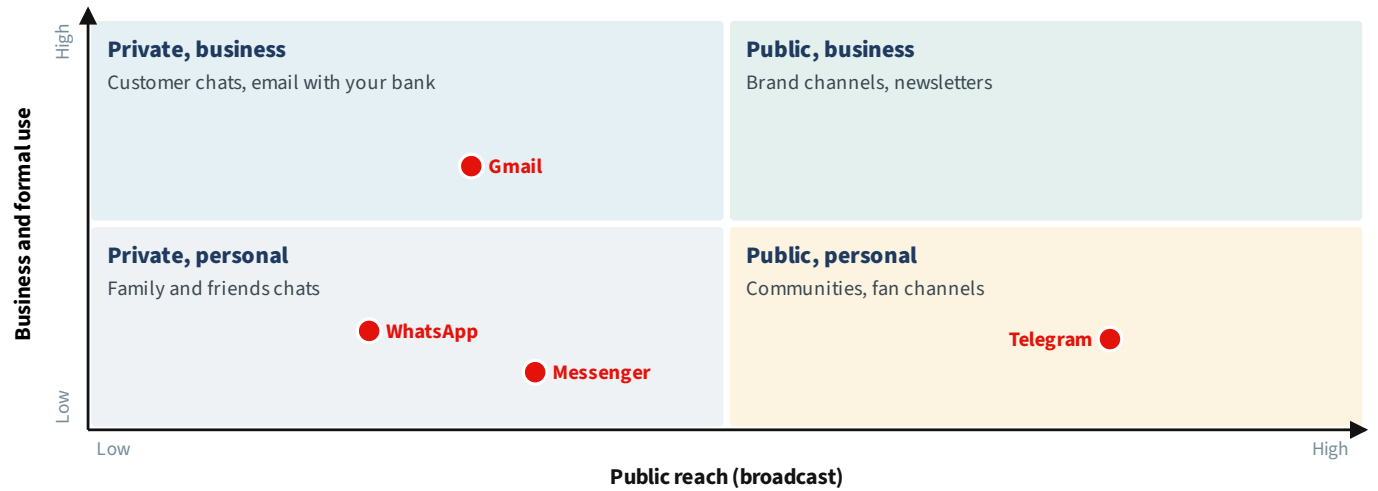
Life admin inbox for India. *Problem*: bills, KYC requests, policy renewals and OTP-heavy mail are hard to track. *Bet*: auto-detect due dates and renewals and add them to a "To handle" list with reminders. *Metric*: weekly active users of the list; missed-payment reports (down).

Comparing the four

	WhatsApp	Messenger	Telegram	Gmail
Core job	Private chat with people you know	Chat with Facebook friends and sellers	Public channels and big groups	Formal, permanent communication
Graph	Phone contacts	Facebook friends	Username, public links	Email addresses
Money	Business messaging, Updates-tab ads	Ads, business messaging	Premium, channel ads, crypto	Ads, storage, AI plans, Workspace
Moat	Network effect + habit	Facebook's network	Communities and channels	Ubiquity, search, Android
Risk	Over-monetising trust	Irrelevance	Moderation, legal	AI errors, privacy

Private versus public, personal versus business

Where each product's centre of gravity sits (author's judgement)



Likely interview questions

- 1. "WhatsApp wants to launch in-app video. How would you measure success?" (IIMA casebook) North Star: daily users watching and sharing. Guardrails: messages per user must not fall, and data usage complaints.

2. **"Should WhatsApp show ads in chats?"** No. Explain the trust cost. Monetise through business messaging and Updates-tab ads instead, which is what Meta chose.
3. **"Design a feature for WhatsApp groups in housing societies."** Communities with notices, polls, payments for maintenance fees, and admin controls. Measure active societies.
4. **"How would you monetise Telegram in India?"** Paid channels via UPI, creator revenue sharing, and verification. Guardrail: piracy.
5. **"Metrics for Gmail's AI summaries."** Adoption, time to action, and user-rated accuracy. Guardrail: errors on important mail (bills, offers).
6. **"Was unbundling Messenger in 2014 right?"** Yes for 2014's usage and speed. Re-bundling now fits a smaller, Marketplace-led use case.

Recall: messaging and email

1. Why is a messaging app's network effect called "direct", and why is it so strong?
2. Contrast WhatsApp's and Telegram's choices on encryption, group size and discovery.
3. Write WhatsApp's business-messaging revenue formula.
4. What is a click-to-WhatsApp ad, and how does Meta earn twice from it?
5. What lesson does Messenger's unbundling and re-bundling teach?
6. Which Gmail AI features are free and which are paid, and why draw the line there?
7. (Payments) Why hasn't WhatsApp's distribution translated into UPI share?

PRODUCT DOSSIER • AD-SUPPORTED MEDIA

Free to watch, paid for by attention

YouTube, Spotify, Twitch and Moj give you content for free and sell your attention to advertisers. Each also has to pay the creators who make that content. How they split the money decides who wins.

A mechanic in Coimbatore fixes a Royal Enfield while a YouTube video in Tamil explains the carburettor. He has watched this creator for three years. The creator, a former mechanic himself, earns more from YouTube ads, a sponsored tool brand and channel memberships than he did from his garage. Neither the viewer nor the creator pays YouTube anything. The advertiser pays, YouTube keeps a share, and the creator gets the rest. Every ad-supported media business is some version of that triangle.

The job, and the market

Viewers and listeners hire these products for **"entertain or teach me, for free, whenever I have a spare minute."** Creators hire them for **"an audience, and a way to earn from it."** Advertisers hire them for **"attention from the right people, at a price that pays back."** The platform's product job is to keep all three satisfied: enough ads to pay creators, few enough that viewers stay.

What a creator earns from 1 lakh views in India

The creator-economics formula every ad-supported platform runs on

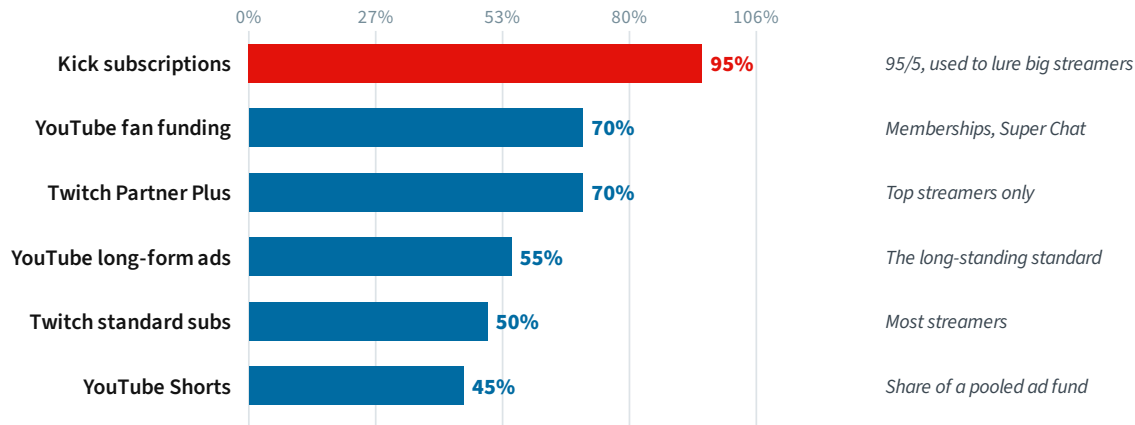
Creator earnings $\approx 1,00,000 \times 0.6 \times ₹80 \div 1,000 \times 55\% \approx ₹2,640$			
Views Monetised long-form views 1,00,000	Ad impressions per view ✗ Pre-roll, mid-roll; many views show no ad ~0.6	Price per 1,000 impressions ✗ India CPMs are far below US levels ₹80 (illus.)	Creator share ✗ YouTube long-form: 55% to creator 55%

Source: Revenue share from YouTube Partner Program terms (55% long-form); other values illustrative for Indian audiences

That small number explains Indian creator behaviour. Ads alone rarely pay the bills, so creators add **brand deals, memberships, courses and live gifts**. It also explains why platforms fight over **revenue share**: a few points more for creators can pull the best ones across.

How much of the money goes to the creator

Headline creator revenue shares, 2026



Source: YouTube Help (Partner Program); Twitch and Kick public terms; reported in industry coverage (2026)

The pattern to notice: the challenger pays creators the most, and the leader pays the least but offers the biggest audience. Creators usually follow the audience, not the percentage.

MEDIA • YOUTUBE

The world's largest library, and India's TV

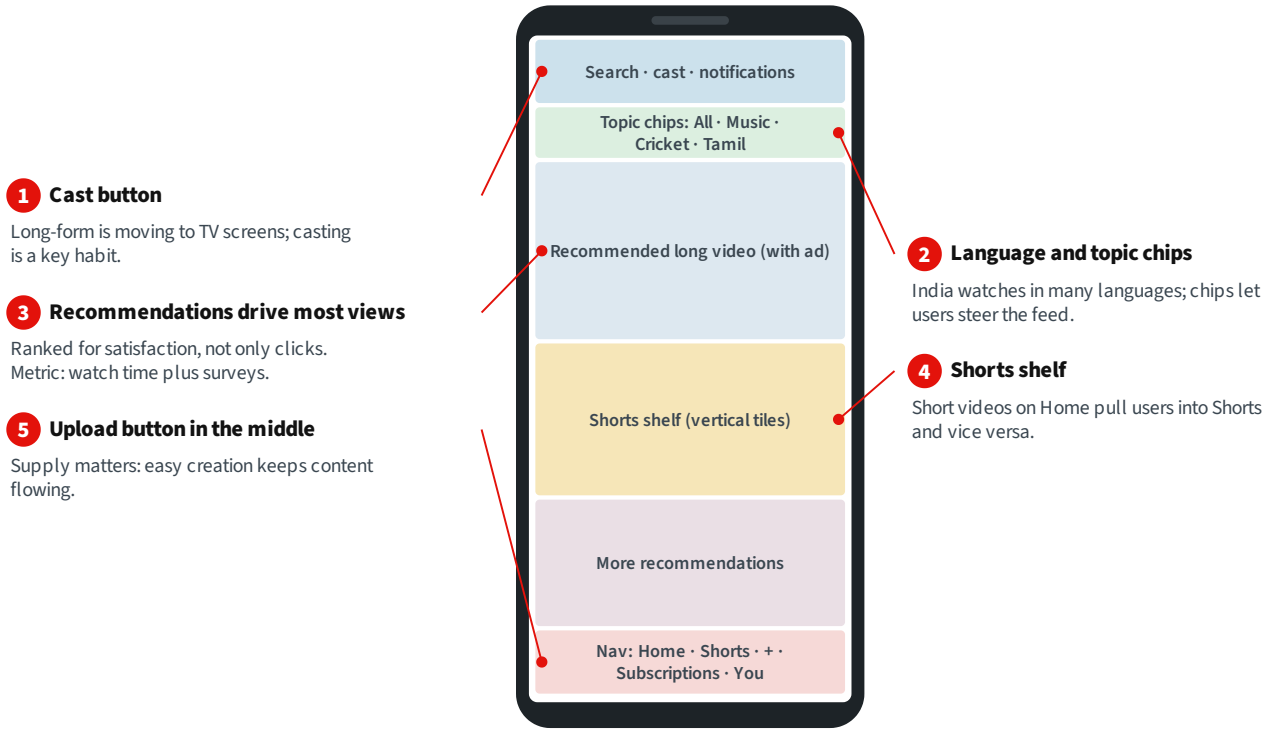
YouTube is where India learns, laughs and listens. It has over 500 million Indian users and pays creators more than any other platform.

Who it is for. Everyone: over 2.7 billion users worldwide and around 518 million in India. Positioning: "give everyone a voice and show them the world." It has four products in one: long-form video (now mostly watched on TVs in many markets), **Shorts** (200 billion daily views), YouTube Music, and Premium.

Core loop. Search or open Home → watch → the next video autoplays or is recommended → subscribe to a creator → notifications bring you back → creators see their audience grow and upload more. The **supply loop** matters as much: more viewers → more ad money → more creators earning → more and better videos.

YouTube home on a phone, annotated

Serving three habits: long videos, Shorts and subscriptions



Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Recommendations	"I don't know what to watch"	Ranking tuned for satisfaction surveys as well as watch time	Watch time, satisfaction
Shorts	"I have 30 seconds"	Vertical feed; revenue pooled and shared	Shorts views, creator uploads
Partner Program (YPP)	Creators: "How do I earn?"	Tiers: 500 subscribers (fan funding), 1,000 + watch hours (ads)	Monetising creators
Memberships, Super Chat, Shopping	Creators: "Ads don't pay enough"	Direct fan payments; product tags	Creator revenue per channel
Premium and Music	"Ads interrupt my music"	Ad-free, background play, downloads	Subscribers (125M incl. trials, 2025)
Auto-dubbing and captions	"It's not in my language"	AI dubbing into other languages	Views from other languages

Business model. Ads (about 55% of long-form ad revenue goes to creators), subscriptions (Premium, Music, YouTube TV in the US), and a cut of fan payments. YouTube ad revenue grew **13%** in Q2 2026 (Alphabet). YouTube says it paid creators, artists and media companies **over \$100 billion** between 2021 and 2024. In August 2026 YouTube announced that from **February 2027** new creators will need **8,000 watch hours (or 20 million Shorts views)** to join the ad programme, double today's bar (reported by Indian creator-economy sites). The aim is to reward sustained quality over volume.

Moat. **Two-sided network effects** (viewers ↔ creators), the **largest video library in the world** (a cornered resource built over 20 years), Google's **ad-sales machine**, and **Android distribution**.

Metrics. *North Star:* daily watch time from satisfied viewers. *Inputs:* daily viewers, Shorts views, uploads by active creators, share of monetising creators. *Guardrails:* policy violations (misinformation, unsafe content for kids), ad load, creator earnings concentration.

What I would build next at YouTube India

- 1. Learning mode for exam students.** *Problem:* students watch lectures but lose track across channels. *Bet:* playlists turned into courses with progress tracking, notes and quizzes. *Metric:* weekly learners; completion rate.
- 2. Regional creator accelerator.** *Problem:* small creators in Bhojpuri, Odia and Assamese can't monetise under the higher bar. *Bet:* auto-dubbing and a regional fund for fast-growing channels. *Metric:* monetising creators in smaller languages.

MEDIA · SPOTIFY

Freemium audio at scale

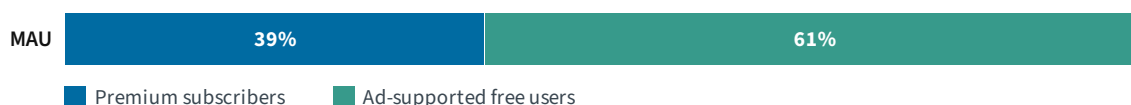
Spotify gives most of its users music for free, paid for by ads, and turns enough of them into subscribers to make a profit.

Who it is for. Music and podcast listeners worldwide: **777 million monthly users, 300 million paying** (Spotify Q2 2026). In India most users are on the free tier, and Spotify competes with YouTube Music, JioSaavn and Gaana. Positioning: *"the soundtrack to your life."*

Core loop. Listen free with ads → Spotify learns your taste → Discover Weekly, Daily Mix and Wrapped make the product feel personal → frustration with ads or limits → upgrade to Premium. Spotify's 2018 listing documents said that over 60% of new Premium subscribers had first been free users, which is why the free tier is a **marketing channel**, not charity.

Spotify's users, free versus paying

Q2 2026, approximate (millions)

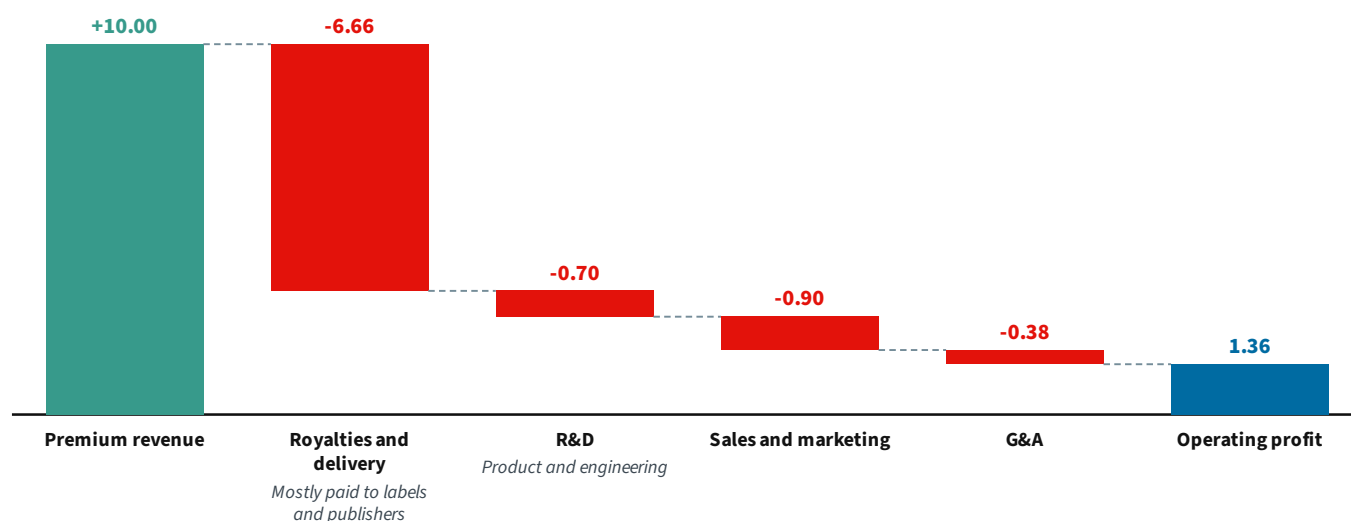


Premium brings in most of the revenue; the free tier feeds it and earns from ads. 'Talk to Spotify' (voice) and Reserved (ticketing) launched in 2026.

Source: Spotify Q2 2026 results (777M MAU, 300M subscribers). Ad-supported share derived by subtraction

Where a €10 Premium payment goes

Per subscriber per month, using Spotify's Q2 2026 margins; illustrative split of costs



Spotify keeps about €1.36 of every €10. Record labels, not Spotify, capture most of music streaming's value.

Source: Spotify Q2 2026: gross margin 33.4%, operating income €655M on €4.8B revenue; cost split illustrative

Key features. **Discover Weekly and Daily Mixes** (personal discovery; metric: tracks saved). **Wrapped** (a year-end summary that users share: a free viral marketing campaign every December). **Podcasts and audiobooks** (content Spotify can own or license more cheaply than music, which improves margins). **AI DJ and "Talk to Spotify"** (voice requests). **Free tier upgrades** so free users can pick specific songs (2025), which reduces the reason to leave for YouTube.

Moat. Personalisation data and **switching costs** (your playlists and years of taste history). Scale in negotiating with labels. The weakness is that labels hold the **cornered resource** (the music), so they capture most of the value, and Spotify's margins depend on them.

Metrics. *North Star*: time spent listening by monthly users. *Inputs*: free-to-Premium conversion, Premium churn, podcast minutes, ad fill rate. *Guardrails*: gross margin, artist and label satisfaction, ad frequency on the free tier.

What I would build next at Spotify India

Regional "radio" with local ads. *Problem:* Indian free users listen in many languages, and advertisers can't target them well. *Bet:* language-based live stations with local DJs (AI-assisted) and city-level audio ads sold to small businesses. *Metric:* free-tier listening hours; India ad revenue per user.

MEDIA · TWITCH

Live, together, now

Twitch turned watching other people play video games into a social experience, and it still leads live streaming. But rivals are paying creators more to leave.

Who it is for. Gamers and fans of live, unscripted streams: gaming, "Just Chatting", music, esports. Twitch is owned by Amazon (since 2014). It has **about 54% of live-streaming watch time**, against YouTube's 24% and Kick's 11% (industry trackers, 2026). Positioning: *"you're already one of us."*

Core loop. Join a live stream → chat with others → the streamer reacts to your message → you subscribe, send Bits (tips), use emotes → you come back at the next scheduled stream. The **live chat** is the product: viewers watch *with* each other, not just watch.

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Live chat and emotes	"I want to be part of it"	Channel-specific emotes unlock with a subscription	Chatters per stream
Subscriptions, Bits	"I want to support my streamer"	Monthly subs and micro-tips shown on stream	Revenue per viewer
Raids	Streamers: "How do small channels grow?"	Send your audience to another streamer at the end	New-viewer discovery
Clips	"I missed the best moment"	Short shareable clips	Off-platform reach
Channel points	"Reward loyal viewers"	Points for watching, redeemable for perks	Watch time

Creator economics under pressure. Twitch's standard subscription split is **50/50**, rising to 70/30 for top creators. **Kick** offers creators **95%**, which has lured some big streamers. Twitch's challenge is that live video is **expensive to deliver** (it shut down in South Korea in 2024 because of high network fees). It cannot easily match 95/5 without losing money.

Twitch versus Kick

Twitch	Kick
● Creator split 50/50 standard; up to 70/30	● Creator split 95/5 on subscriptions
● Strength Largest audience, culture, tools	● Strength Pays stars to switch; looser rules
● Weakness High delivery costs; creators feel underpaid	● Weakness Smaller audience; brand-safety concerns

Money moves creators, but audiences move slowly. Twitch's defence is discovery and community, not matching the split.

In India, most live streaming happens on YouTube, with gaming-first local apps like Loco and Rooter. Twitch is small, because of low ad rates and the payment habits of Indian fans.

What I would build next at Twitch

Co-streaming for new creators. *Problem:* new streamers stream to empty rooms and quit. *Bet:* match small streamers to "co-stream" events alongside bigger ones in the same game. *Metric:* 90-day retention of new streamers; average concurrent viewers.

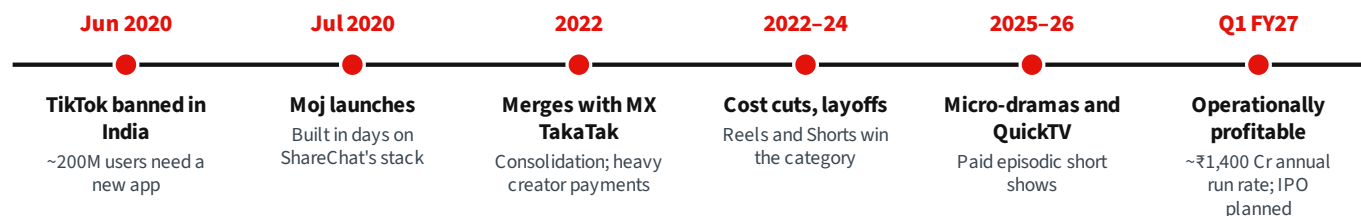
MEDIA · MOJ (SHARECHAT)

The TikTok-shaped hole

When India banned TikTok in 2020, Moj launched within days. After years of losses it found profit, not in short videos, but in micro-dramas and live gifting.

Who it is for. Users in smaller towns watching in Hindi and regional languages. **ShareChat and Moj together have about 150 million monthly users** (Mohalla Tech, 2026). Positioning: "India's own" short video, in 15+ languages.

Moj's path, from launch to profit



Source: Company statements; Business Today and Bloomberg (Jul 2026)

What worked. Competing with Instagram Reels and YouTube Shorts on free short videos was a losing fight. ShareChat found money in two formats Meta and Google did not dominate. **Micro-dramas:** very short, episodic soap operas, where ShareChat has about two-thirds of India's audience, with 65 million monthly viewers and a subscription app, QuickTV. And **live audio chatrooms with virtual gifts**, where fans pay hosts in small amounts.

Business model. Ads, virtual gifting and micro-drama subscriptions. Annual revenue is running at about **₹1,400 Cr, growing over 30%**, and the company plans a **\$400 million IPO** (Business Today, Jul 2026).

Lesson. When you cannot win a category against Meta and Google, find a **format or monetisation model** they are not optimised for, and own it.

What I would build next at Moj

Creator-led micro-drama studio. *Problem:* micro-drama supply depends on a few studios. *Bet:* give top Moj creators tools and revenue share to produce their own series. *Metric:* series published per month; paid conversions per series.

Comparing the four

	YouTube	Spotify	Twitch	Moj/ ShareChat
Core format	Long video + Shorts	Audio (music, podcasts)	Live streams	Short video, micro-dramas, live audio
Money	Ads + Premium	Premium + ads	Subs, Bits, ads	Ads, gifting, subscriptions
Creator deal	55% long-form, 45% Shorts	Pays rights holders	50/50 to 70/30	Gifting share, creator funds
Moat	Library, network, Google ads	Personalisation, habit	Live community	Regional languages, niche formats
Risk	Regulation, creator bar	Label power	Creator poaching, costs	Scale against Meta and Google

Likely interview questions

1. **"YouTube's daily revenue: estimate it."** (IIMA guesstimate) Daily viewers × videos watched × ads per video × CPM, then check the result against Alphabet's reported YouTube ad revenue.
2. **"Should Spotify launch a cheaper India plan?"** Weigh the conversion lift against cannibalisation of existing subscribers. Test in two cities. Guardrail: revenue per user. (Compare the IIMA JioSaavn family-plan case.)
3. **"Design a podcast feature for Spotify."** (IIMA) Pick a segment (commuters in India), a problem (discovery in regional languages), and a metric (weekly podcast listeners).

4. **"How would you stop top streamers leaving Twitch for Kick?"** Tools, discovery, guaranteed deals for the top tier, and community features money cannot buy.
5. **"Is raising YouTube's monetisation bar a good idea?"** It improves quality and advertiser trust, but may slow new creators. Offer a fan-funding path at lower thresholds.
6. **"Moj's growth has stalled. What next?"** Double down on formats where it leads, micro-dramas and live gifting, rather than copying Reels.

Recall: ad-supported media

1. Write the creator-earnings formula and fill it in for 1 lakh views.
2. Why is Spotify's free tier described as a marketing channel?
3. Who captures most of the value in music streaming, and why?
4. What makes Twitch's live chat the core of the product?
5. How did ShareChat reach operating profit after losing the short-video fight?
6. Place YouTube Shorts, Twitch and Kick on the creator-share scale.
7. (OTT) How is JioHotstar's ad model different from YouTube's?

PRODUCT DOSSIER • GAMING

Free to play, paid by a few

Zynga went from FarmVille on Facebook to one of the world's biggest mobile-game publishers. Its story is also the clearest lesson in free-to-play economics: most players never pay, and the business works anyway.

A 38-year-old accountant in Chennai plays Toon Blast on the train home. She has played for two years. She has never spent a rupee, but she watches an ad now and then for an extra five moves. Three seats away, a college student has spent ₹2,400 this month on boosters to beat a hard level before his friends. The game is identical for both of them. Its business depends on keeping the accountant happy and playing, because she makes the game feel alive and fills its ad slots, while the student pays most of the bills.

The job, and how free-to-play works

Casual players hire mobile games for **"a few minutes of satisfying progress when I'm bored or stressed."** Competitive players hire them for **"mastery and beating other people."** A **free-to-play (F2P)** game is free to download and earns from **in-app purchases** (boosters, lives, currency, passes) and **ads** (mostly "rewarded" ads that players choose to watch for a bonus).

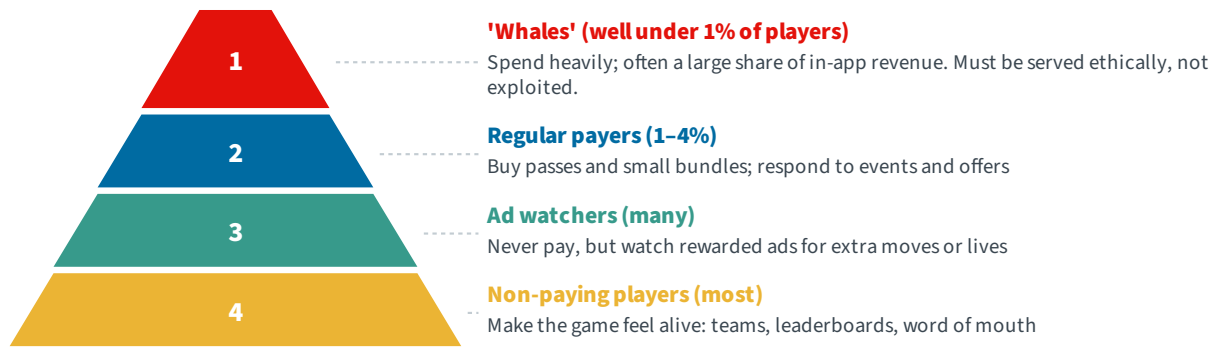
The core loop of a casual puzzle game

Toon Blast, Match Factory and Candy Crush all run a version of this



Who pays in a free-to-play game

A typical value pyramid; shares illustrative



Source: Illustrative; industry rule of thumb that roughly 2-5% of players ever pay in casual mobile games

The whole business rests on one inequality: a player's lifetime value (LTV) must exceed the cost of acquiring them (CPI, cost per install).

The one formula a games PM must know

Does acquiring a new player pay back?

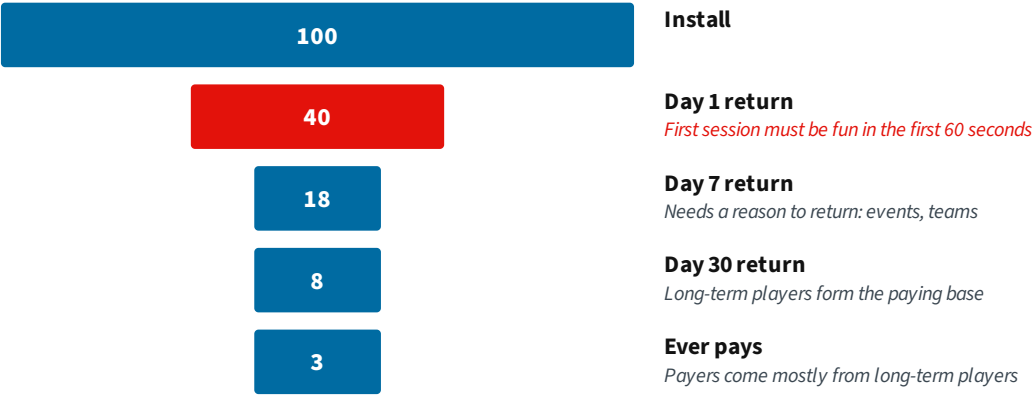
LTV ≈ ARPDau × days active = \$4.80 > CPI \$3.00, so buying players pays back

ARPDau Average revenue per daily active user (IAP + ads) \$0.12	×	Days active per install Sum of retention: D1 × D2 × ... over the player's life 40 days	VS	Cost per install (CPI) Paid marketing cost to get one install \$3.00
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Source: Structure standard in mobile gaming; example values illustrative

Where players drop off

A typical casual game's retention, illustrative

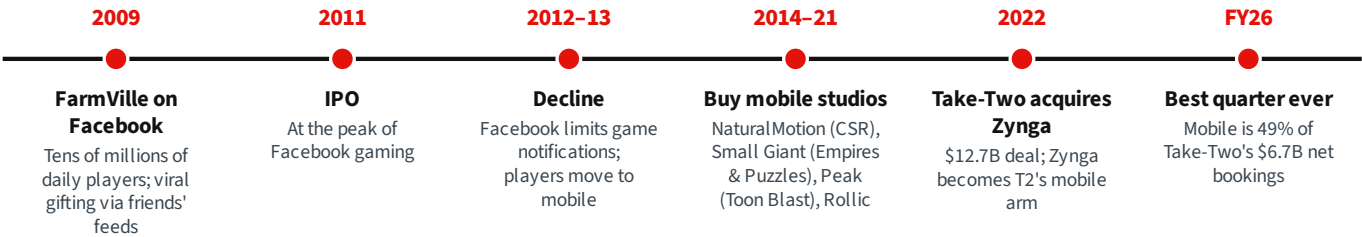


Source: Illustrative benchmarks commonly used for casual mobile games

Zynga: from Facebook virality to mobile portfolio

Who it is for. Casual and mid-core mobile players worldwide: puzzle fans (Toon Blast, Match Factory, Color Block Jam), word-game players (Words With Friends), football-management fans (Top Eleven), racers (CSR Racing). Positioning: "connecting the world through games." It is a **portfolio**: many games, each tuned to a different audience.

Zynga's arc



Source: Company history; Take-Two filings; Mobilegamer.biz (2026)

Lesson 1: borrowed distribution is rented, not owned. FarmVille grew on Facebook's **viral channels**: requests to friends ("send me a cow"), feed posts and notifications. When Facebook cut those channels to protect its users' feeds, Zynga's growth collapsed. The same risk applies today to anyone who depends on one platform's algorithm.

Lesson 2: buy what you cannot build. Zynga missed mobile at first, then acquired studios with proven hits. Hit rates in mobile games are low, so buying successful games often costs less than building many that fail.

Toon Blast level screen, annotated

Every element is tuned for retention and gentle monetisation

1 Clear goal, few moves

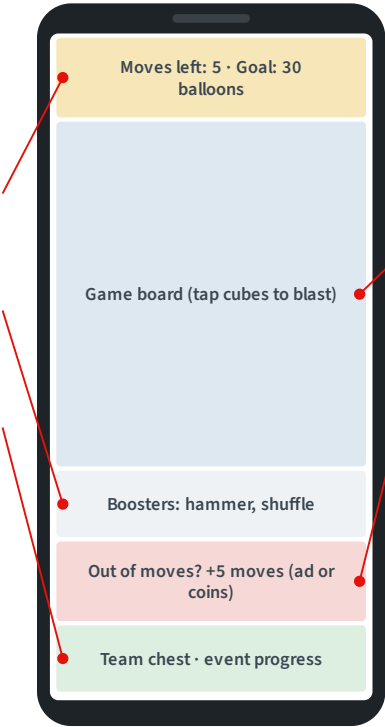
Tension that resolves in 2–3 minutes.
Metric: level completion rate.

3 Boosters

Earned in play or bought; a way to buy progress, not to win outright.

5 Team and events

Social commitment brings players back daily.
Metric: D30 retention.



2 The board

Easy to learn, hard to master. The first levels are designed to be won.

4 The 'near-miss' offer

The moment of highest willingness to pay.
Guardrail: difficulty spikes that feel unfair.

Feature	Player problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Lives that refill over time	Game: "Stop players burning out in one sitting"	Limits play; creates a reason to return later	Sessions per day
Rewarded ads	"I'm stuck but won't pay"	Watch an ad for extra moves	Ad ARPDAU, retention of non-payers
Teams and team chests	"Playing alone gets boring"	Shared goals and help requests	D30 retention
Live events (weekly)	"It feels the same every day"	Limited-time goals and rewards	DAU, spend during events
Season / battle pass	"I want steady rewards for playing"	Pay once; earn rewards by playing	Payer conversion, ARPPU
Direct-to-consumer web store	Studio: "App stores take up to 30%"	Sell currency on the web after rules on app-store payments eased	Margin per purchase

Business model and 2026 results. In fiscal 2026 (to March 2026), Take-Two reported **record net bookings of \$6.7 billion**, with **mobile, mostly Zynga, at \$3.3 billion or 49%**. Toon Blast grew over 25%, Color Block Jam 15% and Empires & Puzzles 5%, while 16-year-old Top Eleven had its best quarter ever. Zynga credited **direct-to-consumer web stores** for rising margins and **generative AI** for cutting the cost of making ad creatives (Mobilegamer.biz). CSR 3 and Top Goal are in soft launch, meaning a limited release in a few countries to test retention and monetisation before a global launch.

Where a \$10 in-game purchase goes

App store versus the studio's own web store; illustrative

Bought inside the app	Bought on the studio's web store
● Store fee Up to \$3.00 to Apple or Google	● Payment fee About \$0.30–0.50
● Studio receives About \$7.00	● Studio receives About \$9.50
● Pros One tap; the easiest purchase	● Pros Higher margin; direct player relationship; bonus to reward the extra step

Moving even a fifth of spending to the web adds several points of margin. That is why every big studio now builds web stores.

Source: Illustrative; standard app-store commission up to 30%; web payment costs typically a few per cent

Moat. Process power in live operations (events, offers and difficulty tuning refined over years), a **portfolio** that spreads hit risk, and **scale in user acquisition** (data on which ads bring profitable players). Games themselves have weak moats: players move to the next hit.

Metrics. *North Star:* DAU of retained players (D30+). *Inputs:* D1/D7/D30 retention, sessions per day, payer conversion, ARPDAU, ad ARPDAU. *Guardrails:* LTV/CPI above 1, complaints about unfair difficulty or spending, and spending by minors.

The India angle

India is the world's largest market for game downloads but one of the lowest-spending per player. In August 2025 Parliament passed the **Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act**, which **banned real-money games** (fantasy sports, rummy, poker played for money) and their advertising and payments, while promoting e-sports and casual games (Law.asia). Dream11, MPL and others had to shut their money games, cut staff and end cricket sponsorships. For PM candidates, the product lesson is **regulatory risk**: an entire category's business model can disappear overnight.

What I would build next at Zynga

1. **India-priced passes and ad-first economy.** *Problem:* Indian players rarely pay dollar-level prices. *Bet:* ₹49 weekly passes via UPI on the web store and more rewarded-ad options. *Metric:* India ARPDAU; payer conversion in India.
2. **AI-generated levels tuned per player.** *Problem:* a single difficulty curve makes some players quit and others bored. *Bet:* generate and choose levels to keep each player's win rate in a target band. *Metric:* D30 retention (guardrail: complaints of manipulation, spending by vulnerable players).

Likely interview questions

1. **"DAU is flat but revenue fell 15%. Diagnose."** Split revenue into IAP and ads, then into payers, conversion and ARPPU. Check for an event ending, price changes, or an app-store policy change.
2. **"Design a new feature for a puzzle game to improve D7 retention."** Teams, daily streaks, a narrative meta. Measure D7 against a holdout group.
3. **"Is it ethical to design near-miss moments?"** Name the trade-off. Suggest guardrails: spending limits, no pay-to-win for minors, transparent odds.
4. **"Should a studio launch globally or soft-launch first?"** Soft launch, to prove retention and LTV/CPI before spending on marketing.
5. **"How would you measure the success of a web store?"** Share of revenue through the web store, margin per purchase, and payer retention. Guardrail: total revenue must not fall because of the extra friction.

Recall: gaming

1. Draw the core loop of a casual puzzle game.
2. What must be true of LTV and CPI for paid user acquisition to make sense?
3. Why can a game in which only 3% of players pay still be profitable?
4. What did Zynga learn when Facebook cut game notifications?
5. Why are direct-to-consumer web stores lifting game margins?
6. What did India's 2025 online gaming law ban, and what does it teach about regulatory risk?
7. (Social) How is a Reels feed's retention loop similar to a puzzle game's?

PRODUCT DOSSIER · ANALYTICS

From "raise a ticket" to "just ask"

ThoughtSpot lets business users search company data like Google. Amplitude shows product teams what users actually do. Both are rebuilding themselves around AI agents that answer questions without anyone writing a query.

Monday, 10 a.m., at a Bengaluru lending start-up. The head of growth wants to know why loan applications fell 12% last week. In 2016 she would have raised a ticket with the data team, waited three days for a SQL query, and received a spreadsheet that raised three new questions. In 2026 she types *"Why did applications drop last week?"* into an analytics tool. Thirty seconds later she has a chart: the drop is entirely on Android, in one app version, at the PAN-verification step. She forwards it to the engineering lead before her coffee is cold.

The job, and the two categories

Business teams hire analytics for **"answer my question about the business now, without waiting for an analyst."** Product teams hire product analytics for **"show me what users do in my product, where they get stuck, and whether my change worked."** These are two different categories. Interviewers like candidates who can tell them apart.

Two kinds of analytics

Business intelligence (ThoughtSpot, Tableau, Power BI)	Product analytics (Amplitude, Mixpanel, PostHog)
● Data Company data in a warehouse: sales, finance, operations	● Data Events: every tap, screen and action in an app
● Typical question Revenue by region this quarter vs last?	● Typical question Where do users drop in onboarding? Did the new button help?
● User Business teams, analysts, executives	● User PMs, growth, designers, engineers

BI answers 'what happened to the business'. Product analytics answers 'what did users do, and why'. AI agents are now blurring the line.

Where analytics tools sit in a company's data stack

From raw data at the bottom to answers at the top

Layer	What it does	Everyday example
AI agents	Ask in plain language; the agent writes queries and explains results	Spotter, Amplitude's Global Agent
Analytics apps	Dashboards, search, funnels, retention, experiments	ThoughtSpot, Amplitude, Tableau
Semantic layer	Shared definitions: what counts as 'active user' or 'revenue'	Stops two teams reporting different numbers
Warehouse	All company data in one place, queried at scale	Snowflake, BigQuery, Databricks
Sources	Apps, payments, CRM, marketing tools	Razorpay payments, app events

The big change of 2025–26 is at the top of that stack. Large language models can now turn a plain-English question into a database query. Anyone can build a demo of that. What cannot be copied quickly is **getting the answer right**: using the company's agreed definitions, respecting who is allowed to see what, and explaining how the number was produced. Both dossiers below are bets on owning that trust layer, and both face rivals who give a "good enough" version away inside tools companies already pay for.

ANALYTICS · THOUGHTSPOT

Search for your company's numbers

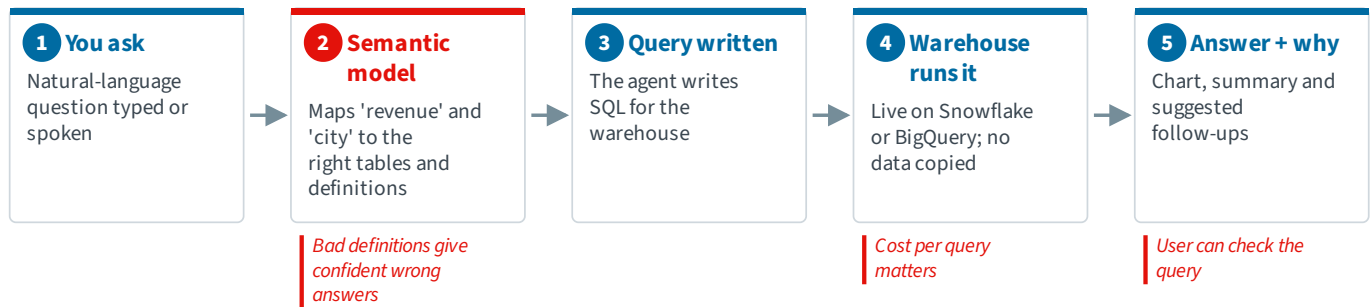
ThoughtSpot's founding idea was a Google-style search bar for company data. Its 2026 version is a team of AI agents that build dashboards and models for you.

Who it is for. Large enterprises whose business users want answers from a cloud data warehouse without learning SQL or waiting for analysts. Also software companies that want to **embed** analytics inside their own products. Founded in 2012, with large engineering teams in India. Positioning: "AI-powered analytics for everyone." It was named a Leader in Gartner's 2026 Magic Quadrant for analytics and BI (ThoughtSpot, Jul 2026).

Core loop. A user asks a question → gets a chart → asks a follow-up ("break it down by city") → saves it to a Liveboard (a live dashboard) → shares it → colleagues start asking their own questions → more users and more queries → more value, so the contract expands.

From a typed question to an answer

What happens when you ask ThoughtSpot 'revenue by city last quarter'



Source: Simplified from ThoughtSpot product documentation

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric it moves
Search and Spotter (AI analyst)	"I can't write SQL"	Ask in plain language; follow up in conversation	Weekly active business users
Liveboards	"Static dashboards go stale"	Live, drillable dashboards on warehouse data	Dashboard views, shares
SpotterModel	Analysts: "Building data models takes weeks"	AI drafts the semantic model	Time to first answer for a new customer

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric it moves
SpotterViz	"Designing dashboards is slow"	Builds a dashboard from a description	Liveboards created
SpotterCode and Embedded	SaaS firms: "Our customers want analytics in our app"	Analytics components developers embed	Embedded revenue
Monitor and alerts	"I find out about drops too late"	Alerts when a KPI moves unusually	Alerts acted on

Business model. Enterprise subscriptions priced by users or consumption, plus embedded licences. ThoughtSpot is private. It was last valued at about **\$4.2 billion in 2021**.

Moat and threats. Its moat is search and semantic technology built over a decade, **live connection** to cloud warehouses (no copying of data), and enterprise customer relationships. The threats are strong: **Microsoft Power BI** comes bundled with Microsoft 365, **Tableau** has Salesforce behind it, **Looker** has Google, and the warehouses themselves (Snowflake, Databricks) now offer AI assistants that answer questions directly. With large language models making "ask in English" easy for everyone, ThoughtSpot's edge has to be **accuracy and trust**: whether the agent is right, and whether it can show how it knows.

Metrics. *North Star*: weekly active users getting answers (questions answered and acted on). *Inputs*: questions per user, share of answers saved or shared, time to first answer for new customers, embedded deployments. *Guardrails*: answer accuracy (checked against analyst-verified queries), warehouse cost per query, customer net retention.

What I would build next at ThoughtSpot

1. **"Show your working" trust panel.** *Problem*: executives don't trust AI answers they can't verify. *Bet*: every answer shows the definition used, the query, and a confidence note, and analysts can certify common questions. *Metric*: share of answers used in decisions; accuracy audits passed.
2. **WhatsApp and Slack answers for field teams.** *Problem*: sales teams in the field never open dashboards. *Bet*: ask Spotter from WhatsApp (via Business API) or Slack and get a chart back. *Metric*: weekly active non-desk users.

ANALYTICS · AMPLITUDE

The product team's microscope

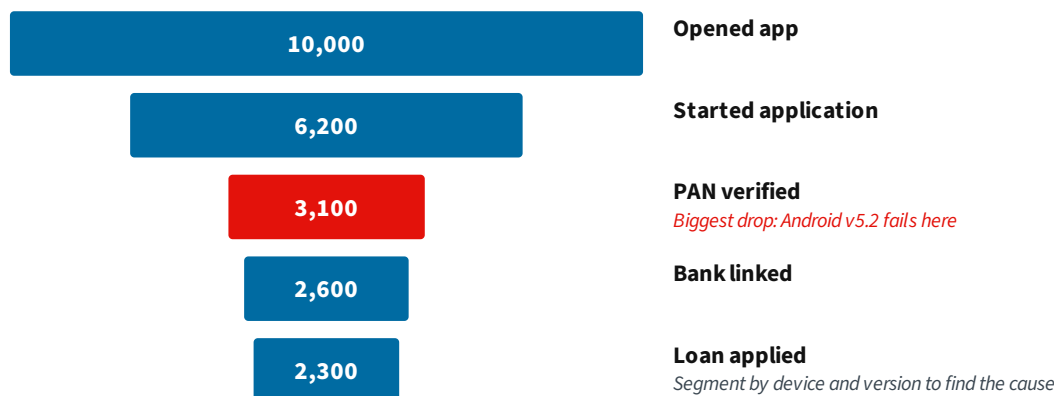
Amplitude turned funnels, retention curves and cohorts into everyday tools for PMs. In 2026 it calls itself an AI analytics company.

Who it is for. Product, growth and marketing teams at digital companies, from start-ups to large enterprises. Positioning: *"the digital analytics platform"*, now expanded to experiments, session replay, surveys and AI agents. It was founded in 2012 and listed in 2021.

Core loop. Instrument the app with events → a PM builds a funnel or retention chart → finds a drop-off → designs a fix → runs an **experiment** in Amplitude → sees the lift → shares it → more teams adopt → more events tracked → the contract grows. This is **land and expand**: start with one team and grow across the company.

The chart that made Amplitude famous: the funnel

A lending app's onboarding, weekly users; illustrative



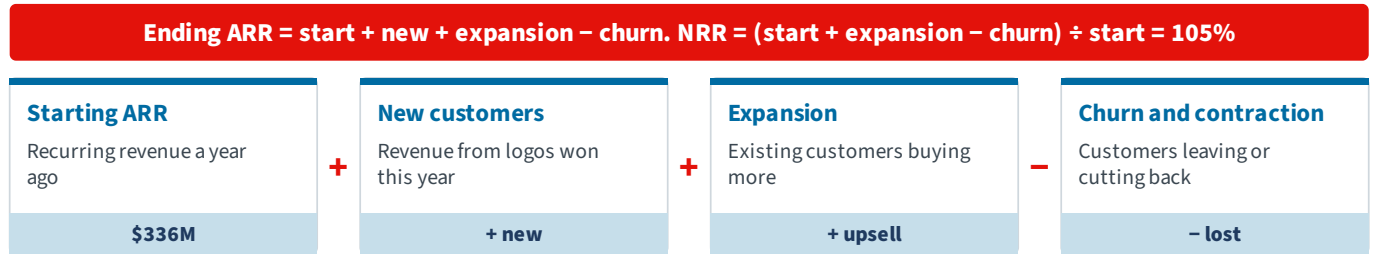
Source: Illustrative example of an Amplitude funnel analysis

Feature	User problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Funnels, retention, cohorts	"Where do users drop? Who comes back?"	Self-serve charts on event data, no SQL	Charts created per PM
Experiment	"Did my change actually work?"	A/B tests with results in the same place as the analytics	Experiments run
Session Replay	"I see the drop but not why"	Watch recordings of real sessions at the drop point	Time to root cause
Guides and Surveys	"Ask users why, inside the app"	In-app messages and surveys tied to behaviour	Response rate
Global Agent, Wave, MCP	"I don't have time to look at every chart"	AI that watches signals and explains changes; connects to Claude and Slack	Insights acted on
Agent Analytics	"How do I measure my AI chatbot?"	Tracks AI agent conversations and outcomes	New AI-product customers

Business model and results. Subscriptions priced by data volume and features. In Q2 2026 revenue reached **\$100.9 million (+21%)**, its first \$100 million quarter, **ARR \$410 million (+22%)**, **824 customers paying over \$100,000 a year (+30%)**, net revenue retention **105%**, and free cash flow of \$23.7 million (Amplitude Q2 2026 release).

How a SaaS company like Amplitude grows

The ARR bridge and net revenue retention (NRR)



Source: Amplitude Q2 2026: ARR \$410M, NRR 105% (trailing twelve months)

An NRR of 105% means that, with no new customers at all, revenue from last year's customers grew 5%. Enterprise SaaS leaders often run at 120% or more. Amplitude's lower figure reflects cost-cutting by software customers after 2022, which is why its AI push matters.

Moat. Switching costs (years of events, charts and definitions; teams trained on it), a strong brand among PMs, and a **data network** that grows with each product added. The threats are cheaper and open-source rivals (PostHog, Mixpanel), warehouse-native analytics, and free Google Analytics.

Metrics. *North Star:* weekly learning users (people who view or create an analysis and act on it). *Inputs:* charts and experiments per account, seats per account, products adopted, AI-agent insights accepted. *Guardrails:* NRR, event-volume cost to customers, data accuracy incidents.

What I would build next at Amplitude

1. **"Launch review" agent.** *Problem:* PMs ship features and forget to check the results. *Bet:* an agent that automatically reviews every launch after 7 and 30 days, compares it with a holdout group, and posts the result to Slack. *Metric:* share of launches with a measured result; expansion revenue.

2. **India starter plan with UPI billing.** *Problem:* Indian start-ups find dollar pricing hard at an early stage. *Bet:* a rupee plan with event limits, paid by UPI Autopay. *Metric:* Indian self-serve sign-ups; conversion to paid.

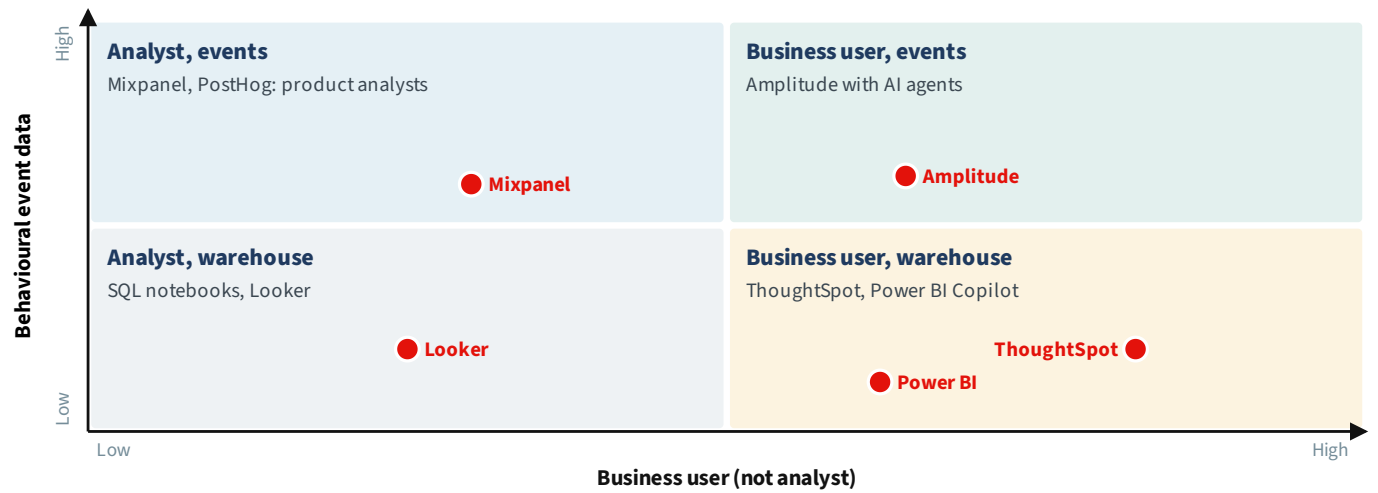
Comparing the two

	ThoughtSpot	Amplitude
Category	Business intelligence, search and agents	Product analytics, experiments
Data	Warehouse tables	App events
Buyer	CIO, data leader	Head of product or growth

	ThoughtSpot	Amplitude
AI bet	Spotter agents: model, visualise, embed	Global Agent, Wave, Agent Analytics
Moat	Search tech, live warehouse connection	Switching costs, PM brand
Main threat	Bundled BI (Power BI), warehouse AI	Open-source and cheaper tools, warehouse-native analytics

Who asks, and what data

Where each tool sits (author's judgement)



Likely interview questions

1. **"You're the PM for ThoughtSpot's AI agent. What's your North Star?"** Questions answered correctly and acted on. The guardrail is accuracy, audited against verified queries.
2. **"How would you sell Amplitude to a CFO?"** Frame it as revenue saved: faster diagnosis of drops, experiments that lift conversion, and fewer analyst hours.
3. **"Low adoption of a CRM or analytics tool inside a company. Diagnose."** (IIMA: low CRM adoption) Look at who was trained, whether the data can be trusted, the time to first value, and the incentives to use it.
4. **"NRR fell from 110% to 105%. What happened?"** Split it into churn, contraction and weaker expansion, by customer segment and product. Tie it to customers' budgets.
5. **"Will LLMs kill BI tools?"** They commoditise the 'ask in English' part. The value moves to trusted definitions (the semantic layer), accuracy, governance and embedding.

Recall: analytics

1. Explain the difference between BI and product analytics with one question each would answer.
2. What is a semantic layer, and why does it matter more once AI writes the queries?
3. Draw a funnel for an app you use and mark where you would look first.
4. Define NRR and interpret Amplitude's 105%.
5. Name two threats to ThoughtSpot and one way it can defend itself.
6. What does "land and expand" mean in B2B SaaS?
7. (Gaming) Which Amplitude charts would a games PM use to track D1, D7 and D30 retention?

PRODUCT DOSSIER · AD TECH

The auction that runs before the page loads

Every free app and website is paid for by an auction that finishes in about a tenth of a second. Google and Meta run the biggest. InMobi and Media.net, both built in India, show how smaller players survive around them.

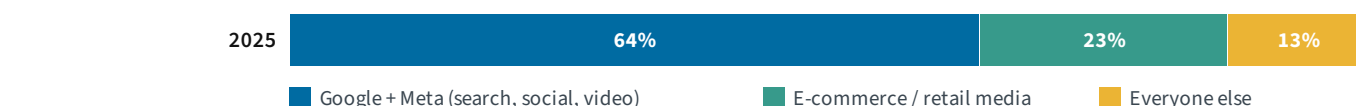
At 9:02 p.m. you search Google for "running shoes under ₹3,000", tap nothing, and go to a cricket news site. The page takes a moment to load. In that pause your browser asked the site's ad server for an ad. The ad server sent a description of the slot, the page and (if allowed) some signals about you to an exchange. Dozens of advertisers' buying systems bid, one won, and a shoe ad appeared next to the match report. The whole process took about **100–200 milliseconds**. It happens billions of times a day, and it pays for most of the free internet.

The job, and the market

Advertisers hire ad tech for "**reach the right people at the right moment, at a price that pays back, and prove it worked.**" Publishers such as news sites, apps and games hire it for "**earn the most per page view or app session without driving readers away.**" Users never hire it, but they have a stake in it: "**keep the internet free, show me relevant ads, don't be creepy.**" Most ad-tech product decisions trade those three interests against each other.

India's digital ad market, 2025

Share of ₹94,700 Cr digital ad spend (+26% YoY)



Retail media (ads on Amazon, Flipkart, Blinkit, Zomato) grew 50% to ₹22,000 Cr. 'Everyone else' includes news sites, OTT, InMobi, ShareChat and others.

Source: FICCI-EY Media & Entertainment report (Mar 2026), via Storyboard18

How the stack works

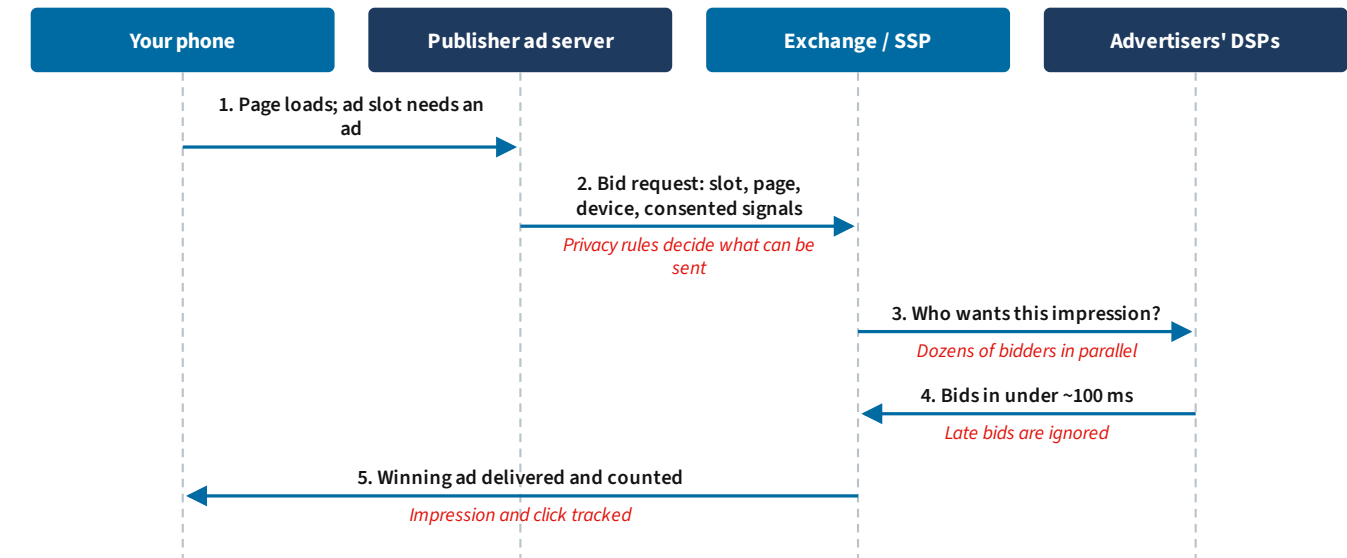
The ad-tech stack, from advertiser to your screen

The open web; walled gardens like Google Search and Meta do all of this inside one company

Layer	What it does	Everyday example
Advertiser and agency	Sets budget, audience, creative and goal (clicks, installs, sales)	A shoe brand and its media agency
DSP (demand-side platform)	Software that bids for the advertiser in real time	Google DV360, The Trade Desk, InMobi DSP
Ad exchange	Marketplace where bids meet ad slots; runs the auction	Google AdX, others
SSP (supply-side platform)	Software that sells a publisher's slots to many exchanges and buyers	InMobi Exchange, Media.net, PubMatic
Publisher ad server	Decides which ad fills each slot, including direct deals	Google Ad Manager (DFP)
Publisher and user	The app or site you use; the ad appears here	A cricket news site

One real-time bidding auction

About 100–200 ms from page load to ad on screen



Source: Simplified OpenRTB flow

Walled gardens versus the open web

Walled gardens (Google Search, YouTube, Meta, Amazon)	Open web (programmatic)
● Data Logged-in users; first-party data on intent, interests and purchases	● Data Thin signals; depends on cookies, device IDs, context
● Stack Buying, auction, serving and measurement all in-house	● Stack Many companies in the chain, each taking a fee
● Advertiser view Easy, effective, but hard to verify independently	● Advertiser view More choice and transparency, but more waste and fraud

Privacy changes (Apple's 2021 tracking prompt, India's DPDP Act) weakened open-web targeting and strengthened walled gardens and contextual ads.

AD TECH · GOOGLE

The intent machine

Google's ads work because people tell it what they want. Its search auction is the most studied pricing system in product management.

Who it is for. Advertisers of every size, from a Jaipur dentist to Unilever. Publishers use AdSense and Google Ad Manager to sell their space. Positioning: "be there when customers are looking." Search ads grew **17%** in Q2 2026 and YouTube ads 13%, and **AI Mode** in Search passed 1 billion monthly users (Alphabet Q2 2026).

The search auction. Google does not simply sell the top spot to the highest bidder. Each ad gets an **Ad Rank** $\approx \text{bid} \times \text{quality}$ (quality means expected click-through, relevance and landing-page experience). The winner pays only enough to beat the next ad's rank. Better ads therefore pay less, which keeps results useful and users clicking.

Why the highest bid doesn't always win

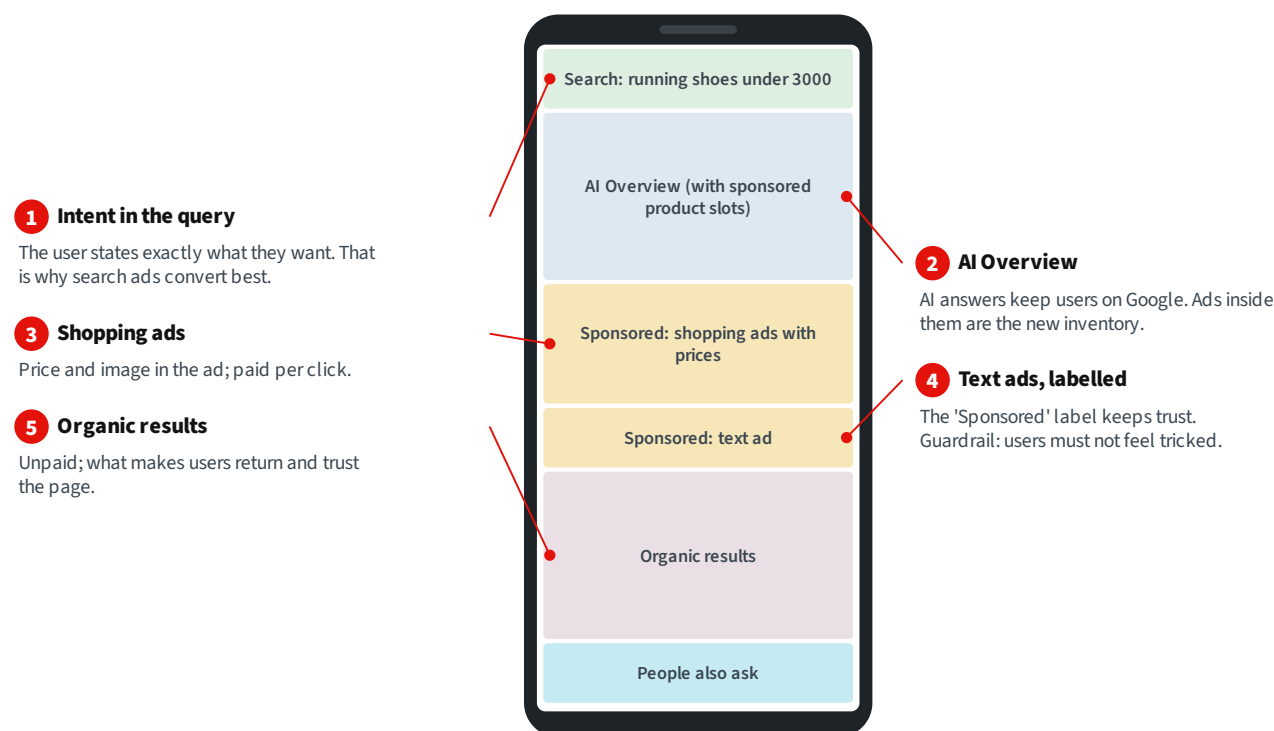
Two advertisers bidding for 'running shoes under 3000'; simplified

B wins the top slot and pays about ₹25, half of A's bid, because its ad is more useful		
Brand A Bid ₹50 × quality 4 Ad Rank 200	VS	Brand B Bid ₹30 × quality 8 Ad Rank 240: wins
	→	B's price per click Next rank ÷ own quality + ₹0.01 = 200 ÷ 8 ≈ ₹25

Source: Simplified Google Ads auction logic; values illustrative

A Google results page in 2026, annotated

Ads, AI answers and organic results compete for the same screen



The publisher side, and the 2026 ruling. Google also runs the most used **publisher ad server** (Google Ad Manager, formerly DFP) and the largest **exchange** (AdX). In April 2025 a US court ruled that Google had illegally monopolised these markets. On **16 September 2026** Judge Brinkema's remedies were unsealed. Google **does not have to sell AdX**, but must make AdX and DFP work with the open-source **Prebid** system, send AdX bids to rival ad servers on the same terms, share bid data with publishers, stop favouring its own tools, and accept a technical monitor for six years (AdExchanger, Sep 2026).

Moat. **Intent data** from search is a cornered resource. **Scale** on both sides of the market. **Switching costs** for advertisers whose campaigns, data and skills are built on Google Ads. The risk is that AI assistants answer questions directly, which changes where ads appear and how many clicks there are.

Metrics. *North Star:* advertiser value delivered (conversions at target cost). *Inputs:* queries with commercial intent, ad click-through rate, conversion rate, advertisers active. *Guardrails:* user satisfaction with results, ad load per query, invalid-click rate.

AD TECH · META

The prediction machine

Meta cannot see what you search for. It predicts what you will buy from what you do, and it has become the best system in the world at doing that.

Who it is for. Advertisers who want to create demand, not just capture it: D2C brands, app developers, small businesses. Positioning: "find your customers, wherever they are across our apps." Meta's **Q2 2026 revenue was \$60.8 billion (+28%)**, with ad impressions

up 14% and price per ad up 12% (Meta).

How the auction differs. Meta's auction ranks ads by **total value** $\approx \text{bid} \times \text{estimated action rate} + \text{ad quality}$. The "estimated action rate" is Meta's prediction that *this* person will click, install or buy. The better Meta predicts, the more each impression is worth to advertisers, and the more Meta earns without showing more ads.

Product	Advertiser problem	Why designed this way	Metric
Advantage+ campaigns	"I don't know whom to target"	AI chooses audience, placement and budget	\$75B annual run rate (Meta)
AI creative tools	"I can't make 20 ad versions"	Generates images, video and text variants	9M small businesses using them
Click-to-WhatsApp ads	"Indian customers want to chat first"	Ad opens a WhatsApp chat with the business	Conversations started
Reels ads	"Attention moved to short video"	Full-screen ads between Reels	Reels ad revenue
Conversions API	"Apple's tracking prompt hid my results"	Sends conversion data server-to-server with consent	Measured conversions

The privacy shock and the answer. When Apple introduced **App Tracking Transparency** in 2021, most users declined tracking, and Meta said the change would cost it about \$10 billion in 2022. Meta's response was to invest in **AI that predicts from less data**. It now reports that new AI ranking models raised ad conversions by up to 15.7% on Facebook (Meta Q2 2026). The lesson for product managers: *when a key input disappears, the company with the best models recovers first*.

Moat. Scale of engagement data across 3.6 billion daily people, AI infrastructure (capex of \$130–145 billion in 2026), and millions of small advertisers who have learned its tools. Risks: regulation (EU, India's DPDP Act), teen-safety concerns, and dependence on Apple and Google platforms.

Metrics. *North Star:* advertiser conversions at target cost. *Inputs:* impressions, conversion rate, advertisers using Advantage+, creative variants per campaign. *Guardrails:* ad load and user sentiment, policy-violating ads, and scam ads.

AD TECH · INMOBI

India's first unicorn, on the lock screen

InMobi built a mobile ad network from Bengaluru in 2007, then bet on Glance, content on the phone's lock screen. In 2025 its founders bought back control ahead of an Indian listing.

Who it is for. On the buy side, app developers and brands wanting mobile reach, especially in Asia. On the sell side, app publishers selling their ad slots through InMobi's exchange. Positioning: *"mobile-first advertising and discovery."*

What it runs. (1) **InMobi Advertising:** a DSP for advertisers and an exchange/SSP for app publishers, focused on in-app ads. (2) **Glance:** a lock-screen content service pre-installed through deals with Android phone makers, which shows news, games and shopping cards when you wake your phone. It also owns the short-video app **Roposo**.

Why Glance is interesting, and controversial. The lock screen is the most-viewed screen on any phone, dozens of times a day. Owning it gives huge reach without users downloading anything, which is a **distribution** advantage. But because it comes pre-installed and users did not choose it, it draws complaints about intrusiveness. The guardrail is **opt-out rates and user complaints**, not only views.

Business. InMobi is private. Estimates put its annual revenue at roughly **\$600–700 million**. In 2025 it bought back SoftBank's stake for about **\$250 million**, financed with debt, leaving its founders with majority control ahead of a planned Indian IPO (IPO Central, 2025).

Moat. Relationships with Android phone makers (a cornered distribution channel), in-app data at scale in emerging markets, and a full stack (DSP + SSP). Its weaknesses: dependence on phone makers' deals, and competition from Google's and Meta's own app-install ads.

What I would build next at InMobi / Glance

User-controlled lock screen. *Problem:* users feel Glance was pushed on them. *Bet:* a first-boot choice of topics (cricket, recipes, jobs) with one-tap off. *Metric:* 30-day retention of users who opted in, and revenue per opted-in user (which should rise as it becomes more relevant).

AD TECH · MEDIA.NET

Ads that read the page, not the person

Media.net, built in Mumbai and Dubai, runs the contextual ads behind the Yahoo and Bing network. As tracking gets harder, its old-fashioned idea is back in fashion.

Who it is for. Publishers such as news sites, blogs and reference sites that want revenue from ads matched to their content. Advertisers reach them through Microsoft's and Yahoo's search advertising. Media.net was founded by Divyank Turakhia in 2010 and sold to a Chinese consortium (Miteno) in 2016 for about **\$900 million** (TechCrunch).

How contextual advertising works. Instead of tracking *who* you are, the system reads *what the page is about*. An article on marathon training shows ads, or "related searches" links, for running shoes. When a reader clicks, Media.net and the publisher share the advertiser's payment. It is essentially **search advertising placed on content pages**.

Behavioural versus contextual targeting

Behavioural (tracking-based)	Contextual (content-based)
Signal Your browsing history, app use, purchases	Signal The words and topic of the page you're reading
Strength Precise; follows you across sites	Strength Privacy-safe; works without personal data
Weakness Needs cookies or IDs; privacy laws and Apple limit it	Weakness Less precise; depends on content quality

Contextual targeting was old-fashioned in 2015. After Apple's ATT, the EU's GDPR and India's DPDP Act, it is a growth market again.

Moat. Its long-standing position running the **Yahoo! Bing Network Contextual Ads** programme, a large engineering team in India, and semantic technology that understands page content. The risk is dependence on one demand partner, plus publishers' traffic falling as AI answers reduce clicks to websites.

What I would build next at Media.net

Contextual ads for AI answers. *Problem:* AI chat answers are becoming a new kind of "page", and they have no ad model beyond the big platforms. *Bet:* a contextual ad unit that AI apps and publishers can place next to generated answers, matched to the topic and not the person. *Metric:* publisher revenue per 1,000 AI answers; user complaints (guardrail).

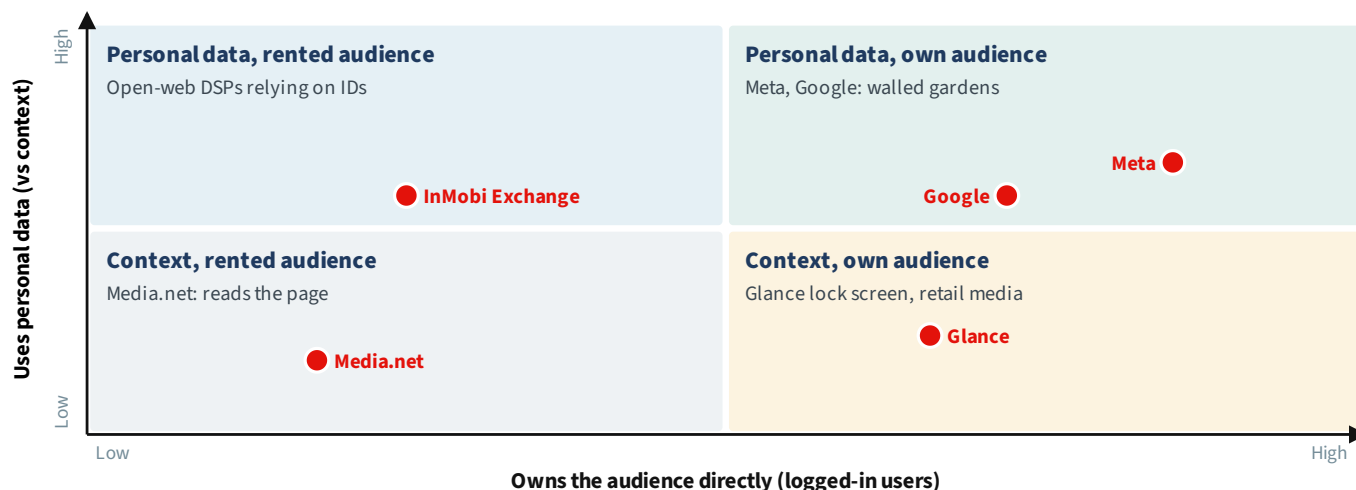
Comparing the four

	Google	Meta	InMobi	Media.net
Core signal	Search intent	Predicted interest from behaviour	In-app and lock-screen context	Page content
Position	Walled garden + open-web stack	Walled garden	Open-web mobile (DSP + SSP) + Glance	Contextual network, publisher side
Main product	Search, YouTube, Ad Manager, AdX	Advantage+, Reels, click-to-WhatsApp	InMobi Exchange, Glance	Contextual ads, related searches

	Google	Meta	InMobi	Media.net
Moat	Intent data, scale	Engagement data, AI	Phone-maker distribution	Demand partnership, semantic tech
Main risk	Antitrust, AI answers	Privacy, regulation	Intrusiveness, OEM deals	Partner dependence, falling clicks

Where each player gets its targeting signal

Author's judgement



Likely interview questions

1. **"Explain real-time bidding to a non-technical person."** An auction for every ad slot, finished in the time a page takes to load. Name the buyer (DSP), the seller (SSP) and the marketplace (exchange).
2. **"Why does Google charge the winner less than its bid?"** Ad Rank combines bid and quality, and the winner pays just enough to beat the next rank. This rewards useful ads and keeps users clicking.
3. **"Meta's ad revenue per user in India is a fraction of the US. How would you raise it?"** Click-to-WhatsApp ads for small businesses, UPI-linked conversions, regional creatives, and better measurement.
4. **"Design metrics for a new ad format in AI answers."** Advertiser conversions, user satisfaction with answers, and ad load per answer. Guardrail: trust in the answer.
5. **"Apple blocks tracking. You're a PM at a mobile ad network. What do you do?"** Contextual signals, first-party data partnerships with consent, on-device modelling, and measurement based on aggregate data.
6. **"What changes for publishers after the 2026 Google ad-tech ruling?"** Easier use of rival ad servers and Prebid with AdX demand, more transparency on bids. Watch whether publisher revenue per 1,000 views rises.

Recall: ad tech

1. Name the parts of the open-web ad-tech stack in order, with one example each.
2. Walk through an RTB auction in five steps.
3. Compute the price paid: Brand X bids ₹40 with quality 5; Brand Y bids ₹25 with quality 10. Who wins and what do they pay?
4. How did Meta respond to Apple's App Tracking Transparency?
5. What is contextual advertising, and why is it growing again?
6. What did the September 2026 Google ad-tech remedies require, and what did they not require?
7. (Messaging) How do click-to-WhatsApp ads link Meta's ad business to WhatsApp's revenue?

INDEX

Every case in this book

#	Case	Type	Page
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